

Official Report of the
One Hundred Fifty-fifth
Annual General

CONFERENCE

of The Church of Jesus Christ
of Latter-day Saints

held in the Tabernacle
Salt Lake City, Utah

April 6 and 7, 1985

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THE ONE HUNDRED FIFTY-FIFTH ANNUAL GENERAL CONFERENCE OF THE CHURCH OF JESUS CHRIST OF LATTER-DAY SAINTS

The 155th Annual General Conference of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints convened in the Tabernacle on Temple Square in Salt Lake City, Utah, on Saturday, April 6, 1985, at 10:00 A.M.

The general sessions of the conference were held at 10:00 A.M. and 2:00 P.M. on Saturday and Sunday, April 6 and 7, 1985. The general priesthood meeting was held in the Tabernacle on Saturday, April 6, 1985 at 6:00 P.M.

President Spencer W. Kimball attended and presided at the four general sessions of the conference and watched the general priesthood session on television in his apartment in the Hotel Utah. President Marion G. Romney, First Counselor in the First Presidency, attended one session and watched the other sessions on television in his home because of ill health. President Gordon B. Hinckley, Second Counselor in the First Presidency, conducted the Saturday morning, general priesthood, and Sunday morning sessions. President Ezra Taft Benson, President of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, conducted the Saturday afternoon and Sunday afternoon sessions.

Television and radio stations carried portions or all of some of the conference sessions to large audiences throughout the world. In addition, the general sessions and the priesthood session were carried via satellite transmission to more than 750 stake centers. The general priesthood session was also carried by closed-circuit transmission to approximately 892 locations in many countries.

General Authorities present

The following General Authorities of the Church attended one or more of the general sessions:

The First Presidency: Spencer W. Kimball, Marion G. Romney, and Gordon B. Hinckley.

The Council of the Twelve: Ezra Taft Benson, Howard W. Hunter, Thomas S. Monson, Boyd K. Packer, Marvin J. Ashton, Bruce R. McConkie, L. Tom Perry, David B. Haight, James E. Faust, Neal A. Maxwell, Russell M. Nelson, and Dallin H. Oaks.

The First Quorum of the Seventy:
Presidents: J. Thomas Fyans, Carlos E. Asay, M. Russell Ballard, Dean L. Larsen, Richard G. Scott, Marion D. Hanks, and Wm. Grant Bangerter. *Additional Members of the Seventy:* A. Theodore Tuttle, Franklin D. Richards, Theodore M. Burton,¹ Hartman Rector, Jr., Loren C. Dunn, Robert L. Simpson, Rex D. Pinegar, Adney Y. Komatsu, Joseph B. Wirthlin, Gene R. Cook, Charles Didier, William R. Bradford, George P. Lee, John H. Groberg, Jacob de Jager, Vaughn J. Featherstone, Royden G. Derrick, Robert E. Wells, James M. Paramore, Hugh W. Pinnock, F. Enzio Busche, Yoshihiko Kikuchi, Ronald E. Poelman, Derek A. Cuthbert, Robert L. Backman, Rex C. Reeve, Sr., F. Burton Howard, Ted E. Brewerton, Jack H. Goaslind, Jr., Angel Abrea, John K. Carmack, Russell C. Taylor, Robert B. Harbertson, Devere Harris, Spencer H. Osborn, Philip T. Sonntag, John Sonnenberg, F. Arthur Kay, Keith W. Wilcox, Victor L. Brown, H. Burke Peterson, J. Richard Clarke, Hans B. Ringger, Waldo P. Call, and Helio da Rocha Camargo.

The Presiding Bishopric: Robert D. Hales, Henry B. Eyring, and Glenn L. Pace.

Emeritus General Authorities: Eldred G. Smith, Sterling W. Sill,

¹Paul H. Dunn was hospitalized and was not in attendance at any of the conference meetings.

Henry D. Taylor, Bernard P. Brockbank, James A. Cullimore, Joseph Anderson, John H. Vandenberg, and O. Leslie Stone.

Other authorities present

Other authorities of the Church in attendance included Regional Repre-

sentatives, presidents of missions, presidents of stakes and their counselors, presidents of temples, bishops of wards, and presidencies and members of the Aaronic and Melchizedek priesthood quorums.

Many general, stake, and ward auxiliary officers also attended.

FIRST DAY MORNING MEETING

FIRST SESSION

The first general session of the 155th Annual General Conference convened in the Tabernacle on Temple Square in Salt Lake City, Utah, on Saturday, April 6, 1985, at 10:00 A.M. President Gordon B. Hinckley, Second Counselor in the First Presidency, conducted this session.

The music for the opening session was provided by the Tabernacle Choir with Jerold Ottley and Donald Ripplinger conducting and Robert Cundick at the organ.

Prior to the meeting the Tabernacle Choir sang "Jehovah, Lord of Heaven and Earth" without announcement.

President Hinckley made the following remarks:

President Gordon B. Hinckley

My beloved brethren and sisters, we greet you in general conference, on this beautiful morning in the valley of the mountains, at this glorious Easter season. We are convened in the Tabernacle on Temple Square in Salt Lake City in this, the first general session of the 155th Annual General Conference of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-

day Saints. President Spencer W. Kimball, President of the Church, is seated on the stand, and we are delighted to have him with us this beautiful morning.

We welcome all who are participating in the conference, whether seated here in the Tabernacle or in the overflow session in the nearby Assembly Hall where Elders J. Thomas Fyans and Rex D. Pinegar preside, or who are participating by satellite transmission, radio, cable, or television. These proceedings are being carried to over seven hundred and fifty stake centers throughout the United States, Canada, and Puerto Rico, to which the conference is being carried by satellite transmission.

We acknowledge the General Authorities of the Church, the Relief Society, Young Women, and Primary general presidencies, and the Activities Committee, who are seated on the stand. We extend a special welcome to government, education, and civic leaders who are present.

The Tabernacle Choir under the direction of Jerold Ottley and Donald Ripplinger with Robert Cundick at the organ is providing the music for this session.

The choir opened this session by singing "Jehovah, Lord of Heaven and Earth," and they will now sing "How Gentle God's Commands." Following the singing, the invocation will be offered by Elder A. Theodore Tuttle, a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

The choir sang "How Gentle God's Commands."

Elder A. Theodore Tuttle offered the invocation.

President Gordon B. Hinckley spoke without announcement.

President Gordon B. Hinckley

My brethren and sisters, my heart reaches out to you, wherever you are, with a great overflowing spirit of gratitude. This vast congregation spans the continents of the world as we are assembled in this great general conference.

President Kimball—a long season

We are so delighted to have President Spencer W. Kimball with us this morning. He recently celebrated his ninetieth birthday. While he is unable to speak to us, his very presence stirs within each of us a great sense of appreciation to the Lord, who has spared his life during these four score and ten years. That is a long season for the life of a man in this generation. He is here because of the manifest power of the Lord. I assure you that we speak with him frequently and that no action for which there is not a well-established pattern is taken without his approval. He customarily meets with us in the weekly temple meetings of the First Presidency and the Council of the Twelve. His presence is a blessing and an inspiration to all of us. Unitedly we invoke the favor of the Lord upon him that he may be preserved in comfort and ease.

We regret the absence of President [Marion G.] Romney, who suffers from the problems of illness and age. We anticipate that he will be with us during at least one of the sessions of this conference.

We remember with sincere appreciation our able and beloved associate and friend, Elder G. Homer Durham of the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy, who passed away last January.

Release of Presiding Bishopric

The Church moves forward with remarkable unity and strength. The burdens of responsibility are many and serious, but they are lightened by the absolute certainty that this is God's work, that he is watching over it and directing it. It is our prayer that constantly he will give his direction, that we shall be sensitive to the promptings of the Holy Spirit at all times and in all circumstances, that his will may be done in earth as it is in heaven.

The burdens of responsibility are also lightened by the demonstrated unity among the brethren and sisters, among all of the General Authorities who are united in a remarkable and wonderful way, among officers and boards of the auxiliary organizations, among local officers worldwide, and with relatively few exceptions, among the membership. I appreciate more than I can express in language your prayers, your letters of assurance, the sustaining power of your lives and faith, and your willing response to every request made upon you.

The Presiding Bishopric, particularly, have carried an extremely heavy burden since Bishop Victor L. Brown came into the Bishopric twenty-four

years ago. He was named Presiding Bishop and Bishop Peterson became his Counselor thirteen years ago. Bishop Clarke is in his ninth year of service. Never before in the history of the Church have so many new buildings been constructed: meetinghouses, temples, and other significant structures, such as the new Church museum and the new Genealogy Building. With the work moving forward in more than ninety nations, these Brethren, who have had responsibility for all of these and many other activities, have been under taxing administrative obligations and the most rigorous schedules of travel in overseeing these vast and widely scattered programs. I cannot say enough of good for what they have accomplished. They have earned a change from the burdens they have carried so well for so long.

With great appreciation for all that they have done and with our sincere love and our blessing, we extend honorable releases to Bishop Victor L. Brown as the Presiding Bishop of the Church, to his First Counselor, Bishop H. Burke Peterson, and to Bishop J. Richard Clarke, his Second Counselor. All who wish to join in an expression of appreciation to these devoted and able Brethren may do so by the uplifted hand.

Sustaining of General Authorities and general officers

I shall now present to you the General Authorities and general officers of the Church for your sustaining vote.

It is proposed that we sustain President Spencer W. Kimball as prophet, seer, and revelator and President of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. All in favor, please manifest it. Any opposed, by the same sign.

Marion G. Romney as First Counselor in the First Presidency, and Gordon B. Hinckley as Second Counselor in the First Presidency. All in favor, please signify it. Contrary, if there be any, by the same sign.

It is proposed that we sustain as President of the Council of the Twelve, Elder Ezra Taft Benson. All in favor, please manifest it. Those opposed, by the same sign.

As the Council of the Twelve Apostles: Ezra Taft Benson, Howard W. Hunter, Thomas S. Monson, Boyd K. Packer, Marvin J. Ashton, Bruce R. McConkie, L. Tom Perry, David B. Haight, James E. Faust, Neal A. Maxwell, Russell M. Nelson, and Dallin H. Oaks.

It is proposed that we sustain the Counselors in the First Presidency and the Twelve Apostles as prophets, seers, and revelators. All in favor, please manifest it. Contrary, if there be any, by the same sign.

As the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy: J. Thomas Fyans, Carlos E. Asay, M. Russell Ballard, Dean L. Larsen, Richard G. Scott, Marion D. Hanks, and Wm. Grant Bangerter. As new members of the First Quorum of the Seventy to serve on a lifetime basis: Victor L. Brown, H. Burke Peterson, and J. Richard Clarke; and, additionally, Hans B. Ringger, Waldo Pratt Call, Sr., and Helio da Rocha Camargo to serve as new members of this quorum on the rotation basis we announced a year ago. All other members of the First Quorum of the Seventy and the emeritus Brethren as at present constituted. All in favor, please manifest it. Contrary, if there be any, by the same sign.

It is proposed that we sustain Robert D. Hales as Presiding Bishop, with Henry Bennion Eyring as First Counselor and Glenn Leroy Pace as Second Counselor. Simultaneously, we release Elder Hales as a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy with our appreciation. All in favor. Any opposed.

It is proposed that we sustain Dean L. Larsen as Church Historian and Recorder. All in favor of this proposition. Any opposed.

For your information, Elder Ringger is a native of Switzerland. He has served long and faithfully in the

Church in many capacities, including those of stake president and Regional Representative. Elder Call is a native of Mexico and has served as president of the Juarez Mexico Stake. He presently serves as president of the Uruguay Montevideo Mission. Elder Camargo is from Brazil, where at various times he has served as stake president, mission president, and Regional Representative.

Also for your information, in harmony with the principle we have followed of calling some members of the First Quorum of the Seventy to serve as temple presidents and as mission presidents, Elder Victor L. Brown has been called to serve as president of the Salt Lake Temple—his appointment will become effective June 1; Elder Peterson to serve as president of the Jordan River Temple—his appointment to be effective at the same time; and Elder Clarke to serve as president of the South Africa Capetown Mission, a place and a work he has loved ever since serving as a missionary in that land.

By way of announcement we desire to inform you of decisions of area administration. In three international areas, for over eight months, we have tested the concept of having Area Presidencies living on site. This has been done in Europe, in the southern part of South America, and in the Pacific Islands, and has proved highly desirable. We now announce that effective

July 1 three more Area Presidencies will be put in place—one to reside in Brazil, to serve Brazil and the northern portions of South America; another in Mexico, to serve Mexico and Central America; and another will reside perhaps in Japan to serve the Far East—so that beginning in July we will have six Area Presidencies presiding in the international areas. Additionally, we wish to confirm that seven Presidencies will have responsibility over Areas in the United States and Canada. We thank these Brethren and their families for their willingness to go wherever they are asked to go.

With the exceptions noted, there have been no changes within the General Authorities or the general officers of the Church since the last conference. It is proposed, therefore, that we sustain all of the General Authorities and general officers of the Church as at present constituted. All in favor, manifest it. Any who may feel otherwise, may so manifest it.

It appears that the voting has been unanimous in favor in each instance. We thank you for your sustaining vote and for your undeviating support.

President Hinckley

We shall now be pleased to hear from President Ezra Taft Benson, President of the Council of the Twelve Apostles.

President Ezra Taft Benson

Our mission—to preach the gospel

My beloved brethren and sisters, we have called a conference of mission presidents from all over the world. We have met with these wonderful men and their wives earlier this week, and they have received instruction and counsel. I therefore feel that I should like to say

a few words about our missionary responsibility as members of the Church.

Our mission as a church is to preach the gospel to all the world. That means, in due time, every country, nationality, and people. In a letter to Mr. John Wentworth in March 1842, Joseph Smith prophesied: "No unhalloved hand can stop the work from progressing; . . . the truth of God will

go forth boldly, nobly, and independent, till it has penetrated *every* continent, visited *every* clime, swept *every* country, and sounded in *every* ear, till the purposes of God shall be accomplished, and the Great Jehovah shall say the work is done" (*History of the Church*, 4:540; italics added).

Much is required

To appreciate the accelerated progress that the Church has made in the last few decades, consider that it took 117 years for the Church to reach its first million members (1947); 16 years to reach its second million (1963); and 9 years its third million (1972). But during President Kimball's administration as President of the Church, over two million people were added.

Yet there is much to do before the work of God can be pronounced completed. Hearts of leaders of nations must be softened, doors of nations opened, false ideologies overcome, and the gospel presented to all our Heavenly Father's children.

As members of the Lord's Church, we must take missionary work more seriously. The Lord's commission to "preach the gospel to every creature" (Mark 16:15) will never change in our dispensation. We have been greatly blessed with the material means, the technology, and an inspired message to bring the gospel to all men. More is expected of us than any previous generation. Where "much is given much is required" (D&C 82:3).

Permit me to suggest some of the ways you can participate in this glorious endeavor to bring the gospel to all mankind.

Live the principles of the gospel

First, *you can live the principles of the gospel.*

The Lord expects this of us. The Apostle Paul commended, "Be thou an example of the believers, in word, in

conversation, in charity, in spirit, in faith, in purity" (1 Timothy 4:12).

We are grateful that members of the Church for the most part are striving to live the gospel and dealing justly with our fellowman. But are we not all saddened and disappointed when Church members are found guilty of taking advantage of others through business transactions or are judged guilty of breaking the laws of God and man? As Church members, blessed with the truths of the gospel, the Lord expects us to be honest, morally clean, chaste, free from profanity and vulgarity, trustworthy, and exemplary in all our conduct.

The Lord said to Church members of this dispensation:

"But inasmuch as they keep not my commandments, and hearken not to observe all my words, the kingdoms of the world shall prevail against them.

"For they were set to be a light unto the world, and to be the saviors of men;

"And inasmuch as they are not the saviors of men, they are as salt that has lost its savor, and is thenceforth good for nothing but to be cast out and trodden under foot of men" (D&C 103:8-10).

One of our best missionary tools is the sterling examples of members who live the gospel. This is what the Lord meant when He said to the Church, "Zion must increase in beauty, and in holiness; . . . Zion must . . . put on her beautiful garments" (D&C 82:14).

Prepare sons for missions

Second, *we can prepare our sons to serve missions.*

President Kimball was once asked, "How many missionaries do you expect? How many do you need?" His answer: "All of them" (Regional Representatives' seminar, 3 Apr. 1975).

"I am asking," said he, "for missionaries who have been carefully indoctrinated and trained through the family and the organizations of the

Church, and who come to the mission with a great desire.

"I am asking," he further stated, "that we start earlier and train our missionaries better" (Regional Representatives' seminar, 4 Apr. 1974).

When do we begin such preparation? Our prophet said we should "start at the birth of a male child and begin to put away money and help him save for his mission so that at 19 years when he is of age, he is prepared and ready for his mission. Every boy should have saved much toward his mission" (Regional Representatives' seminar, 3 Oct. 1974).

How do you build in boys a great desire to serve? You do not wait until they are nineteen years old to help them decide to serve a mission. You help them decide to go when they are nine, ten, or eleven! The home is the seedbed for the preparation of young men. And every young man should be prepared in his home to serve.

Early preparation consists of teaching a young boy how to pray, reading him stories from the Book of Mormon and other scriptures, having home evenings and giving him a portion of the lesson, teaching him principles of moral cleanliness, starting a savings account for his future mission, teaching him how to work, and providing opportunities to serve others.

I know of families who always prayed in family prayer that their sons would be worthy to serve missions. This, they say, had a great effect on their sons.

For our teenage young men and women, one of the best preparations for a mission is provided by the Church through seminary and institute of religion classes. We hope you will urge your children to take part in this inspired program.

Financially support missionary program

Third, *we can financially support the missionary program.*

Let me explain to you the challenge we face in the Church. Many of our worthy young men who desire to serve missions are in other countries of the world. Most of these elders and sisters do not have the resources to support themselves for two years on a mission and therefore must receive supplementary assistance. We have a General Missionary Fund in the Church to which we ask all members to contribute. Those who have received bounteously from the Lord can afford to give generously to support this program. Most adult members could contribute some each month and, by doing so, help prosper the missionary efforts throughout the world.

Introduce friends and neighbors to missionaries

Fourth, *we can introduce our friends and neighbors to the missionaries.*

On January 2, 1831, the Lord said: "And again, I say unto you, I give unto you a commandment, that every man, both elder, priest, teacher, and also member, go to with his might, with the labor of his hands, to prepare and accomplish the things which I have commanded.

"And let your preaching be the warning voice, every man to his neighbor, in mildness and meekness" (D&C 38:40-41).

Also, on December 27, 1832, the Lord commanded:

"Behold, I sent you out to testify and warn the people, and it becometh every man who hath been warned to warn his neighbor.

"Therefore, they are left without excuse, and their sins are upon their own heads" (D&C 88:81-82).

Our living prophet today has told us how this work is best accomplished:

"We must . . . involve the members of the Church more effectively in missionary work. Member-missionary work is the key to the future growth of the Church, and it is one of the great keys to the individual growth of our

members" (Regional Representatives' seminar, 3 Oct. 1980).

We all share this great responsibility. We cannot avoid it. Let no man or woman think that because of where we live, or because of our place in society, or because of our occupation or status, we are exempt from this responsibility.

Membership in the Lord's Church is a gift and a blessing which the Lord has given us in mortality, and He expects us to share that blessing with those who do not have it.

We also have a great obligation to love our neighbors. It is the second of the two great commandments. Many of our neighbors are not yet members of the Church. We must be good neighbors. We must love all our Father's children and associate with them.

How I pray that we will be filled with the love of God for our fellowman!

Participate in missionary service

Fifth, we can participate in missionary service by preparing for and serving a mission.

One way couples can do this is to save and prepare to serve a mission together. Again I state, "We have need for select missionary couples" (*Ensign*, May 1984, p. 45).

I repeat, we urge you to seriously consider serving a full-time mission. Some of you younger couples have your sons already on missions. Perhaps now is the time for you to prepare financially and otherwise for missionary service. Many couples have provided distinguished service and stability to various missions in the Church.

You can study the scriptures together, particularly the Book of Mormon. The Lord has said that we are condemned if we do not remember the new covenant, even the Book of Mormon. (See D&C 84:56-57.)

Missionary service requires great faith. I know how difficult it is for older couples to decide to serve missions. I have two widowed sisters who went on a mission to England together. A brother has just left for his third mission

with his wife. Many couples can attest that their missionary service was among their happiest times together because they were completely dedicated to one purpose—missionary work.

Spirit of missionary work

Yes, brothers and sisters, the field is "white already to harvest; and lo, he that thrusteth in his sickle with his might, the same layeth up in store that he perisheth not, but bringeth salvation to his soul" (D&C 4:4).

I am grateful for the great missionary program of the Church. My father's family consisted of eleven children. All eleven of us have filled missions. My wife also filled a mission and had the pleasure of her widowed mother serving with her for the last six months. When my own father went on a mission, I remember, as the eldest son, the letters that he wrote from the mission field in the Midwest. There came into that home a spirit of missionary work that has never left it, for which I am humbly grateful.

May God bless this great missionary program. May He bless each of us with the spirit of missionary work prompted out of love for our fellowman.

I testify that this work is true and that the results of all our efforts today will one day fill the world with wards, stakes, and many millions of our Father's children whose souls are saved in His kingdom.

God bless us all as members of His Church to share the gospel with others, in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

President Ezra Taft Benson, President of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, has just addressed us.

We shall ask the newly called Brethren to come and take seats here on the stand—if they will proceed to do so immediately so that all of you may watch them.

The Tabernacle Choir will now sing "Blessing, Glory, Wisdom, and Strength," following which we will be pleased to hear Elder Bruce R. McConkie, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles.

The choir sang "Blessing, Glory, Wisdom, and Strength."

Elder Bruce R. McConkie spoke without further announcement.

Elder Bruce R. McConkie

Most transcendent event

I feel, and the Spirit seems to accord, that the most important doctrine I can declare, and the most powerful testimony I can bear, is of the atoning sacrifice of the Lord Jesus Christ.

His atonement is the most transcendent event that ever has or ever will occur from Creation's dawn through all the ages of a never-ending eternity.

It is the supreme act of goodness and grace that only a god could perform. Through it, all of the terms and conditions of the Father's eternal plan of salvation became operative.

Blessings of the true and faithful

Through it are brought to pass the immortality and eternal life of man. Through it, all men are saved from death, hell, the devil, and endless torment.

And through it, all who believe and obey the glorious gospel of God, all who are true and faithful and overcome the world, all who suffer for Christ and his word, all who are chastened and scourged in the Cause of him whose we are—all shall become as their Maker and sit with him on his throne and reign with him forever in everlasting glory.

Witness by Holy Spirit of God

In speaking of these wondrous things I shall use my own words, though you may think they are the words of scripture, words spoken by other Apostles and prophets.

True it is they were first proclaimed by others, but they are now mine, for the Holy Spirit of God has borne witness to me that they are true, and it is now as though the Lord had revealed them to me in the first instance. I have thereby heard his voice and know his word.

Christ suffered for us in Gethsemane

Two thousand years ago, outside Jerusalem's walls, there was a pleasant garden spot, Gethsemane by name, where Jesus and his intimate friends were wont to retire for pondering and prayer.

There Jesus taught his disciples the doctrines of the kingdom, and all of them communed with Him who is the Father of us all, in whose ministry they were engaged, and on whose errand they served.

This sacred spot, like Eden where Adam dwelt, like Sinai from whence Jehovah gave his laws, like Calvary where the Son of God gave his life a ransom for many, this holy ground is where the Sinless Son of the Everlasting Father took upon himself the sins of all men on condition of repentance.

He made mercy available

We do not know, we cannot tell, no mortal mind can conceive the full import of what Christ did in Gethsemane.

We know he sweat great goutts of blood from every pore as he drained the

dregs of that bitter cup his Father had given him.

We know he suffered, both body and spirit, more than it is possible for man to suffer, except it be unto death.

We know that in some way, incomprehensible to us, his suffering satisfied the demands of justice, ransomed penitent souls from the pains and penalties of sin, and made mercy available to those who believe in his holy name.

We know that he lay prostrate upon the ground as the pains and agonies of an infinite burden caused him to tremble and would that he might not drink the bitter cup.

We know that an angel came from the courts of glory to strengthen him in his ordeal, and we suppose it was mighty Michael, who foremost fell that mortal man might be.

As near as we can judge, these infinite agonies—this suffering beyond compare—continued for some three or four hours.

He was judged as a common criminal

After this—his body then wrenched and drained of strength—he confronted Judas and the other incarnate devils, some from the very Sanhedrin itself; and he was led away with a rope around his neck, as a common criminal, to be judged by the arch-criminals, who as Jews sat in Aaron's seat and who as Romans wielded Caesar's power.

They took him to Annas, to Caiaphas, to Pilate, to Herod, and back to Pilate. He was accused, cursed, and smitten. Their foul saliva ran down his face as vicious blows further weakened his pain-engulfed body.

With reeds of wrath they rained blows upon his back. Blood ran down his face as a crown of thorns pierced his trembling brow.

But above it all he was scourged, scourged with forty stripes save one, scourged with a multithonged whip into whose leather strands sharp bones and cutting metals were woven.

He suffered an ignominious death at Calvary

Many died from scourging alone, but he rose from the sufferings of the scourge that he might die an ignominious death upon the cruel cross of Calvary.

Then he carried his own cross until he collapsed from the weight and pain and mounting agony of it all.

Finally, on a hill called Calvary—again, it was outside Jerusalem's walls—while helpless disciples looked on and felt the agonies of near death in their own bodies, the Roman soldiers laid him upon the cross.

With great mallets they drove spikes of iron through his feet and hands and wrists. Truly he was wounded for our transgressions and bruised for our iniquities.

Then the cross was raised that all might see and gape and curse and deride. This they did, with evil venom, for three hours from 9:00 A.M. to noon.

He entered paradise of God

Then the heavens grew black. Darkness covered the land for the space of three hours, as it did among the Nephites. There was a mighty storm, as though the very God of Nature was in agony.

And truly he was, for while he was hanging on the cross for another three hours, from noon to 3:00 P.M., all the infinite agonies and merciless pains of Gethsemane recurred.

And, finally, when the atoning agonies had taken their toll—when the victory had been won, when the Son of God had fulfilled the will of his Father in all things—then he said, "It is finished" (John 19:30), and he voluntarily gave up the ghost.

As the peace and comfort of a merciful death freed him from the pains and sorrows of mortality, he entered the paradise of God.

When he had made his soul an offering for sin, he was prepared to see

his seed, according to the messianic word.

These, consisting of all the holy prophets and faithful Saints from ages past; these, comprising all who had taken upon them his name, and who, being spiritually begotten by him, had become his sons and his daughters, even as it is with us; all these were assembled in the spirit world, there to see his face and hear his voice.

After some thirty-eight or forty hours—three days as the Jews measured time—our Blessed Lord came to the Arimathæan's tomb, where his partially embalmed body had been placed by Nicodemus and Joseph of Arimathæa.

He will reign forever in eternal glory

Then, in a way incomprehensible to us, he took up that body which had not yet seen corruption and arose in that glorious immortality which made him like his resurrected Father.

He then received all power in heaven and on earth, obtained eternal exaltation, appeared unto Mary Magdalene and many others, and ascended into heaven, there to sit down on the right hand of God the Father Almighty and to reign forever in eternal glory.

He is father of immortality

His rising from death on the third day crowned the Atonement. Again, in some way incomprehensible to us, the effects of his resurrection pass upon all men so that all shall rise from the grave.

As Adam brought death, so Christ brought life; as Adam is the father of mortality, so Christ is the father of immortality.

And without both, mortality and immortality, man cannot work out his salvation and ascend to those heights beyond the skies where gods and angels dwell forever in eternal glory.

Atonement—least understood doctrine

Now, the atonement of Christ is the most basic and fundamental doctrine of the gospel, and it is the least understood of all our revealed truths.

Many of us have a superficial knowledge and rely upon the Lord and his goodness to see us through the trials and perils of life.

But if we are to have faith like Enoch and Elijah we must believe what they believed, know what they knew, and live as they lived.

Sound and sure knowledge of the Atonement

May I invite you to join with me in gaining a sound and sure knowledge of the Atonement.

We must cast aside the philosophies of men and the wisdom of the wise and hearken to that Spirit which is given to us to guide us into all truth.

We must search the scriptures, accepting them as the mind and will and voice of the Lord and the very power of God unto salvation.

As we read, ponder, and pray, there will come into our minds a view of the three gardens of God—the Garden of Eden, the Garden of Gethsemane, and the Garden of the Empty Tomb where Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene.

Garden of Eden

In Eden we will see all things created in a paradisiacal state—without death, without procreation, without probationary experiences.

We will come to know that such a creation, now unknown to man, was the only way to provide for the Fall.

We will then see Adam and Eve, the first man and the first woman, step down from their state of immortal and paradisiacal glory to become the first mortal flesh on earth.

Mortality, including as it does procreation and death, will enter the

world. And because of transgression a probationary estate of trial and testing will begin.

Gardens of Gethsemane and the empty tomb

Then in Gethsemane we will see the Son of God ransom man from the temporal and spiritual death that came to us because of the Fall.

And finally, before an empty tomb, we will come to know that Christ our Lord has burst the bands of death and stands forever triumphant over the grave.

Thus, Creation is father to the Fall; and by the Fall came mortality and death; and by Christ came immortality and eternal life.

If there had been no fall of Adam, by which cometh death, there could have been no atonement of Christ, by which cometh life.

Salvation through his atoning blood

And now, as pertaining to this perfect atonement, wrought by the shedding of the blood of God—I testify that it took place in Gethsemane and at Golgotha, and as pertaining to Jesus Christ, I testify that he is the Son of the Living God and was crucified for the sins of the world. He is our Lord, our God, and our King. This I know of myself independent of any other person.

I am one of his witnesses, and in a coming day I shall feel the nail marks in his hands and in his feet and shall wet his feet with my tears.

But I shall not know any better then than I know now that he is God's Almighty Son, that he is our Savior and Redeemer, and that salvation comes in and through his atoning blood and in no other way.

God grant that all of us may walk in the light as God our Father is in the light so that, according to the promises, the blood of Jesus Christ his Son will cleanse us from all sin.

In the name of the Lord Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

Elder Bruce R. McConkie of the Council of the Twelve Apostles has just spoken to us. Thank you, Brother McConkie, for your elequent and moving testimony given under difficult circumstances.

The choir and congregation will now join in singing "Redeemer of Israel, our only delight," following which we shall hear from Elder Russell M. Nelson of the Council of the Twelve Apostles.

The choir and congregation sang "Redeemer of Israel."

Elder Russell M. Nelson spoke without further announcement.

Elder Russell M. Nelson

Unitedly we thank the Almighty for the wondrous prolongation of the life of Elder Bruce R. McConkie, enabling him to preach that powerful sermon. Our gratitude is profound!

Reverence for life

I pray for the Spirit of the Lord to help me communicate his mind and will

on a very vital and sensitive subject. I apologize for the use of words repugnant to me and ill-suited to this hallowed pulpit. I do so only for clarity of communication regarding reverence for human life.

As sons and daughters of God, we cherish life as a gift from him.

A heavy toll on life is included among the evils of war. Data from all

nations are appalling. For the United States of America, one hundred thousand were killed in World War I; over four hundred thousand died in World War II. In the first two hundred years as a nation, the lives of over one million Americans were lost due to war.

Abortion—war on unborn

Regrettable as is the loss of loved ones from war, these figures are dwarfed by the toll of a new war that *annually* claims more casualties than the total number of fatalities from all the wars of this nation.

It is a war on the defenseless—and the voiceless. It is a war on the unborn.

This war, labeled "abortion," is of epidemic proportion and is waged globally. Over 55 million abortions were reported worldwide in the year 1974 alone.¹ Sixty-four percent of the world's population now live in countries that legally sanction this practice.² In the United States of America, over 1.5 million abortions are performed annually.³ About 25 to 30 percent of all pregnancies now end in abortion.⁴ In some metropolitan areas, there are more abortions performed than live births.⁵ Comparable data also come from other nations.

War on life

Yet society professes reverence for human life. We weep for those who die, pray and work for those whose lives are in jeopardy. For years I have labored with other doctors here and abroad, struggling to prolong life. It is impossible to describe the grief a physician feels when the life of a patient is lost. Can anyone imagine how we feel when life is destroyed at its roots, as though it were a thing of naught?

What sense of inconsistency can allow people to grieve for their dead, yet be calloused to this baleful war being waged on life at the time of its silent development? What logic would encourage efforts to preserve the life of a critically ill twelve-week-old infant,

but countenance the termination of another life twelve weeks after inception? More attention is seemingly focused on the fate of a life at some penitentiary's death row than on the millions totally deprived of life's opportunity through such odious carnage before birth.

Twisted reasoning

The Lord has repeatedly declared this divine imperative: "Thou shalt not kill."⁶ Recently he added, "Nor do anything like unto it" (D&C 59:6). Even before the fulness of the gospel was restored, the enlightened understood the sanctity of life. John Calvin, the sixteenth-century reformer, wrote: "If it seems more horrible to kill a man in his own house than in a field, because a man's house is his place of most secure refuge, it ought surely to be deemed more atrocious to destroy a *fetus* in the womb before it has come to light."⁷

But what impropriety could now legalize that which has been forbidden by the laws of God from the dawn of time? What twisted reasoning has transformed mythical concepts into contorted slogans assenting to a practice which is consummately wrong?

Proper concern or convenience?

These slogans begin with proper concern for the health of the mother. Infrequently, instances may occur in which the continuation of pregnancy could be life-threatening to the mother. When deemed by competent medical authorities that the life of one must be terminated in order to save the life of the other, many agree that it is better to spare the mother. But these circumstances are rare, particularly where modern medical care is available.

Another sympathetic concern applies to pregnancies resulting from rape or incest. The tragedy of this despoilment is compounded because, in such relationships, freedom of choice is denied the woman who is innocently involved.

But less than 3 percent of all abortions are performed for these two reasons.⁸ The other 97 percent are performed for what may be termed "reasons of convenience."

Some argue for abortion because a malformed child may result. The harmful effects of certain infectious or toxic agents in the first trimester of pregnancy are real.

Trusting in the Lord

The experience of a couple whom I shall identify as Brother and Sister Brown (fictitious names) is instructive. Sister Brown was only twenty-one years old at the time, a beautiful woman and a devoted wife. In her first trimester, she contracted the dreaded German measles.

Abortion was advised because the developing baby would almost surely be damaged. Some members of her family, out of loving concern, applied additional pressure for an abortion. "Don't burden yourself financially with a handicapped child," they argued. "You are too young and too poor."

Devotedly Brother and Sister Brown consulted their bishop. He referred them to their stake president, who listened to their serious concern and counseled them not to terminate the life of this baby, even though the child might have a problem. He quoted this scripture:

"Trust in the Lord with all thine heart; and lean not unto thine own understanding. In all thy ways acknowledge him, and he shall direct thy paths" (Proverbs 3:5-6).

They chose to follow that counsel and permit their child to be born—a beautiful little girl, normal in every respect, except for a hearing loss, that became evident later. After an evaluation at a school for the deaf, Brother and Sister Brown were advised that this child had the intellect of a genius. Now, some twenty years later, she attends a major university on a scholarship.

When recently asked how they felt about their once-weighty decision, the mother quickly responded, "She is one

of the great joys of my life! She is such a choice spirit! Though she lost the sense of hearing, she has compensated with augmented ability otherwise. Her eyes are alive with constant attention. She excels in dancing, even though she perceives the sounds of music from vibrations. She has served as an officer in school. But most significant is her guileless spirit, her unconditional love. She has taught us to serve and to share. Her spiritual insights have helped us to know God and his purposes. My husband and I are so grateful that she is one of our children."

Consider another individual weighing the consequences of her pregnancy. She was beyond the normal age for bearing children. She announced to her doctor that her husband was an alcoholic with a syphilitic infection. One of her children had been born dead. Another child was blind. Another had tuberculosis. Her family had a history of deafness. Finally she confessed that she was living in abject poverty. If this true historical situation were posed today, many would recommend abortion. The child born from that pregnancy became the renowned composer Ludwig van Beethoven.

But the principle involved extends beyond those who may become great. If one is to be deprived of life because of potential for developing physical problems, consistency would dictate that those who already have such deficiencies should likewise be terminated. Continuing, then, those who are either infirm, incompetent, or inconvenient should be eliminated by those in power. Such irreverence for life is unthinkable!

Free but not from consequences

Another contention raised is that a woman is free to choose what she does with her own body. To a certain extent this is true for all of us. We are free to think. We are free to plan. And then we are free to do. But once an action has been taken, we are never free from its consequences. Those considering abortion have already exercised certain choices.

To clarify this concept, we can learn from the astronaut. Any time during the selection process, planning, and preparation, he is free to withdraw. But once the powerful rocket fuel is ignited, he is no longer free to choose. Now he is bound by the consequences of his choice. Even if difficulties develop and he might wish otherwise, the choice made was sealed by action.

So it is with those who would tamper with the God-given power of procreation. They are free to think and plan otherwise, but their choice is sealed by action.

Two separate lives involved

The woman's choice for her own body does not validate choice for the body of another. The expression "terminate the pregnancy" applies literally only to the woman. The consequence of terminating the fetus therein involves the body and very life of another. These two individuals have separate brains, separate hearts, and separate circulatory systems. To pretend that there is no child and no life there is to deny reality.

It is not a question of when "meaningful life" begins or when the spirit "quickens" the body. In the biological sciences, it is known that life begins when two germ cells unite to become one cell, bringing together twenty-three chromosomes from both the father and from the mother. These chromosomes contain thousands of genes. In a marvelous process involving a combination of genetic coding by which all the basic human characteristics of the unborn person are established, a new DNA complex is formed. A continuum of growth results in a new human being. The onset of life is not a debatable issue, but a fact of science.

Approximately twenty-two days after the two cells have united, a little heart begins to beat. At twenty-six days the circulation of blood begins.⁹

Scripture declares that the "life of the flesh is in the blood"

(Leviticus 17:11). Abortion sheds that innocent blood.

Faith and obedience

Another excuse some use to justify abortion relates to population control. Many in developing nations unknowingly ascribe their lack of prosperity to overpopulation. While they grovel in ignorance of God and his commandments, they may worship objects of their own creation (or nothing at all), while unsuccessfully attempting to limit their population by the rampant practice of abortion. They live in squalor, oblivious to the divine teaching—stated in the scriptures not once, but thirty-four times—that people will prosper in the land only if they obey the commandments of God.¹⁰

How can God fulfill his promise to prosper his children in obedience if they worship idols or destroy life created by him—destined to be in his very image?

They will prosper only when their education includes faith in and obedience to the God of this world, who said, "I, the Lord, . . . built the earth, my very handiwork; and all things therein are mine. And it is my purpose to provide. . . . *But it must needs be done in mine own way.* . . . For the earth is full, and there is enough and to spare" (D&C 104:14–17; italics added).

Warnings

Now, as a servant of the Lord, I dutifully warn those who advocate and practice abortion that they incur the wrath of Almighty God, who declared, "If men . . . hurt a woman with child, so that her fruit depart from her, . . . he shall be surely punished" (Exodus 21:22).

Of those who shed innocent blood, a prophet declared: "The judgments which [God] shall exercise . . . in his wrath [shall] be just; and the blood of the innocent shall stand as a witness against them, yea, and cry

mightily against them at the last day" (Alma 14:11).

The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints has consistently opposed the practice of abortion. One hundred years ago the First Presidency wrote: "And we again take this opportunity of warning the Latter-day Saints against those . . . practices of foeticide and infanticide."¹

Early in his presidency, our beloved President Spencer W. Kimball said, "We decry abortions and ask our people to refrain from this serious transgression."²

Why destroy a life that could bring such joy to others?

Hope for those who have so sinned?

Now, is there hope for those who have so sinned without full understanding, who now suffer heartbreak? Yes. So far as is known, the Lord does not regard this transgression as murder. And "as far as has been revealed, a person may repent and be forgiven for the sin of abortion."³ Gratefully, we know the Lord will help all who are truly repentant.

Life—gift from God

Yes, life is precious! No one can cuddle a cherished newborn baby, look into those beautiful eyes, feel the little fingers, and caress that miraculous creation without deepening reverence for life and for our Creator.

Life comes from life. It is a gift from our Heavenly Father. It is eternal, as he is eternal. Innocent life is not sent by him to be destroyed! This doctrine is not of me, but is that of the living God and of his divine Son, which I testify in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

References

- ¹ Christopher Tietze, *Induced Abortion: A World Review*, 4th ed. (New York: Population Council, 1981), p. 19.

² Tietze, *Induced Abortion*, pp. 7, 19–37.

³ See Stanley K. Henshaw, Jacqueline Darroch Forrest, Ellen Sullivan, and Christopher Tietze, "Abortion Services in the United States, 1979 and 1980," *Family Planning Perspective*, Jan./Feb. 1982, pp. 1, 7.

⁴ Henshaw, et al, "Abortion Services," *Family Planning Perspective*, p. 6.

⁵ See Center for Disease Control, *Annual Summary: Abortion Surveillance, 1979–80*, U.S. Department of Health, Education, and Welfare, p. 130.

⁶ See Exodus 20:13, Deuteronomy 5:17, Matthew 5:21, Mark 10:19, Luke 18:20, Romans 13:9, James 2:11, Mosiah 13:21, 3 Nephi 12:21, D&C 42:18–19, D&C 132:36.

⁷ John Calvin, *Commentaries on the Four Last Books of Moses Arranged in the Form of a Harmony*, 24 vols., trans. Charles William Bingham (Grand Rapids, Michigan: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1950), 3:42 (Exodus 21:22).

⁸ See U.S. Senate Committee on the Judiciary, *The Human Life Bill: Hearings on S. 158*, 97th Congress, First Session, 1981.

⁹ See J. Willis Hurst, R. Bruce Logue, Robert C. Schlant, and Nanette Kass Wenger, *The Heart*, 4th ed. (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1978), p. 7.

¹⁰ See Leviticus 26:3–15; Joshua 1:7–8; 1 Kings 2:3; 2 Kings 18:7; 2 Chronicles 24:20, 26:5, 31:21; Ezra 6:14; Job 36:11; 1 Nephi 2:20, 4:14; 2 Nephi 1:9, 20, 31; 4:4; 5:10–11; Jarom 1:9; Omni 1:6; Mosiah 1:7; 2:22, 31; Alma 9:13; 36:1, 30; 37:13; 38:1; 45:6–8; 48:15, 25; 50:20; Helaman 3:20; 3 Nephi 5:22; D&C 9:13.

¹¹ In James R. Clark, comp., *Messages of the First Presidency of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints*, 6 vols. (Salt Lake City: Bookcraft, 1965–75), 3:11.

¹² *Ensign*, Nov. 1975, p. 6.

¹³ *General Handbook of Instructions*, 1983, p. 78.

President Hinckley

We have just listened to Elder Russell M. Nelson, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, who professionally has been widely recog-

nized in his capacity as a medical doctor and surgeon.

Elder Victor L. Brown, who was just released as Presiding Bishop of the Church and sustained as a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy, will be our next speaker.

Elder Victor L. Brown

Twenty-four years ago this next October, I received a long-distance telephone call at our home in Chicago. The caller in Salt Lake City asked if I planned to attend general conference, which convened the next morning. To this I answered, "No," whereupon he asked if I could. I responded, "I suppose I can if you want me to." The caller said, "The President of the Church would like to see you tomorrow morning at 8:00 in his office. Now have a good night's sleep because it will be your last." After some twenty-four years, it looks as though I may get that good night's sleep—perhaps.

Gratitude

These years have been the most challenging and rewarding years of my life. I have had the indescribable blessing of being tutored every week, with few exceptions, by four Presidents of the Church and eight different Counselors in the First Presidency, and, of course, for eleven years of that time, by a wonderful Presiding Bishop, John H. Vandenberg. It was a great blessing to serve with Elder Robert L. Simpson as Counselors to Bishop Vandenberg. Words cannot adequately express my love and my appreciation for my own faithful Counselors, Elder Vaughn J. Featherstone, Bishop H. Burke Peterson, and Bishop J. Richard Clarke, for their loyalty to me personally, and for their outstanding contribution to the Church during these thirteen years. We've been abundantly blessed by men and women of great faith and

commitment—both here at home and from all over the world—who joined with us in response to the assignment from the First Presidency to accomplish the temporal work of the kingdom in these latter days. I express my heartfelt appreciation and gratitude to all, wherever they may be, and thank them for the blessing of being associated with them.

Free agency

These associations have reinforced for me the basic principles learned in my youth. I should like to discuss two or three of them today. There are some things that are common to all mankind. Two of the most obvious are that we are born and we die. We take with us in death no more than we brought with us in birth, as far as material things are concerned. The closer I get to the time of departure from this life, the more concern I feel about what I will take with me.

A common principle, perhaps one of the most important, is the gift of free agency. This great gift of God to all of his children was part of the plan of salvation explained in the councils in heaven. From the scriptures we read:

"And the Messiah cometh in the fulness of time, that he may redeem the children of men from the fall. And because they are redeemed from the fall they have become free forever, knowing good from evil, to act for themselves. . . .

"Wherefore, men are free according to the flesh; and all things are given

them which are expedient unto man. And they are free to choose liberty and eternal life, through the great Mediator of all men, or to choose captivity and death, according to the captivity and power of the devil; for he seeketh that all men might be miserable like unto himself" (2 Nephi 2:26-27).

Individual salvation

As President Brigham Young said:

"If Brother Brigham shall take a wrong track, and be shut out of the Kingdom of heaven, no person will be to blame but Brother Brigham. I am the only being in heaven, earth, or hell, that can be blamed.

"This will equally apply to every Latter-day Saint. Salvation is an individual operation. I am the only person that can possibly save myself. When salvation is sent to me, I can reject or receive it. In receiving it, I yield implicit obedience and submission to its great Author throughout my life, and to those whom he shall appoint to instruct me; in rejecting it, I follow the dictates of my own will in preference to the will of my Creator" (*Discourses of Brigham Young*, sel. John A. Widtsoe [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1941], p. 390).

Obedience

Thus we see that free agency goes hand in hand with responsibility, and that consequences, good or bad, are the result of our personal decisions resulting from the exercise of free agency. And this is another principle, obedience.

The Lord, understanding our frailty as human beings and recognizing the influence that Satan would exert, gave us standards by which we can live our lives and know good from evil. These standards are found in the holy scriptures. I should like to refer to some of these scriptures which for me have increased meaning as I grow older. The

first one, perhaps, would be the foundation upon which the others can rise.

Light of life

In the eighth chapter of John, the Savior says, "I am the light of the world: he that followeth me shall not walk in darkness, but shall have the light of life" (John 8:12). If we accept this statement of the Lord, others will naturally fold into proper place. What does it mean to have the "light of life" and "not walk in darkness"? A rich young ruler may have had this question in mind when he asked Jesus what he should do to inherit eternal life, which is the greatest gift of God to man. The Savior responded:

"Thou knowest the commandments, Do not commit adultery, Do not kill, Do not steal, Do not bear false witness, Honour thy father and thy mother.

"And he said, All these have I kept from my youth up.

"Now when Jesus heard these things, he said unto him, Yet lackest thou one thing: sell all that thou hast, and distribute unto the poor, and thou shalt have treasure in heaven: and come, follow me.

"And when he heard this, he was very sorrowful: for he was very rich.

"And when Jesus saw that he was very sorrowful, he said, How hardly shall they that have riches enter into the kingdom of God!

"For it is easier for a camel to go through a needle's eye, than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God" (Luke 18:20-25).

Naaman and a prophet in Israel

May I restate part of President Young's quotation: "When salvation is sent to me, I can reject or receive it. In receiving it, I yield implicit obedience and submission to its great Author throughout my life."

One of the great lessons on obedience is taught in the story of Naaman. Naaman was "captain of the host of the

king of Syria, . . . and a mighty man in valour, but he was a leper" (2 Kings 5:1).

One of his wife's maidens, an Israelite who had great faith and concern for Naaman's condition, "said unto her mistress, Would God my lord were with the prophet that is in Samaria! for he would recover him of his leprosy" (2 Kings 5:3).

When the king learned of this, he sent Naaman to the king of Israel with a letter and with gifts, requesting that the king of Israel cure Naaman of his leprosy. He had misunderstood the maiden's comment and thought that the king of Israel was the one who could cure his ailment. The Israelite king was very upset with this request because he had no power to do such a thing. Yet, he knew if he did not do it, it could mean war with the Syrians. Elisha, the prophet, heard of the king's distress and suggested, "Let him come now to me, and he shall know that there is a prophet in Israel."

"So Naaman came with his horses and with his chariot, and stood at the door of the house of Elisha.

"And Elisha sent a messenger unto him, saying, Go and wash in Jordan seven times, and thy flesh shall come again to thee, and thou shalt be clean" (2 Kings 5:8-10).

Naaman being a man of high position was insulted that Elisha would send a messenger and not show him the respect of coming himself. In addition, the simple nature of the message offended him.

"Naaman was wroth, and went away, and said, Behold, I thought, He will surely come out to me, and stand, and call on the name of the Lord his God, and strike his hand over the place, and recover the leper.

"Are not Abana and Pharpar, rivers of Damascus, better than all the waters of Israel? may I not wash in them, and be clean? So he turned and went away in a rage.

"And his servants came near, and spake unto him, and said, My father, if the prophet had bid thee do some great

thing, wouldest thou not have done it? how much rather then, when he said to thee, Wash, and be clean?

"Then went he down, and dipped himself seven times in Jordan, according to the saying of the man of God: and his flesh came again like unto the flesh of a little child, and he was clean" (2 Kings 5:11-14).

Naaman needed to have the faith of a child to be obedient as a child before his flesh became clean as a little child's.

Act promptly and decisively

The final principle that I have observed in the lives of effective men and women is to act promptly and decisively once they have determined what the Lord wishes done. In the parable of the ten virgins, we are taught the folly of procrastinating and delaying our preparation for the day when the Savior will come again—but it is our choice. We "are free to choose liberty and eternal life . . . or to choose captivity and death" (2 Nephi 2:27).

"Then shall the kingdom of heaven be likened unto ten virgins, which took their lamps, and went forth to meet the bridegroom"—who is the Savior—at his second coming.

"And five of them were wise, and five were foolish.

"They that were foolish took their lamps, and took no oil with them:

"But the wise took oil in their vessels with their lamps. . . .

"And at midnight there was a cry made, Behold, the bridegroom cometh; go ye out to meet him.

"Then all those virgins arose, and trimmed their lamps.

"And the foolish said unto the wise, Give us of your oil; for our lamps are gone out.

"But the wise answered, saying, Not so; lest there be not enough for us and you: but go ye rather to them that sell, and buy for yourselves.

"And while they went to buy, the bridegroom came; and they that were

ready went in with him to the marriage: and the door was shut.

"Afterward came also the other virgins, saying, Lord, Lord, open to us.

"But he answered and said, Verily I say unto you, I know you not.

"Watch therefore, for ye know neither the day nor the hour wherein the Son of man cometh" (Matthew 25:1-4, 6-13).

The foolish virgins expected that they could borrow oil from others. To their sorrow, they learned that they were individually responsible for their circumstances and had not prepared themselves. As I conclude this part of my service in the Church, it is my prayer that each of us will be wise enough to live lives that will cause us to be found among those referred to in this scripture:

"And at that day, when I shall come in my glory, shall the parable be fulfilled which I spake concerning the ten virgins.

"For they that are wise and have received the truth, and have taken the Holy Spirit for their guide, and have not been deceived—verily I say unto you, they shall not be hewn down and cast into the fire, but shall abide the day.

"And the earth shall be given unto them for an inheritance; and they shall multiply and wax strong, and their children shall grow up without sin unto salvation.

"For the Lord shall be in their midst, and his glory shall be upon them, and he will be their king and their lawgiver" (D&C 45:56-59). In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

Elder Howard W. Hunter, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, will now address us. He will be our concluding speaker.

Elder Howard W. Hunter

Passover and Easter

I believe it is safe to say that Passover is without equal in the Jewish calendar of celebrations. It is the oldest of the Jewish festivals, celebrating an event in advance of receiving the traditional Mosaic Law. It reminds every generation of the return of the children of Israel to the promised land and of the great travail in Egypt which preceded it. It commemorates the passage of a people from subjection and bondage to freedom and deliverance. It is the Old Testament festival of springtime when the world of nature awakens to life, growth, and fruition.

Passover is linked with the Christian observance of Easter which we celebrate this weekend in this great conference of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. The Passover in the Old Testament and Easter in

the New Testament testify of the great gift God has given and of the sacrifice that was involved in its bestowal. Both of these great religious commemorations declare that death would "pass over" us and could have no permanent power upon us, and that the grave would have no victory.

Plagues in Egypt

In delivering the children of Israel out of Egypt, Jehovah himself spoke to Moses out of the burning bush at Sinai saying:

"I have surely seen the affliction of my people which are in Egypt, and have heard their cry by reason of their taskmasters; for I know their sorrows. . . .

"Come now therefore, and I will send thee unto Pharaoh, that thou mayest bring forth my people the children

of Israel out of Egypt" (Exodus 3:7, 10).

Because Pharaoh was unyielding, many plagues were brought upon Egypt, but still "the heart of Pharaoh was hardened, neither would he let the children of Israel go" (Exodus 9:35).

In response to that refusal by Pharaoh, the Lord said, "And all the firstborn in the land of Egypt shall die, from the firstborn of Pharaoh that sitteth upon his throne, even unto the firstborn of the maidservant that is behind the mill; and all the firstborn of beasts" (Exodus 11:5).

As a protection against this last and most terrible punishment inflicted upon the Egyptians, the Lord instructed Moses to have the children of Israel take to them every man a lamb without blemish.

"And they shall take of the blood, and strike it on the two side posts and on the upper door post of the houses, wherein they shall eat it.

"And they shall eat the flesh in that night, roast with fire, and unleavened bread; and with bitter herbs they shall eat it. . . .

"And thus shall ye eat it; with your loins girded, your shoes on your feet, and your staff in your hand; and ye shall eat it in haste: it is the Lord's passover. . . .

"And it shall come to pass, when your children shall say unto you, What mean ye by this service?

"That ye shall say, It is the sacrifice of the Lord's passover, who passed over the houses of the children of Israel in Egypt" (Exodus 12:7-8, 11, 26-27).

Boy Jesus in the temple

After the Israelites had escaped from Pharaoh's grasp and death came to the firstborn of the Egyptians, the Israelites eventually crossed over Jordan. It is recorded that "the children of Israel encamped in Gilgal, and kept the passover on the fourteenth day of the month at even in the plains of Jericho" (Joshua 5:10). And so it was with Jewish families year after year thereafter,

including the family of Joseph and Mary and the young boy, Jesus.

When Jesus was but twelve years old, he went to Jerusalem with his parents to take part in the Passover celebration. Luke's account tells us that Jesus remained behind in the temple after his parents had departed for home. They returned with fear and anxiety to find him among the doctors of the law "both hearing them, and asking them questions" (Luke 2:46). Luke records that all who "heard him were astonished at his understanding and answers" (Luke 2:47).

Could it have been possible that Jesus was teaching these older and formally trained men about the meaning of the Passover just celebrated? Would it have surprised them that one so young and seemingly inexperienced would have known so much about the meaning of that fateful night in Egypt so long ago and so far away? Would they have been amazed at his knowledge of the lamb and the blood and the firstborn and the sacrifice? The scriptures are silent on such questions.

Passovers during Christ's ministry

As the Gospel of John makes clear, the feast of the Passover marked significant milestones during the mortal ministry of Christ. At the first Passover in his ministry, Jesus made his mission known by purifying the temple when he drove from its portals the money changers and those who sold animals. In the second Passover Jesus manifested his power by the miracle of the loaves and fishes. Christ here introduced the symbols that would later have even greater meaning in the Upper Room. "I am the bread of life," he said. "He that cometh to me shall never hunger; and he that believeth on me shall never thirst" (John 6:35).

Jesus' last Passover

Of course, it would be the feast of his last Passover that would give full expression to this ancient celebration.

By that final week of his mortal ministry, Jesus knew clearly what this particular Passover would mean to him. Trouble was already in the air. Matthew records:

"When Jesus had finished all these sayings, he said unto his disciples,

"Ye know that after two days is the feast of the passover, and the Son of man is betrayed to be crucified" (Matthew 26:1-2).

Knowing full well what awaited him, Jesus asked Peter and John to make arrangements for the paschal meal. He told them to ask of the master of a local house, "Where is the guest-chamber, where I shall eat the passover with my disciples?" (Luke 22:11).

The loneliness of his birth was to be, in a sense, duplicated in the loneliness of his death. Foxes had holes and birds had nests, but the Son of Man had nowhere to lay his head either in his nativity or in his last hours of mortality.

Finally, preparations for the Passover meal were complete, in keeping with nearly fifteen hundred years of tradition. Jesus sat down with his disciples and, after the eating of the sacrificial lamb and of the bread and wine of this ancient feast, he taught them a newer and holier meaning of that ancient blessing from God.

He took one of the flat, round loaves of unleavened bread, said the blessing over it, and broke it into pieces that he distributed to the Apostles, saying: "This is my body which is given for you: this do in remembrance of me" (Luke 22:19).

As the cup was being poured, he took it and, giving thanks, invited them to drink of it, saying, "This cup is the new testament in my blood, which is shed for you" (Luke 22:20). Paul said of it: "For as often as ye eat this bread, and drink this cup, ye do shew the Lord's death till he come" (1 Corinthians 11:26).

Sacrament of the Lord's Supper

The bread and wine, rather than the animals and herbs, would become

emblems of the great Lamb's body and blood, emblems to be eaten and drunk reverently and in remembrance of him forever.

In this simple but impressive manner the Savior instituted the ordinance now known as the sacrament of the Lord's Supper. With the suffering of Gethsemane, the sacrifice of Calvary, and the resurrection from a garden tomb, Jesus fulfilled the ancient law and ushered in a new dispensation based on a higher, holier understanding of the law of sacrifice. No more would men be required to offer the firstborn lamb from their flock, because the Firstborn of God had come to offer himself as an "infinite and eternal sacrifice."

Gift of eternal life

This is the majesty of the Atonement and Resurrection, not just a pass-over from death, but a gift of eternal life by an infinite sacrifice as so beautifully stated by Amulek:

"For it is expedient that there should be a great and last sacrifice; yea, not a sacrifice of man, neither of beast, neither of any manner of fowl; for it shall not be a human sacrifice; but it must be an infinite and eternal sacrifice" (Alma 34:10).

At this Easter season, I bear testimony of the Firstborn of God, who made that sacrifice, who has "borne our griefs, and carried our sorrows," who "was wounded for our transgressions" and "was bruised for our iniquities" (Isaiah 53:4-5). Of the divine nature of this Redeemer and Savior of all mankind I testify, in his name, Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

Elder Howard W. Hunter, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, has been our concluding speaker.

We are grateful to the managers and operators of the many television and radio stations and cable systems for

offering their facilities as a public service to bring the proceedings of this conference to a large audience throughout many areas of the world.

The Tabernacle Choir will now sing "Thy Spirit, Lord, Has Stirred Our Souls." The benediction will then be given by Elder Yoshihiko Kikuchi, a member of the First Quorum of the Sev-

enty, after which this conference will be adjourned until two o'clock this afternoon.

The choir sang "Thy Spirit, Lord, Has Stirred Our Souls."

Elder Yoshihiko Kikuchi offered the benediction.

FIRST DAY AFTERNOON MEETING

SECOND SESSION

The second general session of the 155th Annual General Conference began at 2:00 P.M. on Saturday, April 6, 1985. President Ezra Taft Benson, President of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, conducted this session.

Music for this session was provided by a Primary children's choir from the Jordan Utah Region with Susan Kenney as director and Clay Christiansen at the organ.

The Primary children's choir sang "Jesus Once Was a Little Child" and "Keep the Commandments," followed by organ music just prior to the opening of the meeting.

At the beginning of the meeting, President Ezra Taft Benson made the following remarks:

President Ezra Taft Benson

What a joy to hear their sweet voices. My beloved brethren and sisters, the First Presidency has asked that I conduct this session of the conference.

We are grateful for the presence of our beloved President Spencer W. Kimball. We deeply regret the absence of President Marion G. Romney to whom we extend our love and blessings.

We are pleased to welcome those who are gathered here in the Tabernacle for this, the second general session of the 155th Annual General Conference of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.

We also welcome those who are participating by means of television, cable, or radio; also the many who are watching in over seven hundred and fifty stake centers throughout the United States and Canada to which the conference is being carried by satellite transmission.

We note that Elders Richard G. Scott and William R. Bradford are presiding in the overflow session in the Assembly Hall.

We are pleased to acknowledge especially our guests who are present this afternoon, along with general and local Church leaders and members from many parts of the world.

We express our appreciation to the owners and operators of many radio and television stations and to the owners and operators of cable systems for their cooperation in making these proceedings available to members and friends of the Church in many countries.

The music for this session will be provided by a Primary children's choir from the Jordan Utah Region, under the direction of Susan Kenney with Clay Christiansen at the organ.

The choir will begin this service by singing "Seek the Lord Early" and "If with All Your Hearts." The invocation will be offered by Elder Theodore M. Burton, a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

The choir sang "Seek the Lord Early" and "If with All Your Hearts." Elder Theodore M. Burton offered the invocation.

President Benson

The choir with Clark Utterback as soloist will now sing "Oh, How Lovely Was the Morning," following which Brother Wilford G. Edling will read the auditor's report and Brother Francis M. Gibbons will present the statistical report of the Church for the year 1984.

The choir sang "Oh, How Lovely Was the Morning."

Auditor's Report 1984

Wilford G. Edling

We have reviewed the annual financial report of the Church as of 31 December 1984 and operations for the year then ended. The financial statements and operations reviewed by the committee include the general funds of the Church and of other controlled organizations, the accounts of which are maintained by the Finance and Records Department of the Church. We have also examined the budgeting, accounting, and auditing procedures employed and the manner in which funds are received and expenditures are controlled. We determined that expenditures of general Church funds were authorized by the First Presidency and by budgetary procedures. The budget is authorized by the Council on Disposition of Tithes, composed of the First Presidency, the Council of the Twelve, and the Presiding Bishopric. The Budget and Appropriations Committee, in weekly meetings, administers the expenditure of funds under the budget.

Modern accounting technology and equipment are employed by the Finance and Records Department and other departments in keeping abreast of rapid Church expansion and changing methods of electronic data processing.

The Auditing Department, which is independent of all other departments, functions in the threefold capacity of performing financial audits, operational audits, and audits of computer systems employed by the Church. These services are conducted on a continuous basis for all Church departments and other Church-controlled organizations, the accounts of which are maintained under the direction of the Finance and Records Department. These comprise worldwide operations including missions, schools, administrative offices, and departmental activities conducted in foreign countries. The extent and scope of the Auditing Department services in safeguarding the resources of the Church are expanding to encompass the growth and widening activities of the Church. The audits of local funds of wards and stakes are performed by stake auditors, the reports of which are reviewed by the Church Auditing Department. Incorporated businesses owned or controlled by the Church, for which accounts are not maintained in the Finance and Records Department, are audited by the Auditing Department, professional auditing firms, or governmental regulatory agencies.

Based on our review of the annual financial report and other accounting data, and our study of the accounting

and auditing methods by which financial operations are controlled, together with continuing discussions with personnel of the Finance and Records Department and Auditing departments, and Church legal representatives, we are of the opinion that the general funds of the Church received and expended during the year 1984 have been prop-

erly accounted for in accordance with established procedures outlined herein.

Respectfully submitted,

Church Audit Committee
Wilford G. Edling
David M. Kennedy
Warren E. Pugh
Merrill J. Bateman
Ted E. Davis

Statistical Report 1984

Francis M. Gibbons

For the information of the members of the Church, the First Presidency has issued the following statistical report concerning the growth and status of the Church as of 31 December 1984.

Church Units

Number of stakes	1,507
Number of districts.....	353
Number of missions.....	180
Number of wards	9,723
Number of branches in stakes	2,697
Number of branches in missions	2,043
Number of sovereign countries with organized wards or branches.....	96
Number of territories, colonies, and possessions with organized wards or branches.....	18

Church Membership

Total membership at the close of 1984	5,650,000
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Church Growth during 1984

Increase in children of record	98,000
Children of record baptized	69,000
Converts baptized	192,983

Priesthood

Deacons.....	240,000
Teachers	178,000
Priests.....	356,000
Elders.....	465,000
Seventies	33,000
High priests	198,000

Missionaries

Full-time missionaries	27,655
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Genealogical Data

Names cleared in 1984 for temple endowments	6,328,870
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Temples

Number of endowments performed during 1984:	
For the living	53,998
For the dead	4,395,424
Temples in operation	31
Temples planned or under construction	15
Temples closed during the year for renovation	1
(Six temples were dedicated in 1984, and seven are planned to be dedicated in 1985.)	

Church Educational System

Total enrollment during 1983-84 school year:	
Seminaries and Institutes, including special programs	322,802
Church schools, colleges, and continuing education	440,502

Welfare Services

Persons assisted by LDS

Social Services	84,069
Persons placed in gainful employment	26,116
Man-days of labor donated to Welfare Services	277,754
Bishop's orders from storehouses	345,498

Prominent Members Who Have Passed Away Since Last April

Elder G. Homer Durham, a member of the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy, who was Church Historian and Recorder; Ethel D. Stapley, widow of Elder Delbert L.

Stapley, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles; Neil D. Schaerrer, former general president of the Young Men organization; and Emily Higgs Bennett, former counselor in the YW-MIA presidency.

President Benson

Thank you, Brothers Edling and Gibbons.

Elder L. Tom Perry, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, will be our first speaker. He will be followed by Elder John Sonnenberg, a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

Elder L. Tom Perry

To Bishop Brown, Bishop Peterson, Bishop Clarke, I just want to express my deep love and appreciation for your great devoted years of service. To Bishop Hales, Bishop Eyring, Bishop Pace, I want you to know that I'm ready to assist in any way that you may desire.

Pavilion foundations

"Therefore whosoever heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them, I will liken him unto a wise man, which built his house upon a rock:

"And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell not: for it was founded upon a rock.

"And every one that heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them not, shall be likened unto a foolish man, which built his house upon the sand:

"And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell: and great was the fall of it" (Matthew 7:24-27).

Years ago I had the privilege of serving on the New York World's Fair

Committee. I remember that after months of planning we were ready to start construction. It was a clear and beautiful day as we gathered at the fair site for our groundbreaking event. All around us was a flurry of activity as the fair buildings were taking shape. The fair was being constructed on a lush meadowland. Instead of the traditional groundbreaking ceremonies of turning over soil with shovels, we were using a pile driver because of the lack of a solid foundation. Big wooden piles about the size of those used for telephone poles were being driven into the ground to form the foundation of our pavilion.

After a prayer and two or three responses, it was time to drive the first pile. Everything was in place. The driver was ready for action. There was a big puff of steam and a loud thud. The pile driver started its work. Then the second puff and the second thud—the pile was on its way into the earth. Then the third puff and the third thud—suddenly the earth swallowed up the pile, and it sank completely out of sight. We learned a great deal that day about foundations.

The days and weeks passed, and many piles were driven into the meadowland soil until a foundation was established that was strong enough to support our beautiful pavilion.

Foundation in the gospel

How often do we consider or think about our own personal faith and our foundation in the gospel? On what are they built? How strong is our house? our household? our family? Helaman taught his two sons:

"I desire that ye should remember to keep the commandments of God. . . . Behold, I have given unto you the names of our first parents who came out of the land of Jerusalem; and this I have done that when you remember your names ye may remember them; and when ye remember them ye may remember their works . . . that they were good.

"Therefore, my sons, I would that ye should do that which is good" (Helaman 5:6-7).

Then Helaman continued to teach his sons "to lay up for yourselves a treasure in heaven, yea, which is eternal . . . that precious gift of eternal life" (Helaman 5:8).

Then he said to them, "My sons, remember, remember that it is upon the rock of our Redeemer, who is Christ, the Son of God, that ye must build your foundation . . . which is a sure foundation, a foundation whereon if men build they cannot fall" (Helaman 5:12).

Rock of eternal truth

We have been taught by the prophets concerning foundations. President Joseph F. Smith has said: "But the men and the women who are honest before God, who humbly plod along, doing their duty, paying their tithing, and exercising that pure religion and undefiled before God and the Father, which is to visit the fatherless and the widows in their afflictions and to keep oneself unspotted from the world, and who help look after the poor; and who

honor the holy Priesthood, who do not run into excesses, who are prayerful in their families, and who acknowledge the Lord in their hearts, they will build up a foundation that the gates of hell cannot prevail against; and if the floods come and the storms beat upon their house, it shall not fall, for it will be built upon the rock of eternal truth" (*Gospel Doctrine*, 5th ed. [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1939], pp. 7-8).

Eternal nature of family unit

One of those great eternal truths which the gospel anchors to a sure foundation is the doctrine of the eternal nature of the family unit. It was to the prophet Malachi the Lord declared:

"Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the Lord:

"And he shall turn the heart of the fathers to the children, and the heart of the children to their fathers" (Malachi 4:5-6).

Can we think of anything more important than residing in an eternal family unit with parents loving children, and children loving parents? It begins, of course, with a husband and wife married in the holy temple of God for all eternity by those holding priesthood authority. For we know that "in the celestial glory there are three heavens or degrees; And in order to obtain the highest, a man must enter into this order of the priesthood [meaning the new and everlasting covenant of marriage]" (D&C 131:1-2).

There is no other way to start an eternal family unit than to be married in the proper place, at the proper time, by the proper authority, receiving the proper instructions that will lay the proper foundation. President David O. McKay said in his infinite wisdom:

"The exalted view of marriage as held by this Church is given expressly in five words found in the 49th section of the Doctrine and Covenants, 'Marriage is ordained of God.' . . .

"It is said that the best and noblest lives are those which are set toward high ideals. Truly no higher ideal regarding marriage can be cherished by young people than to look upon it as a divine institution. In the minds of the young such a standard is a protection to them in courtship, an ever-present influence inducing them to refrain from doing anything which may prevent their going to the temple to have their love [sealed] in an enduring and eternal union. It will lead them to seek divine guidance in the selecting of their companions, upon the wise choice of whom their life's happiness here and hereafter is largely dependent. 'Our home joys . . . are the most delightful earth affords, and the joy of parents in their children is the most holy joy of humanity. It makes their hearts pure and good; it lifts them up to their Father in heaven.' Such joys are within the reach of most men and women if high ideals of marriage and home be properly fostered and cherished" (*Gospel Ideals* [Salt Lake City: Improvement Era, 1953], p. 462).

Goodly parents

As a marriage is blessed with children, we realize even more the necessity of teaching and training in the family. We recall the words of Nephi at the beginning of the Book of Mormon as he said, "I, Nephi, having been born of goodly parents" (1 Nephi 1:1).

What a blessing it would be to have it said of all fathers and mothers that they were goodly parents, righteous parents, active parents, faithful parents, exemplary parents, celestial parents. Then Nephi goes on further to say, "I, Nephi, having been born of goodly parents, therefore I was taught somewhat in all the learning of my father" (1 Nephi 1:1).

Nephi was taught in the ways of the gospel by his father, Lehi. It was this good father, Lehi, who in a dream saw the tree of life whose fruit was most desirable to make one happy. When he partook of the fruit of the tree, he knew

it was desirable above all other fruit. After partaking, his first thought was of his family. And he said, "I began to be desirous that my family should partake of it also" (1 Nephi 8:12).

Lehi wanted more than anything else for his family to partake of the blessings of life—eternal life.

We have another good example in Enos, the son of Jacob, for he also came from a good home:

"I, Enos, knowing my father that he was a just man—for he taught me in his language, and also in the nurture and admonition of the Lord. . . .

"And the words which I had often heard my father speak concerning eternal life, and the joy of the saints, sunk deep into my heart.

"And my soul hungered" (Enos 1:1, 3-4).

Praise be to the father and mother who bestow the blessings of a good name, a noble heritage, and a testimony of the gospel, and who teach their children obedience to the Lord.

Family foundations

We have just enjoyed two special events in our family this year. The first was the privilege of participating in a priesthood ordinance as our first grandson received the Aaronic Priesthood. How proud I was of Terry as he presented himself fully prepared for this occasion.

The second was just a few weeks ago when a new little granddaughter was blessed. As the circle formed, I looked down on bright, beautiful, little Cami and thought how precious and sweet she is.

On both occasions I listened to beautiful blessings pronounced by my two sons-in-law. They were blessings of love, gratitude, faith, understanding, and hope, using the power of the priesthood, which each is worthy to hold.

In the circles which were formed to participate in these events were relatives who had made a great effort by traveling many, many miles over snow-

covered roads to be with us for these occasions.

To build a foundation strong enough to support a family in our troubled world today requires the best effort of each of us—father, mother, brother, sister, grandmother and grandfather, aunts and uncles, cousins, and so on. Each must contribute energy and effort in driving piles right down to the bedrock of the gospel until the foundation is strong enough to endure through the eternities. The Lord has promised us in the Doctrine and Covenants that “he that buildeth upon this rock shall never fall” (D&C 50:44).

To strengthen family

Build traditions in your families that will bring you together, for they can demonstrate your devotion, love, and support for one another. For each of the members of your family, these events would include blessings of children, baptisms, other priesthood ordinances, graduations, missionary farewells, homecomings, and, of course, marriages. If distance, missions, or ill health prevent personal reunions, write one of those special letters that will be treasured in family histories. Sharing these occasions as a family will help us build a foundation established upon a rock.

Does this not lend great strength in any family? It is so essential that we build homes that are strengthened by the support of an extended family. “Honour thy father and thy mother” (Exodus 20:12). If we show love for our parents, we will, in turn, be teaching our children love and respect in the family unit.

Continue building lasting, loving relationships for all family members. Listen to one another, be united, work together, play together, pray together, study together. Live celestial principles together, serve the Lord together. Find those precious teaching moments with one another. Don’t let them slip through your fingers, but feed and nur-

ture these special occasions. Never let golden opportunities go by in your relationships with your family members that will help build eternal principles.

Work and search and train

The Lord has declared in the Doctrine and Covenants, “I have commanded you to bring up your children in light and truth” (D&C 93:40).

Jesus, as He appeared to the Nephites, instructed them to “pray in your families unto the Father, always in my name, that your wives and your children may be blessed” (3 Nephi 18:21).

“And if ye shall always do these things blessed are ye, for ye are built upon my rock.” (3 Nephi 18:12.)

These are wise words from the book of Proverbs: “Train up a child in the way he should go: and when he is old, he will not depart from it” (Proverbs 22:6). If we want an eternal family, we must work for it. It does not come by chance.

Let us each day search from the scriptures and from the prophets that which it takes to make an eternal family. The scriptures that are never read will never help us. If read, the words of God will nourish our souls and carry us to great heights in our endeavors to build and excel in our family life. Oh, how I desire that every Latter-day Saint child could say as Nephi of old, “Having been born of goodly parents, therefore I was taught.”

Yes, I was taught in the ways of my father the gospel of Jesus Christ, taught to obey the commandments of God, taught to walk in the ways of an eternal family, taught to walk in light and truth, taught to build my life on a sure foundation as a child of God.

Brothers and sisters, God lives! Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, the sure foundation upon which all else is built, for He is the cornerstone. Of this I bear solemn witness to you in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Benson

Elder L. Tom Perry, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, has just spoken to us.

We shall now hear from Elder John Sonnenberg who was sustained

for the first time last conference as a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy. He will be followed by Elder F. Arthur Kay who also was sustained for the first time last conference as a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

Elder John Sonnenberg

Testimony and calling

I would like to preface my remarks by bearing my testimony and telling you that I know this church is true, that Jesus is the Christ, and that we are led by prophets of God.

October 3, 1984, began as an ordinary day. The sun rose, the colors of autumn sprinkled the Midwest, and it appeared as the garden spot of the nation. The day was somewhat uneventful until the telephone rang. "Elder Sonnenberg?" the voice inquired, and then intoned, "The office of the First Presidency is calling. President Hinckley would like to speak with you."

After a brief exchange of kindnesses, he invited me to become a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy and a General Authority. It has been, and yet remains, overwhelming. The day took on new meaning and an entirely different dimension in my life as I pondered the challenge and invitation. I will do my best and serve with all my heart. My lovely wife and children and their wonderful families surely sustain me, as they have always done.

Invitation of the Master

Men's lives have been clearly and completely changed by such invitations from men of God. This acceptance was acknowledged by asking when and where the Lord would have me go.

Men and women the world over are invited each day to come and join

with us. The Savior invited men to "come, follow me" (Luke 18:22). It was not an ordinary invitation—to follow Jesus. The commitment had everlasting and eternal consequences. Peter was invited to "launch out into the deep" (Luke 5:4). He was a strong, suntanned, ordinary fisherman until he was invited "to let down [the] nets" (Luke 5:4). Thereafter he would never be the same because the Savior was steering his soul more than the ship. Yes, he was an ordinary fisherman until he heard the voice of Jesus and accepted His invitation.

Another time Peter was invited to walk on the water, and when he couldn't continue he learned that when our faith falters we fail. (See Matthew 14:28-31.) Accepting the invitation requires unconditional faith.

To be as He is

In the presence of arrogant and angry men who were eager to accuse, the Master inscribed in sand and dust that which is now cast in concrete. The crowded courtyard of anxious accusers was cleared, and a sinner was saved from stoning because the Savior was interested in the person more than the problem. (See John 8:3-11.) He invited us to not judge, and then He demonstrated that forgiveness fosters love and that casting stones simply wouldn't solve the problem or bring about a solution.

If we are to be as He is, we must be as He was. We must even invite with interest those who show disin-

terest and hope that somehow they will recognize the divine discourse described as a testimony.

He invited us to seek after the singular sheep that was lost. He made us to understand that a lost sheep is really a lost soul that we need to seek and search for, that a lost coin is one who needs to be counted and then converted, and that a prodigal son is one that can be saved by serving and then giving service himself.

He invited little children to come unto Him and each of us to become as one of them. He invited men to love one another as He has loved us, and then He would call them His disciples. He extended His love to his Apostles on condition that they understood what unconditional love for their fellowman was.

He invites men to receive the priesthood of God and to magnify it by service. He invites us to pay our tithing and fast offering, to teach the gospel, and to be baptized, and receive the Holy Ghost. And He invites us to preach the gospel in all the world because we are a worldwide church.

Last month my faithful and youthful companion, Timmy Manners, and I did our home teaching. Sixteen-year-old Timmy was born in the British Isles, I was born in the DDR [German Democratic Republic], and we teach a family from France. We visit them in Germany, and speak English—and we all understand each other.

Each of our families was converted to this, the Lord's true church,

by dedicated missionaries in different lands. We were taught by the sweet Spirit of the Lord. As we meet monthly in the lovely home of Jean Collin and his wonderful family, we have the opportunity to enlighten one another in our home teaching visit by that same sweet Spirit.

We invite the Spirit of the Lord on bended knee in the attitude of prayer. On this wise shall ye pray. What an invitation to communicate in the name of Christ! We are invited to cry repentance and bear our testimony, and then as a crown of commitment He allows us to go to His Holy House and be sealed for eternity.

Before 1830, April 6 was also just an ordinary day. Since the coming of the Book of Mormon and the organization of His church, the Spirit of the Lord has touched men and women around the world. Apostles and prophets and fellow Saints have borne witness of the divinity of the restoration of the gospel. Light, knowledge, and truth have been restored, and the Spirit of the Lord has been felt by members of His Church.

My beloved brothers and sisters, I testify that the Book of Mormon is true, that Jesus is the Christ and that Spencer W. Kimball is a prophet of God, and I invite you to follow them and enjoy the Spirit of the Lord, in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

Elder F. Arthur Kay spoke without further announcement.

Elder F. Arthur Kay

My beloved brothers and sisters, words are so inadequate to express the deep and tender feelings of my heart as I stand at this pulpit, which has been hallowed by the prophets of God and their associates, the General Authorities of the Church. Yes, "holy men of God spake as they were moved by the

Holy Ghost" (2 Peter 1:21), for "they spake the word of God with boldness" (Acts 4:31).

I love and revere these valiant servants of our Heavenly Father and feel honored and very humbled to be numbered among them.

Testimony of the prophets

I come to this calling knowing that God lives—that he is our Father, that Jesus Christ is the very Son of God, our Savior and the Redeemer of the world. I say, as did Job:

“For I know that my redeemer liveth, and that he shall stand at the latter day upon the earth:

“And though after my skin worms destroy this body, yet in my flesh shall I see God:

“Whom I shall see for myself” (Job 19:25–27).

I know that Joseph Smith was a prophet, called of God, an instrument in His hands to restore the gospel in its fullness.

The accounts of the marvelous manifestations and experiences of his youth, and throughout his life, have always been very real to me. I have identified with him as if they had almost been experiences of my own.

I sustain our beloved prophet, Spencer W. Kimball, with all the strength that I possess. I never cease to marvel at the lengthened stride and progress of the Church under his inspired leadership and that of his noble associates.

I express special appreciation to President Gordon B. Hinckley this day for his great and dedicated service at this time in the history of the Church.

To strengthen others

Now, the great desire of my heart is to always be found in step and in unity with the Brethren and to be in harmony with the revealed word and will of God, for I know that obedience is the first law of heaven and the first law of his kingdom here on earth.

Therefore, I desire to do well that which is assigned to me, wherever and under whatever circumstances. “I’ll go where you want me to go, dear Lord.” I’ll do what you want me to do. (See *Hymns*, no. 75.)

With all my heart I desire to share my testimony with others of our Fa-

ther’s children—those who may have need of strengthening within the flock, those who may have estranged themselves from God and his Church, or those who may never have heard the glorious gospel message.

My earnest desire is to kindle in their hearts that which burns so deeply and strongly within my own, that they, too, may have the peace, the happiness, the security, and the spiritual strength that gospel living brings.

As President Kimball has said of truth and of testimony, it “is the electric light illuminating the cavern; the wind and sun dissipating the fog. . . . It is much more than all else, for . . . ‘this is life eternal, that they might know thee the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent.’ (John 17:3.)” (*Faith Precedes the Miracle* [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1972], p. 14).

Testimony, like the widow’s cruse of oil, will not fail (see 1 Kings 17:14), neither be diminished as it is shared; rather, it will be enlarged at its base and renewed at its source.

Joy of service in the temples

With this calling comes the privilege and the blessing and obligation of sharing my testimony as an *especial* witness of Him whose name we bear and in whose image and likeness we were created. (See D&C 107:25.)

I want to kindle in the hearts of our Father’s children a desire to receive the sacred ordinances of His holy house and help them to understand the importance of associated covenants and the necessity of honoring those covenants if they are to have eternal life.

I want to help them understand and appreciate the joy of service in the temples and to understand that service is essential to their salvation. The Savior taught this mighty principle when he said, “Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto me” (Matthew 25:40).

It is in these holy edifices we become Saviors on Mount Zion. (See Obadiah 1:21.) Whenever one serves selflessly, with an eye single to the glory of God (see D&C 59:1), one receives joy unspeakable.

In closing, I wish to express my eternal gratitude to the sweetheart of my youth, my eternal companion, for her long and loyal and faithful service and devotion to that cause which we both espouse. I express my love and devotion to our five daughters, their husbands, our grandchildren, and to my sisters and their families, all of

whom extend to me their confidence and their love. I bear this sacred witness in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Benson

We have just listened to Elders John Sonnenberg and F. Arthur Kay, members of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

Elder Keith W. Wilcox, also sustained for the first time as a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy at October conference, will now address us.

Elder Keith W. Wilcox

Look for the beautiful

Not long ago, President Gordon B. Hinckley, in a commencement address at BYU—Hawaii, admonished graduates to “stop seeking out the storms and enjoy more fully the sunlight” (*Church News*, 3 July 1983, p. 10). He pointed out that we can be negative and look for the ugly in life and the faults and failings of those around us, or we can develop positive attitudes and see the beautiful in life and the good, the strong, the decent, and the virtuous in people, which brings joy and happiness. It is a matter of attitude.

Shortly after beginning three years of service as a mission president, I was reminded of my personal attitude concerning the world and the people in it. One evening I looked up to see my thirteen-year-old daughter walking up to my desk. She stopped and looked intently at me, with her hands on her hips. She finally said, “Dad, I think I have you figured out.” Now she had my complete attention. Then she said, “You have devoted your life to the beautiful, haven’t you?”

I thought for a few moments, and then replied, “Yes, Carole, you do have me figured out. Thank you.”

Beauty in buildings and people

My lovely wife and our six beautiful daughters had long been aware of my interest in the beauty of buildings, as expressed in my practice as a professional architect, and also of my interest in the beauty of this world, as expressed in my landscape paintings. Carole had now correctly concluded that I had an even greater interest in the creation of beautiful people—the type of radiant beauty that comes from righteous living and acceptance of the gospel of Jesus Christ, as taught by our missionaries.

In recent months in traveling to many parts of the world, I have observed this same beauty and spiritual glow in so many of those with whom I have associated.

During these travels I have also observed many types of buildings. More and more I see how buildings and people resemble each other. The most beautiful buildings I have seen are our sacred temples.

The Lord has told us that we can be beautiful, even like a temple. In 1 Corinthians he said, “Know ye not that ye are the temple of God, and that the Spirit of God dwelleth in you?” (1 Corinthians 3:16.)

In 2 Corinthians we read, "For ye are the temple of the living God" (2 Corinthians 6:16).

When the Lord Jesus Christ finalized his immortal Sermon on the Mount, he used a comparison of buildings and people to emphasize the importance of foundations common to both:

"Therefore whosoever heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them, I will liken him unto a wise man, which built his house upon a rock:

"And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell not: for it was founded upon a rock.

"And every one that heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them not, shall be likened unto a foolish man, which built his house upon the sand:

"And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell: and great was the fall of it" (Matthew 7:24-27).

Foundation on which to build our lives

A solid foundation is the most important part of a building or of a person. President Benson has emphasized that in the Sermon on the Mount "we are told to be a light to others, to control our anger, to reconcile bad feelings with others . . . , [and] to love our enemy. . . . We are further instructed how to pray, how to fast, and how to regulate our priorities." (*Come unto Christ* [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1983], p. 37).

As we live the principles of the Sermon on the Mount, we build a rock-solid foundation upon which our lives can safely be constructed.

The Lord, the great Master Architect, has given us perfect plans and specifications to guide us in the building of our lives. These are the sacred scriptures. They contain the words of

the Lord and should be frequently read and pondered.

By seeking the Lord through prayer and through his holy scriptures, we learn to look for the beautiful and to develop positive attitudes. We achieve guidance in the building of our foundations and our lives.

A temple of God

As we live righteous and unselfish lives, the Spirit of the Lord enters our souls and then radiates from us. We become beautiful, even as a holy temple is beautiful. And as missionaries we can help others to become beautiful. "How beautiful upon the mountains are the feet of him that bringeth good tidings" (Isaiah 52:7, Mosiah 12:21, 3 Nephi 20:40).

I leave you my testimony that I know this is the restored Church of Jesus Christ, with a message for all mankind. Jesus is the Christ. We are led by a prophet of the Lord, President Spencer W. Kimball. Our church provides the way for each of us to construct that which is truly beautiful—a Christ-like life, which brings joy and happiness now and into the eternities. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Benson

Elder Keith W. Wilcox, a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy, has just spoken to us.

The choir and congregation will now join in singing "Let Us All Press On," following which Bishop Robert D. Hales, who was sustained this morning as Presiding Bishop of the Church, will address us.

The Choir and congregation sang "Let Us All Press On."

Bishop Robert D. Hales spoke without further announcement.

Bishop Robert D. Hales

My dear brothers and sisters, this is the fourth time that I will be ordained or set apart as a bishop.

In turning to the forty-first section of the Doctrine and Covenants, we find where the first Presiding Bishop was called—Edward Partridge. There it was said that he was a guileless man. Concerning that particular attribute, I would like to say of Bishop Brown, Bishop Peterson, and Bishop Clarke how guileless they are and how well they have served. In searching for a Presiding Bishopric, the Lord and the Brethren go through the kingdom to find three men who would be willing to enter a javelin-catching contest.

To bishops and branch presidents

Bishop Vandenberg, Bishop Simpson, and Bishop Featherstone have been great examples to me over the years. When I was a bishop in a ward, they were serving in the Presiding Bishopric.

If I could give a tribute today at this Easter time to the more than ten thousand bishops and branch presidents throughout the world, I would say how much the office of the bishop embodies the Savior's characteristics. There are great bishops throughout the world. There is something that happens to a man when he becomes a bishop because he learns more than anything else to honor the call. Once a bishop is ordained, he is never released—the reason being that he holds within him the confidences, which will go to the grave with him, for those whom he serves.

Mantle of the bishop

The mantle of the bishop includes being president of the Aaronic Priesthood and president of the priests quorum, being a common judge in Israel, being presiding high priest, assisting in temporal matters, providing for the welfare of the Saints through auxilia-

ries and priesthood councils, and being responsible for tithes and offerings.

Have you ever wondered about this mantle which comes upon a bishop? He can sit in a sacrament meeting and look out at his flock and know who is in trouble, look at his Aaronic Priesthood—the deacons, the teachers, and the priests—and know which ones need his counsel. There is a hopeless feeling when you are released as a bishop to become a General Authority, and then return to your home ward where you have been serving and realize you have lost the power of discernment with the ward members. You can't do what you did as a bishop.

We think of the disciples waiting outside the Garden of Gethsemane and not having the discerning nature to know what the Savior was going through. And yet, the Savior himself embodied that characteristic which a bishop and all of us should have. He said, "What, could ye not watch with me one hour?" (Matthew 26:40). They did not understand.

Sometimes, experience is the best teacher of discernment. We are reminded of President Harold B. Lee having to lose his sweet companion so that he might understand the agony and anguish of a single person who has lost his or her companion, turning his attention as a prophet to the singles of the Church. It is in moments like this that we learn.

Learn from others

I remember, too, my mother as she went through eight years of being paralyzed. The last year and a half she needed care around the clock, and my dear father cared for her. One night, a few weeks before she passed away, I knelt at her bed after a word of prayer and she said, "I would like to go to heaven to see Papa."

I said, "Mother, why have you gone through this pain?"

She said, "To learn patience."

"Mother, have you learned enough patience?"

Then, with a mother's kind way of teaching, she looked at me and said, "I have, but have you?"

At such moments you begin to understand that the difficulties and problems of others, if we will feel them, will make us grow, if we will but lend a hand.

Lives of the Saints

There are many priesthood leaders here from all over the world. These stake presidents, Regional Representatives, and General Authorities know the truth of the counsel once given us by one of the Presiding Bishops of this dispensation, Elder LeGrand Richards. After a weighty discussion in the temple with all the General Authorities, he said, "Now, Brethren, I understand all that we discussed, but until the bishops move, nothing will happen. Everything above the bishop is all talk." He taught a great lesson.

Each priesthood leader who is here this day must go home and make sure the bishops understand the messages which we have heard, for it is in their interviews with the youth, it is in their interviews in calling the people to positions, it is in their compassion for the needy and the widows that the important spiritual things happen in the lives of the Saints. The bishop who utilizes the resources at his hands—the auxiliaries, the priesthood—to fulfill the needs of his people, is a true bishop, not one who follows slavishly a handbook to the detriment of his people.

Turn to your bishop

Having said this, I would like to ask the youth and adults who are here, and all within the sound of my voice, that every night and morning you pray for your bishop. He needs your help. He cannot carry the responsibilities on his shoulders without your help and prayers.

The story is told of the young child who misbehaved in sacrament meeting. Father and Mother were embarrassed by his actions. Finally, Father was a little disturbed and took the child out. As he went down the aisle, he gave the child a little squeeze. The child knew he was in trouble. As the father turned to go out of the chapel, the child, now up over his father's shoulder, said, "Bishop, help me!"

All members of the Church can turn to their bishops when they are in need of help and can feel secure in his love for them and can have confidence in following his counsel. Bishops learn not to judge people against a standard of perfection. A bishop learns that he will rejoice with those over whom he presides in any progress they make.

In the forty-first section of the Doctrine and Covenants, on that day when Edward Partridge was called, the superscription says, "The members were striving to do the will of God so far as they knew it." And that's true today. We strive to do the Lord's will so far as we know it. The section goes on to say that the Lord asks us to assemble ourselves together to agree upon his word. (See D&C 41:2.) If we do that, there will be unity. That unity has been here today. May the Lord's blessings continue, that "by the prayer of your faith," as the Lord promises, "ye shall receive my law, that ye may know how to govern my church and have all things right before me" (D&C 41:3).

We stand at the Jordan

In conclusion, let's turn to the story of Elijah and Elisha. Elijah had gone from his duties to go up to a cave. The Lord came to him, and he was called to go back to his duties. He had not had a convert for some period of years, but when he went back he found Elisha, who immediately followed him. (See 1 Kings 19.)

They dwelt and worked together for a few years until the time came when all the priesthood leaders knew

that it was time for Elijah to be translated. Elijah and Elisha stood at the banks of the River Jordan. Fifty other priesthood holders stood in view far off as the two stood by the Jordan. "And Elijah took his mantle, and wrapped it together, and smote the waters, and they were divided hither and thither, so that they two went over on dry ground." And Elijah said to Elisha, "Ask what I shall do for thee." Can you imagine? Then Elijah was translated and departed in a flaming chariot, and the only thing that was left was his mantle. Elisha picked up the mantle, then turned toward the fifty priesthood leaders who were standing afar off. He had to return over the river, so he picked up the cloak, smote the River Jordan, and it parted. (See 2 Kings 2:1-15.)

I now stand at the Jordan with two sweet counselors, Bishop Eyring and Bishop Pace, as we attempt to cross the River Jordan to serve together. I ask for the blessings of Bishop Brown, Bishop Clarke, and Bishop Peterson, and all those who are here, that my counselors and I might also have that river part so we may return and go about our mission.

Bishop Pace said to me when he received his call, "You don't know me that well." My response was, "No, but the Lord does." Bishop Eyring and I have known each other since boyhood. He is a man of God. Sitting in this audience today is Wilber Cox. Both Bishop Eyring and I have served as

counselors to him in a stake presidency. He molded us in a way in which we have been blessed.

I appreciate being taught by the example of my mother and father. Mother, for fifteen years, was a Relief Society president. After I received my driver's license, she had me drive her to deliver the welfare supplies and care for the needy. Father would always have me polish the sacrament trays when I was a deacon, and we would bring them home and wash the sacrament cloths and honor the priesthood. When he was in the bishopric, he took care of the outside of the building; and we, as Aaronic Priesthood boys, assisted him.

May the Lord's blessings be with each and every one of us. It is my testimony that God lives, that Jesus is the Christ. Of this I have no doubt. I give you my testimony with those who have prophesied this day. As I look into their eyes and feel the love I have for them, I ask that we might be able to work together in harmony. I say this in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Benson

Bishop Robert D. Hales, the new Presiding Bishop of the Church, has just addressed us.

Elder James E. Faust, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, will now address us. He will be followed by Elder Boyd K. Packer, also a member of the Council of the Twelve.

Elder James E. Faust

Christian and disciple

In World War II, I was in a military hospital in Africa for a few days with a respiratory infection. The hospital was staffed with native orderlies who were to keep the hospital clean, change the beds, and generally be of help to the patients. Because of the prevalence of malaria and its carrier,

the mosquito, we slept under large mosquito nets which hung from the ceiling and covered the whole bed. One night as I went to bed I slipped my wallet under my pillow and drifted off to sleep.

Some time later in the night I was awakened and started to feel some hands slipping under my bedclothes. I suspected that a thief was after my wal-

let. I instinctively grabbed one of the hands and switched on the light. My wallet slipped out from under the pillow. To my surprise, I held the arm of the native boy who was the orderly assigned to clean my room. All he said in defense of his action was, "Don't worry. I am a disciple." He could tell from the look on my face that I did not understand. In further explanation, he said simply, "I am a disciple. I am a Christian. I do not want your purse. I was only tucking the mosquito netting around your bed to protect you from the mosquitoes while you slept." I came to know that this young man was not only a Christian, he was a disciple.

True disciples believe, act, speak, know

True disciples are those who go beyond simply believing. They act out their belief. Said the Savior, "If any man will *do his will, he shall know of the doctrine*, whether it be of God, or whether I speak of myself" (John 7:17; italics added). Disciples follow the Divine Master. Their actions speak in symphonic harmony with their beliefs. They know who they are. They know what God expects of them. They mirror inner peace and certainty concerning the mission and resurrection of Christ. They hunger and thirst after righteousness. They know they are here on this earth for a purpose. They understand life after death. They believe that the transcendent event in the ministry of the Christ was the Atonement, culminating in the Resurrection.

The prophet Ether says that a disciple may with "surety hope for a better world, . . . which hope cometh of faith, maketh an anchor to the souls of men, which would make them sure and steadfast, always abounding in good works" (Ether 12:4).

Divine gift

I should like on this afternoon before Easter to testify concerning the surety of hope all disciples may have

through the resurrection of the Christ. The resurrection of Jesus is one of the greatest messages of all Christianity. It is a divine gift of the Atonement for all mankind. The idea that one who has died can live again was so unprecedented, so foreign to all human experience, that even the Apostles, who had been told it would happen, could hardly believe it.

When Mary Magdalene, Joanna, Mary (the mother of James), and the other women told the Apostles that they had seen the resurrected Lord, "their words seemed to them as idle tales, and they believed them not" (Luke 24:11; see also Matthew 28:9-10).

Nevertheless, Peter and John must have experienced a confirmation of the Spirit that the women's testimony was not to be ignored. John testified that Peter and John literally ran to the sepulchre to see for themselves. They found that the tomb was empty, just as the women had said, except for the linen burial clothes. (See John 20:3-10.) Peter departed "wondering in himself at that which was come to pass" (Luke 24:12).

Witnesses of the miracle

As Mary stood without the sepulchre weeping, she was addressed by an apparent stranger with two ever-so-tender, compassionate questions: "Woman, why weepest thou? whom seekest thou?" In her grief and blinded by tear-filled eyes, she pleaded with the stranger, whom she supposed to be the gardener, "Sir, if thou have borne him hence, tell me where thou hast laid him, and I will take him away."

"Jesus saith unto her, Mary. She turned herself" (John 20:15-16).

One, only one, person could speak her name that way. With that single word all doubt, confusion, and uncertainty was swept away. Mary, in that instant, came to the grand, sublime realization that He for whom she mourned, even Jesus that was crucified, had risen from the dead, just as the

angels early that very morning had testified, "He is risen." (See Luke 24:6.)

Mary was not to be the only witness of the miracle of the Resurrection. Although the Savior was the "first-fruits" of them that slept (1 Corinthians 15:23), the scriptures testify that "many bodies of the saints which slept arose, and came out of the graves after his resurrection, and went into the holy city, and appeared unto many" (Matthew 27:52-53).

Jesus appeared to two followers in Emmaus whose "eyes were holden that they should not know him" (Luke 24:16), and they entreated him: "Abide with us: for it is toward evening, and the day is far spent. And he went in to tarry with them" (Luke 24:29). As Jesus ate with them, their eyes were opened, and they knew him.

Upon his first appearance to the ten Apostles following the Resurrection, they were terrified and thought they had seen a spirit, and he comforted them by saying, "Behold my hands and my feet, that it is I myself: handle me, and see; for a spirit hath not flesh and bones, as ye see me have."

"And when he had thus spoken, he shewed them his hands and his feet" (Luke 24:39-40).

Thomas was absent, and when the others told him of Jesus' resurrection, his response was disbelief: "Except I shall see in his hands the print of the nails, and put my finger into the print of the nails, and thrust my hand into his side, I will not believe." At his next appearance a week later, Christ said to Thomas: "Reach hither thy finger, and behold my hands; and reach hither thy hand, and thrust it into my side: and be not faithless, but believing."

"And Thomas answered and said unto him, My Lord and my God" (John 20:25, 27-28).

And so for forty days the Savior ministered to his Apostles and other disciples and taught them.

During these forty glorious days, Christ was also "seen of above five hundred brethren at once; of whom the greater part remain unto this

present. . . . After that, he was seen of James; then of all the apostles." Paul adds, "And last of all he was seen of me" (1 Corinthians 15:6-8).

Latter-day witnesses

Latter-day Saints have additional witnesses of the reality of the resurrection of Jesus Christ and of the certainty of life after death. One of these witnesses is the Book of Mormon, a record containing the ministry of the resurrected Christ upon the American continent after his death and resurrection in Jerusalem. The appearance was preceded by a voice as if it came out of heaven: "And it was not a harsh voice, neither was it a loud voice; nevertheless, and notwithstanding it being a small voice it did pierce them that did hear to the center . . . ; yea, it did pierce them to the very soul, and did cause their hearts to burn" (3 Nephi 11:3).

The voice announced, "Behold my Beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased, in whom I have glorified my name. . . ."

"And behold, they saw a Man descending out of heaven; and he was clothed in a white robe; and he came down and stood in the midst of them; and the eyes of the whole multitude were turned upon him" (3 Nephi 11:7-8).

He stretched forth his hand and said, "Behold, I am Jesus Christ, whom the prophets testified shall come into the world" (3 Nephi 11:10). And he invited the multitude: "Arise and come forth unto me, that ye may thrust your hands into my side, and also that ye may feel the prints of the nails in my hands and in my feet, that ye may know that I am the God of Israel, and the God of the whole earth, and have been slain for the sins of the world" (3 Nephi 11:14).

The testimony of modern witnesses is also recorded in the Doctrine and Covenants. The Prophet Joseph Smith and Sidney Rigdon testified:

"And now, after the many testimonies which have been given of him, this is the testimony, last of all, which we give of him: That he lives!

"For we saw him, even on the right hand of God; and we heard the voice bearing record that he is the Only Begotten of the Father—

"That by him, and through him, and of him, the worlds are and were created, and the inhabitants thereof are begotten sons and daughters unto God" (D&C 76:22-24).

The glorified appearance of Jesus Christ in the temple in Kirtland, Ohio, was described by the Prophet Joseph Smith as follows:

"His eyes were as a flame of fire; the hair of his head was white like the pure snow; his countenance shone above the brightness of the sun; and his voice was as the sound of the rushing of great waters, even the voice of Jehovah, saying:

"I am the first and the last; I am he who liveth, I am he who was slain; I am your advocate with the Father" (D&C 110:3-4).

Joseph Smith also testified of the appearance of the Father and the Son to him as a young boy: "When the light rested upon me I saw two Personages, whose brightness and glory defy all description, standing above me in the air. One of them spake unto me, calling me by name and said, pointing to the other—*This is My Beloved Son. Hear Him!*" (Joseph Smith—History 1:17).

What is the resurrection?

What, then, is the resurrection? A very good description comes from the Book of Mormon; the prophet Alma explains that Christ loosed the bands of temporal death for all of us.

"All shall be raised from this temporal death.

"The spirit and the body shall be reunited again in its perfect form; both limb and joint shall be restored to its proper frame . . . ; and we shall be brought to stand before God, knowing

even as we know now, and have a bright recollection of all our guilt.

"Now, this restoration shall come to all, both old and young, both bond and free, both male and female, both the wicked and the righteous; and even there shall not so much as a hair of their heads be lost; but every thing shall be restored to its perfect frame, as it is now. . . .

"And also concerning the resurrection of the mortal body. I say unto you that this mortal body is raised to an immortal body, that is from death, even from the first death unto life, that they can die no more; their spirits uniting with their bodies, never to be divided; thus the whole becoming spiritual and immortal" (Alma 11:42-45).

The members of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints believe in universal salvation as well as individual salvation. We believe that through the Resurrection and Atonement there will be a resurrection of both the just and the unjust: "For as in Adam all [men] die, even so in Christ shall all be made alive" (1 Corinthians 15:22).

Jesus of Nazareth—the resurrected Savior

How do we accept Jesus of Nazareth?

We joyfully accept him without reservation as the greatest personage who ever lived on the face of the earth.

We believe him to be the Messiah, the Redeemer.

We glory in his mission and his doctrine.

We delight in him as the firstfruits of them that slept.

We worship him as the second member of the Godhead of three.

We humbly come to the Father through him, believing his words. "I am the way, the truth, and the life: no man cometh unto the Father, but by me" (John 14:6).

A hallmark of a disciple is described in the words of the Master: "By this shall all men know that ye are my

disciples, if ye have love one to another" (John 13:35).

We can ask, with Job, the age-old question, "If a man die, shall he live again?" (Job 14:14). And the answering testimony is that Jesus Christ made the resurrection possible:

"For I know that my redeemer liveth, and that he shall stand at the latter day upon the earth:

"And though after my skin worms destroy this body, yet in my flesh shall I see God" (Job 19:25-26).

We testify with Isaiah that "his name shall be called Wonderful, Counsellor, The mighty God, The everlasting Father, The Prince of Peace" (Isaiah 9:6). Of the Resurrection we can declare with Paul: "O death, where is thy sting? O grave, where is thy victory?" (1 Corinthians 15:55.)

With the abundance of testimony, both ancient and modern, sealed by the witness of the Holy Spirit of God, we

stand firm and unequivocating in our knowledge that Jesus of Nazareth is the resurrected Savior. His arms are stretched forth to all men, including my native friend in Africa, who, by accepting Him in His appointed way, may become not just believers but true disciples and with Paul hope to "obtain a better resurrection" (Hebrews 11:35).

To all we say, "May Christ lift thee up, and may . . . the hope of his glory and of eternal life, rest in your mind forever" (Moroni 9:25). In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Benson

We have just heard from Elder James E. Faust, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles.

Elder Boyd K. Packer, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, will be our concluding speaker.

Elder Boyd K. Packer

Brethren and sisters, I had in mind speaking on another subject today.

However, during the last few days, I have had pressing upon me, by inspiration as I believe, the feeling that I should present some counsel on another subject.

Ordained by one having authority

I have here in my hand a most interesting document. Let me quote from it: "To whom it may concern:

"This certifies that *Parley P. Pratt*, has been received into the church of the Latter Day Saints, . . . and has been ordained an elder according to the rules and regulations of said church, and is duly authorized to preach the gospel, agreeably to the authority of that office. . . .

"Given by the direction of a conference of the elders of said church, assembled in Kirtland, Geauga

County, Ohio, this 26th day of *April*, in the year of our Lord one thousand, eight hundred, and thirty-five. [Signed] *Joseph Smith Jr. . . . Oliver Cowdery, Clerk*" (Parley P. Pratt Collection, Archives of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, Salt Lake City).

So that you may sense the significance of this document, I quote from the forty-second section of the Doctrine and Covenants:

"I say unto you, that it shall not be given to any one to go forth to preach my gospel, or to build up my church, except *he be ordained by some one who has authority, and it is known to the church that he has authority and has been regularly ordained by the heads of the church*" (D&C 42:11; italics added).

I read that elder's certificate to show that from the very beginning of the Church very careful procedures of authorization have been followed.

It is important that every member of the Church understand that.

The Apostle Paul wrote to Timothy of perilous times and apostasy to come in the last days.

He listed the many evils that would be abroad in those perilous times, such things as false accusers, despisers of those that are good, and traitors, and he warned, "From such turn away" (2 Timothy 3:1-5).

Immunization against evils

"Evil men and seducers shall wax worse and worse, deceiving, and being deceived.

"But continue thou in the things which thou hast learned and has been assured of, *knowing of whom thou hast learned them*" (2 Timothy 3:13-14; italics added).

That phrase, *knowing of whom thou hast learned them*, has great significance.

Paul taught that a knowledge of the scriptures was our immunization against these evils.

Repeating what the Lord said: "Again I say unto you, that it shall not be given to any one to go forth to preach my gospel, or to build up my church, except [one:] *he be ordained by some one who has authority*, and [two:] *it is known to the church that he has authority and has been regularly ordained by the heads of the church*" (D&C 42:11; italics added).

The Church will always be led by those who have been called by the regularly ordained heads of the Church.

Titles in the Church

Now, this does not prevent any member from sharing the gospel in a missionary attitude; that is our duty. There are duties, such as home teaching, and ordinances, such as blessing the sick, which go with the priesthood, and no special setting apart is required. But, for any and every office, there is care to see that anyone given authority receives it from one who has authority

and it is *known to the church* that he has authority.

We sometimes puzzle others with the many titles in the Church. They wonder why we have so many presidents. We have presidents in stakes and missions and quorums and women's auxiliaries.

Each is sustained by the congregations before they are ordained or set apart, and a record is kept of that action.

Bishops receive a certificate of ordination. So do stake and mission presidents and elders and seventies and high priests. It is known to the Church that they have authority.

Identify keys of authority

Once, in company with Elder Gene R. Cook and the mission president, we traveled in a very remote region on the Altiplano, or high plain in Bolivia. We had traveled much of the day in a four-wheel-drive vehicle. We had crossed an arm of Lake Titicaca on an ancient ferry. We followed mountain roads first built by the ancient Incan Indians.

Once, we had to build a stone ramp to emerge from a river bed which formed something of a road in the dry season. Lifting stones at an altitude of more than thirteen thousand feet is no small task.

We came eventually to our destination, Huacuyo. It is really not a village so much as houses scattered about the mountains, as high, I suppose, as men live anywhere on earth.

There we found what we were seeking—a little adobe and stone chapel. The few Saints in the region had built it themselves with no help from the Church.

The distance and forbidding terrain made this, I'm sure, as remote from Church headquarters as any place on earth.

The chapel had a dirt floor and rude hand-hewn benches. The interior walls had been whitewashed. Hanging on the front wall were three pictures:

the President of the Church and his two counselors—the First Presidency.

I repeat the words of Paul:

“Continue thou in the things which thou hast learned, . . . *knowing of whom thou hast learned them*” (2 Timothy 3:14; italics added).

Even in that remote little branch the members could identify those who hold the keys of authority.

Identify general and local authorities

It is not unusual to see pictures of General Authorities in church buildings across the world. These pictures appear in Church publications. Whenever there is a change, new pictures appear. Now, with the sustaining of a new Presiding Bishopric and the calling of other Brethren, their pictures will appear in the news and eventually in chapels across the world.

Those who know me well know that I very much dislike to see pictures of myself displayed. But I endure that, as do the other Brethren, for very good reason.

There is purpose in members of the Church everywhere in the world being able to identify the general and local authorities. In that way they can know of whom they learn.

A few years ago Sister Packer and I were returning from New Zealand. We left Auckland at midnight and landed in Papeete in Tahiti. We waited there for a connecting flight. Just before dawn, a plane landed. It was not the one we were to board. We did not know its route; it was just an airliner landing on that small island in the South Pacific in the wee hours of a Monday morning.

I told my wife, “I will know someone on that plane.” I stood near the gate and as the passengers disembarked, four people, none of whom I had met before, approached me. “Are you Brother Packer?” And near the end of the line was one man I knew.

The point is this. It is manifestly impossible, in Huacuyo, Bolivia, or

Tierra del Fuego, Argentina, in Kemi, Finland, or Vava’U in Tonga or anywhere else on earth, for an imposter to present himself as a member of the Quorum of the Twelve Apostles and not be detected by the members as one who has not been regularly ordained by the leaders of the Church.

Official call and authorized ordination

There are those who claim authority from some secret ordinations of the past. Even now some claim special revealed authority to lead or to teach the people. Occasionally they use the names of members of the First Presidency or of the Twelve or of the Seventy and imply some special approval of what they teach.

There have been too many names presented, too many sustaining votes taken, too many ordinations and settings apart performed before too many witnesses; there have been too many records kept, too many certificates prepared, and too many pictures published in too many places for any one to be deceived as to who holds proper authority. Claims of special revelation or secret authority from the Lord or from the Brethren are false on the face of them and really utter nonsense!

The Lord never operated that way; these things were not done in a corner (see Acts 26:26); there is light on every official call and every authorized ordination, and it has always been that way.

Now, the priesthood is structured so that ordinary men and women and youth are called to work in the Church.

Surely we must appear at times to be very amateurish when compared to the highly schooled clergy of other churches.

The very nature of the priesthood allows for a great variety in the gospel knowledge of members struggling to learn as they serve.

A member, at any given time, may not understand one point of doctrine or another, may have a misconception, or even believe something is true that in fact is false.

There is not much danger in that. That is an inevitable part of learning the gospel. No member of the Church should be embarrassed at the need to repent of a false notion he might have believed. Such ideas are corrected as one grows in light and knowledge.

"From such turn away"

It is not the *belief* in a false notion that is the problem, it is the *teaching* of it to others. In the Church we have the agency to believe whatever we want to believe about whatever we want to believe. But we are not authorized to teach it to others as truth.

If someone approaches you individually or invites you to very private meetings, claiming to have some special calling, whatever you do, follow Paul's counsel—"from such turn away."

They may claim special revelations and callings. They may claim visions and visitations. But where, pray tell me, can they claim the sustaining vote of the membership? In the revelation on organization and Church government given in 1830, the Lord said:

"No person is to be ordained to any office in this church, where there is a regularly organized branch of the same, without the vote of that church" (D&C 20:65).

There is another area where caution means safety. There are some who, motivated by one influence or another, seek through writing and publishing criticisms and interpretations of doctrine to make the gospel more acceptable to the so-called thinking people of the world.

They would do well to read very thoughtfully the parable of the tree of life in the eighth chapter of 1 Nephi, and to ponder very soberly verse twenty-eight:

"And *after*" [meaning after they were members of the Church] *after* "they had tasted of the fruit they were ashamed, because of those that were scoffing at them; and they fell away

into forbidden paths and were lost" (*italics added*).

If their spirits are pure and their motives worthy, they will do no harm either to themselves or to others. If they are not, we would all do well to follow Paul's admonition and "from such turn away."

Preparation for stakehood

I saw something else on the wall of that little chapel in Huacuyo. It was a rudely printed poster. I could not hold back the tears as I read the heading "preparacion para ser estaca"—preparation for stakehood.

There followed a list of qualifications for a stake of Zion. A stake of Zion there in the remotest village atop the Andes Mountains? Oh, yes! That will be one day. And when it comes, one of us will be there to give authority to the leaders. When a stake of Zion is organized anywhere on earth, a man sitting on this stand must be there to confer the keys of presidency. Only from those who *have the authority* and *it is known to the church that they have authority* can they receive them. There is yet a further witness. Any seeking soul—any member—has the right to know by the gift of the Spirit about the call of our leaders.

Witness of the Spirit

On one occasion I was organizing a new stake on Upolu Island in Samoa. As is customary, we were conducting interviews with local priesthood leaders, asking each to suggest a few names of brethren of stature to be considered for a call.

One dignified branch president had walked from the other side of the island. He stood before us in a white shirt and tie, with a lavalava, or skirt, tied about his waist. He wore no shoes; he had never owned shoes.

I asked for names. He gave but one: "Bishop Iono will be our stake president." He was right, for that had

already been revealed to me. But I did not feel he should make the announcement.

So I asked for other names, for we had counselors and others to call as well. He replied, holding up his finger, "Just one name." "But," I said, "suppose he could not serve, would you not like to name others?" This humble priesthood president then asked me a question, "Brother Packer, are you asking me to go against the witness of the Spirit?"

How marvelous! This wonderful man had reminded me that each member of the Church, in prayer, can receive confirmation that the fifth article of faith has been honored.

"We believe that a man [and this applies to sisters as well] must be called of God, by prophecy, and by the laying on of hands by those who are in authority, to preach the Gospel and administer in the ordinances thereof."

The Lord and his servants

On one occasion, Karl G. Maeser was leading a party of young missionaries across the Alps. As they reached the summit, he looked back and saw a row of sticks thrust in the snow to mark the one safe path across the otherwise treacherous glacier.

Halting the company of missionaries, he gestured toward the sticks and said, "Brethren, there stands the priesthood [of God]. They are just common sticks like the rest of us, . . . but the position they hold makes them what they are to us. If we step aside from the path they mark, we are lost" (in Alma P. Burton, *Karl G. Maeser, Mormon Educator* [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1953], p. 22).

Although no one of us is perfect, the Church moves forward, led by ordinary people.

The Lord promised:

"If my people will hearken unto my voice, and unto the voice of my servants whom I have appointed to lead

my people, behold, verily I say unto you, they shall not be moved out of their place.

"But if they will not hearken to my voice, nor unto the voice of these men whom I have appointed, they shall not be blest" (D&C 124:45-46).

I bear witness, brethren and sisters, that the leaders of the Church were called of God by proper authority, and it is known to the Church that they have that authority and have been properly ordained by the regularly ordained heads of the Church. If we follow them we will be saved. If we stray from them we will surely be lost. That is true of the file leaders down through the ranks of the Church, the heads of quorums and wards, of stakes and missions, and of the prophet, who stands at the head of the Church.

I sustain President Spencer W. Kimball as the prophet of God. I know that he is the prophet of God. I know that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and by His order, and in His order, is the Church moved forward in our generation. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Benson

Elder Boyd K. Packer, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, has been our concluding speaker.

We remind the brethren of the general priesthood meeting which will convene here in the Tabernacle this evening at 6:00 P.M.

The nationwide CBS Radio Tabernacle Choir broadcast tomorrow morning will be from 9:30 to 10:00 A.M. Those desiring to attend this broadcast must be in their seats no later than 9:15 A.M.

The singing for this session has been furnished by a Primary children's choir from the Jordan Utah Region. We are grateful, indeed, for the presence of these beautiful children and for the sweet spirit their music has added to this meeting.

The choir will now sing in closing "Jesus Has Risen" and "He Sent His Son." Following the singing, the benediction will be offered by Elder Derek A. Cuthbert, a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

The choir sang "Jesus Has Risen" and "He Sent His Son."

The benediction was offered by Elder Derek A. Cuthbert.

GENERAL PRIESTHOOD MEETING

THIRD SESSION

The general priesthood meeting convened in the Tabernacle at 6.00 P.M. on Saturday, April 6, 1985.

President Gordon B. Hinckley, Second Counselor in the First Presidency, conducted.

The music for this session was provided by a priesthood choir from Brigham Young University directed by Ronald Staheli and Mack Wilberg with John Longhurst at the organ.

President Hinckley opened this session with the following remarks:

President Gordon B. Hinckley

Brethren, President Spencer W. Kimball is watching the proceedings on television in his apartment. President Romney, likewise, is at home. Both send their greetings and love to you. President Kimball has been with us in both of the general sessions today.

For the information of the brethren in outlying areas, we announce that at the first general session this morning Bishops Victor L. Brown, H. Burke Peterson, and J. Richard Clarke were honorably released as the Presiding Bishopric of the Church and were sustained as members of the First Quorum of the Seventy. Elders Hans B. Ringger, Waldo P. Call, and Helio da Rocha Camargo were also sustained as members of that quorum. Elder Wm. Grant Bangerter was sustained as a new member of the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy. Elder Robert D. Hales was sustained as Presiding Bishop with Henry B. Eyring and

Glenn L. Pace as first and second counselors, respectively.

These services are being relayed by closed-circuit transmission to members of the priesthood gathered in the Assembly Hall and in at least 686 locations in many countries around the world. They are likewise being carried to the Marriott Center on the BYU campus and to over 950 stake centers by satellite transmission.

We extend our greetings and blessings to all the priesthood brethren wherever they may be.

We note that Elders Franklin D. Richards and James M. Paramore are seated on the stand in the Assembly Hall, and Elders Charles Didier and John K. Carmack preside at the BYU Marriott Center.

The singing during this session will be furnished by a priesthood choir from Brigham Young University under the direction of Ronald Staheli and Mack Wilberg, with John Longhurst at the organ.

We shall begin this service with the choir singing "Come, O Thou King of Kings." Following the singing, Elder Robert L. Simpson of the First Quorum of the Seventy will offer the invocation.

The choir sang "Come, O Thou King of Kings."

Elder Robert L. Simpson offered the invocation.

President Hinckley

I would like to recognize this evening a group of young men who are with us, seated in the Tabernacle. They are members of the Dixie College basketball team. Dixie College—for those of you who are across the world—is in Southern Utah, in St. George. And these young men have just won the National Junior College Athletic Association men's basketball championship. The best in the entire nation! Of the squad of twelve, seven are returned missionaries, and two more are preparing to leave for missions. All of the team are here tonight except one, who had to be excused. Their Coach [Neil] Roberts was having difficulty getting here and their Coach [Thomas] Dobrusky could not get here, but I would like to have you young men stand so that at least all of those in the Tabernacle can see you and those across the world can hear about you.

We congratulate you most warmly. You go to a state school but you are a credit to this church. Thank you so very much, and our best wishes to you for continued success! Between this group of basketball and the BYU football players, this is going to be a challenging year in 1985.

The choir will now favor us with "The Priesthood Gift." Following the choir number, President Ezra Taft Benson, President of the Council of the Twelve, will speak to us.

I should say that the president of Dixie College is Alton Wade, who at one time served as president of the Church College of New Zealand, so he has a good background also.

The choir sang "The Priesthood Gift."

President Ezra Taft Benson spoke without further announcement.

President Ezra Taft Benson

My beloved brethren, this is a glorious sight. It's a wonderful occasion to be with you. I'm grateful to see so many fathers here in the Tabernacle with their sons, and I feel assured that this is the case with our unseen audience in many locations throughout the world.

Aaronic Priesthood prepares you to serve

Fathers, your greatest influence with your sons will be your example. If you want your boys to see what the gospel will do for them, let them see what it has done for you.

I want to say a few words to you young men who are here tonight because you hold the priesthood. The Aaronic Priesthood is to prepare you to serve—to serve our Heavenly Father all the days of your life. Most of you

within the sound of my voice are preparing for a mission. Let me suggest four ways that you young men can prepare now for your missions.

Prepare yourselves physically

First, prepare yourselves physically. A two-year mission today requires good physical health. It requires that you keep your body clean. In your early teenage years, when temptations come to you to take things into your body which are unsuitable, have the courage to resist. Live the Word of Wisdom—no smoking, no drinking of any alcoholic beverages, and no drugs. Keep your body pure—a pure vessel for the Lord.

Stay morally clean. This means that you keep a clean mind. Your thoughts will determine your actions, and so they must be controlled. It's

difficult to control those thoughts if you submit yourself to temptation. So you will have to carefully select your reading material, the movies you see, and the other forms of entertainment in order to have good thoughts rather than unwholesome desires.

Prepare yourselves mentally

Second, prepare yourselves mentally. A mission requires a great deal of mental preparation. You must memorize missionary discussions, memorize scriptures, and oftentimes learn a new language. The discipline to do this is learned in your early years.

Establish now the daily practice of reading the scriptures ten to fifteen minutes each day. If you do so, by the time you reach the mission field, you will have read all four of the standard works. I urge you to read particularly the Book of Mormon so that you can testify of its truthfulness as the Lord has directed.

Prepare yourselves socially

Third, prepare yourselves socially. A mission requires that you get along with others. You must get along with your companion, who is with you twenty-four hours a day. You must learn to meet people and be gracious and practice good manners. One of the greatest assets that a person has in life is the ability to make friends. When you make a friend of a person, you can teach him the gospel.

Prepare yourselves spiritually

Fourth, prepare yourselves spiritually. A spiritual person obeys all the Lord's commandments. He prays to our Heavenly Father, and he gives service to others.

Let me talk about obedience. You're learning now to keep all the commandments of the Lord. As you do so, you will have His Spirit to be with you. You'll feel good about yourselves. You can't *do* wrong and *feel*

right. It's impossible! One of the great lessons I learned on my first mission was the principle of total obedience.

A lesson on obedience

In 1923 I was serving a mission in Great Britain. At that time there was great opposition to the Church. It began with the ministers and then spread through the press. Many anti-Mormon articles appeared in the daily press. A number of anti-Mormon movies were shown, and derogatory plays were produced on the stage. The general theme was the same—that Mormon missionaries were in England to lure away British girls and make slaves of them on Utah farms. Today that seems fantastic, but in those days it was very real. In some places we even had to stop tracting because of such misunderstandings.

One time we received a letter from mission headquarters instructing us that we should discontinue all street meetings. At that time I was serving as the conference president, and my companion was the conference clerk. When this instruction arrived, we already had a meeting scheduled for the following Sunday night. So we reasoned that we would hold that meeting and then discontinue street meetings thereafter. That's where we made our mistake!

The next Sunday evening we held our street meeting down near the railway station as scheduled. The crowd was large and unruly. In our efforts to preach to them, my companion and I stood back to back. He spoke in one direction, and I faced the other half of the crowd.

When the saloons closed, the rougher, coarser element came out on the streets, many under the influence of liquor. The crowd became noisy, and those on the outside were not able to hear too well.

Some yelled, "What's the excitement?"

Others yelled back, "It's those dreadful Mormons."

To this, others responded, "Let's get them and throw them in the river."

Soon an attempt was made to trample us under their feet. But since we were taller than the average man there, we put our hands on their shoulders and prevented them from getting us under their feet.

During the excitement, my companion and I became separated. They took him down the far side of the railway station and me down the near side. Things began to look pretty bad.

Then a big husky fellow came up to me as some of the others formed a circle around me about ten feet in diameter. The man looked me straight in the eye and said, "Young man, I believe every word you said tonight!"

By this time a British policeman had worked his way through the crowd. He took me by the arm and said, "Young man, you come with me. You're lucky to be alive in this crowd." He led me several blocks and then ordered, "Now you get to your lodge and don't come out anymore tonight."

When I arrived at the lodge, I found that my companion was not yet there. I worried and then prayed and waited. I became so concerned about him that I decided to disguise my appearance by putting on an old American cap and taking off my topcoat. Then I went out to try to find him.

As I neared the place of the meeting, a man recognized me and asked, "Have you seen your companion?"

I said, "No. Where is he?"

He responded, "He's down on the other side of the railway station with one side of his head mashed in."

This frightened me greatly, and I sprinted to the site as fast as I could. Before I reached the railway station, however, I met the same policeman again. He said, "I thought I told you to

stay in and not come out on the street again tonight."

I replied, "You did, officer. But I'm concerned about my companion. Do you know where he is?"

He replied, "Yes, he got a nasty blow on the side of his head, but he's gone to the lodge now. I walked part-way with him as I did earlier with you. Now you get back there and don't come out anymore tonight."

So I went back to the lodge and found my companion disguising himself in order to go out and look for me. We threw our arms around each other and knelt together in prayer. From that experience I learned always to follow counsel, and that lesson has followed me all the days of my life.

Yes, young men, prepare now. Prepare yourselves physically, mentally, socially, and spiritually. Always be obedient to authority. Start a savings account for your mission if you haven't done so already. Pay your tithing, and seek a testimony of the gospel through study and prayer.

I pray, my young brethren, that our Heavenly Father will bless you with an understanding of how desperately you're needed in His service today.

God bless you to prepare yourselves for future service in His Church, in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

President Ezra Taft Benson, President of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, has just spoken to us.

We have another champion with us tonight, Brother Peter Vidmar, winner of two gold medals and one silver medal at the 1984 Summer Olympics. Peter will now address us. He will be followed by Elder M. Russell Ballard, a member of the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

Brother Peter Vidmar

I've been asked to address my remarks to the young men this evening. It is my humble prayer that I may further instill in them the desire to pursue excellence and to dedicate themselves to serving our Heavenly Father.

Beyond athletics

I am very honored and proud to have represented my country in the 1984 Olympic Games in Los Angeles. Participating in that great competition is an event that I will always cherish and remember. My involvement in gymnastics, however, has taught me qualities that go beyond athletics. The qualities, characteristics, and keys to success in sports are factors that carry over to all other aspects of our lives.

For those of us who, in any way, had the opportunity to view the Olympic Games, we saw the greatest athletes in the world performing at the very best of their abilities. Many of those athletes scored the most points, the fastest times, or the greatest distances in the history of the Olympic Games.

Ingredient for success

But how did they do it? What makes a great athlete? I remember a great Olympic champion who once addressed this question. He named some important factors such as great coaching, good equipment, good athletes to train with, or just pure natural talent. All of these ingredients can go into the recipe for a great athlete, and each will help in its own way. But there is one quality that rises above all, and without it, the athlete is not complete. That ingredient is desire.

The athlete with the greatest desire to succeed will stand a greater chance of reaching his or her goal. The same holds true for the student or the musician or whatever it is that you young men aspire to be. A five-year study of many of the United States' top athletes,

musicians, and scholars has recently concluded that "drive and determination, not great natural talent, led to their extraordinary success" (*Los Angeles Times*, 17 Feb. 1985).

"Do it"

In determined athletes, we can see the difference between knowing and doing. Those who really desire to reach their goals will do whatever they must do in order to achieve them.

Our great prophet, Spencer W. Kimball, has in his office a little motto that simply reads: "Do it." In Matthew 21:28-31 we read:

"But what think ye? A certain man had two sons; and he came to the first, and said, Son, go work today in my vineyard.

"He answered and said, I will not: but afterward he repented, and went.

"And he came to the second, and said likewise. And he answered and said, I go, sir: and went not.

"Whether of them twain did the will of his father?"

Let's not just talk about what we want to be. Let's not just dream about what we want to be. Let's just do it, whatever it takes. To reach your goals, you may have to work harder than you have ever worked before in your entire life.

Work harder than anyone else

My coach taught me a great lesson in my early development as a gymnast. I was leaving for my first national team training camp. Before I traveled to the camp, my coach told me only one thing. He didn't tell me to learn any new maneuvers at the camp. He didn't tell me to try to perform my routines better than the rest of the team. He told me that when I returned from that training camp that he wanted to hear me tell him, with all honesty, that I had worked

harder than anyone else on the national team.

So I remember making it a point to be the last one out of the gym every day; and that didn't mean just waiting at the door for everyone else to leave! Also, I remember that at night, when some team members would occasionally relax with their pizza and beer, I would go back to my room and do more exercises.

When I returned home two weeks later, I was proud to tell my coach, "Yes, I worked harder than everyone else." I didn't work twice as hard, just a little bit harder. But it was enough to help me to improve greatly. Sometimes, just a little bit is all that matters.

Margin of victory

Let's realize what the margin of victory was in a few of the events in last summer's Olympics. In women's cycling, after the 79.2-kilometer race, the difference between the gold medalist and the silver medalist at the finish line was just the length of a tire. In a pressure-packed swimming relay, the difference between the first-place team and second-place team was only .04 of a second. In many of the gymnastics competitions, the difference between first place and second place was as minute as .025 of a point.

The champions didn't win by running twice as fast, by jumping twice as far, or by scoring twice as many points as their opponents. In many cases they won by just a fraction of a second, a fraction of an inch, or a fraction of a point. Likewise, and more important, the champions didn't win by training twice as hard as their opponents. If another gymnast trains six hours a day, I can't train twelve hours a day. Twelve hours a day in a gym just isn't healthy! But I can train six hours and fifteen minutes a day. This is where giving it that little extra and going the extra mile makes the difference.

In whatever you want to improve upon, whether it be schoolwork, athletics, music, or studying the scriptures,

just give a little extra—every day. Fifteen minutes a day for one year add up to over ninety-one hours. I only use fifteen minutes as an example of how time well-spent can add up. I know that I would be a better individual if I applied this more in other important areas of my life. I sincerely hope and pray that I do this.

"Don't quit"

There is another little sign in President Kimball's office. This one reads: "Don't quit." We are all going to have hardships and setbacks. But Heavenly Father will not give us a hardship that we cannot overcome. Behind many Olympic champions are stories of incredible hardships that had to be overcome. Just this past summer, many of us had the opportunity to see an American win his country's first gold medal in Greco-Roman wrestling. We saw this big guy crying tears of joy as he stood on that victory stand. Just two years before, he had undergone a serious operation for a rare form of cancer. He never gave up. Now he is an Olympic champion.

As children of our Father in Heaven, we can have setbacks of sin. But we must never quit or give up hope. Heavenly Father has provided a way to overcome spiritual setbacks through the great gift of repentance. He truly loves us and wants to forgive us. All we have to do is to go through the process of repentance, and we will triumph over our mistakes.

Do your best

I have talked today about pursuing excellence in all areas of our lives. I don't stand here as a shining example of that. I have achieved a wonderful thing in the world of sports. I only pray I can do better in other, more important areas of my life.

I do know of the importance of setting your goals very high, for if you do this, your intermediate goals should be easier to reach. By setting my sights

on the Olympics, I found it easier to become a state or college champion because I always knew I had to improve.

Let's not settle for mediocrity. Let's always try our best. Let us decide now what type of person we want to be, and when a difficult situation comes along we will be prepared to pass the test.

Make proper decisions early

I feel very blessed that at a young age I was taught the importance of keeping the Word of Wisdom. I committed myself to keeping that commandment. I remember a very prestigious competition in Germany, when I won the vaulting event. As I stood on the victory stand, I received a gold medal, flowers, and gifts. I couldn't have been more pleased.

Before walking off of the stand, I noticed another individual coming forward with a silver cup, and I thought, "How great! Another prize!" But as the presenter moved closer with this cup, I noticed it was full of wine.

Turning to my German friend and competitor, I asked what it was for, and he explained that tradition calls for the champion to drink out of the cup and to pass it to the next athlete.

I told him, "Well, I don't drink."

He responded with: "Then just take a little sip and hand it to the next person."

Then I explained, "No, it's against my religion, and I can't even take a sip."

My friend proceeded to explain to the officials in German that I wouldn't drink it, but for some reason they insisted I take the cup.

So I took the cup and held it high in the air for the crowd to see. And then, without taking a sip, I handed it down to the next person. I admit that amidst the laughter of the crowd I felt a bit embarrassed, but I felt proud that it was easy to say no. I believe

that if we make proper decisions before we are faced with a temptation, we will find it much easier to resist that temptation.

Proper perspective on goals

In conclusion, I would like to emphasize keeping a proper perspective on our goals. Let us never lose sight of the gospel in pursuing our temporal ambitions. We didn't come to this world to become Olympic champions, or great doctors, lawyers, or businessmen, or to become rich and famous. We came here to prove ourselves worthy of returning back to the presence of our Heavenly Father. We came here to set and reach the highest goal possible.

I know how hard I worked to compete in the Olympics. At times I trained as much as six hours a day, six days a week. It sometimes seemed it took all of my energy and resources. I think I'm beginning to realize how serious my commitment to the Lord's work must be if I am to receive God's greatest gift. Indeed, it will take all of my talent, energy, and resources—my heart, might, mind, and strength—to earn and receive eternal life.

Just imagine what it's like to be an Olympic champion! Imagine the feeling of having that medal placed around your neck as you stand on the victory platform. It's a feeling I can't describe. But let's realize one more thing. We can all have an experience infinitely greater than that. If we prove worthy, we will return to our Heavenly Father's presence.

I have a testimony of the gospel of Jesus Christ. I know that Christ lives. I know that Spencer W. Kimball is a living prophet of God. I have so much to be thankful for. My temple marriage to my beautiful wife is worth more than all the gold in the world.

I know I have a long way to go, but I pray that I may always improve and someday be found worthy of all the

blessings that Heavenly Father has in store for those that truly serve him, in the name of our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ, amen.

Elder M. Russell Ballard spoke without further announcement.

Elder M. Russell Ballard

Blessings of the holy priesthood

Just fifteen days ago, by assignment, I left Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, which is approximately ten thousand miles from here. The world is very small in some ways. Had I been able to fly directly from Addis Ababa to Salt Lake City, it would have taken approximately nineteen hours. In many other ways, however, the world is very large. Billions of our Heavenly Father's children live upon the earth in all kinds of circumstances; the plight of those who are living in the drought-stricken areas of Africa is disastrous. Human suffering there is almost beyond description. I do not know all the reasons for the suffering. However, this most recent experience in my life has had a profound effect on me. I will never be the same.

I can testify to you, my brethren, that I know as I have never known before that to enjoy the privilege of holding the holy priesthood is a most treasured blessing. If every one of you young men of the Aaronic Priesthood could have been on the mission to Ethiopia with Bishop Glenn Pace and me, your hearts surely would have been filled with the *desire* to honor your priesthood. I do not believe even one of us in this vast priesthood gathering should take for granted the great blessings that we enjoy as bearers of the holy priesthood.

When we arrived in Ethiopia, we found one member of the Church, Brother Harry Hadlock from Seattle, Washington. He was overjoyed to meet two brethren of the priesthood. On Sunday morning, the three of us held a testimony meeting and then, with our

priesthood, blessed and passed the sacrament. The Spirit of the Lord was present. Because we had a deep yearning to help our Father's children who were suffering, we offered a special prayer that rain might come to that drought-stricken area. We felt a deep sense of the importance of our mission. I knew that if we called upon the Lord to bless the land the elements would be tempered. We prayed, brethren, for rain. During the balance of the time we were in Ethiopia it rained every day wherever we traveled. We were grateful to our Heavenly Father because the rain was a special witness to us that he was aware that his sons, bearing his holy priesthood, were about his business in that part of the world.

Training to serve missions

But there was more we could do for them, much more. We have a spiritual gift, the *living waters*, to share. (See John 4:10.) Could we but give them this, they would not thirst thereafter. My brethren, tonight I feel a deep urgency to touch the heart of every boy in the Church that each one might have a *desire* to live worthy to hold the Melchizedek Priesthood and serve a mission. You young men must live worthy to become elders so you can carry the light of the gospel of Jesus Christ to every nation, kindred, tongue, and people as the Lord has commanded us to do. (See Mosiah 15:28.)

The light of the gospel of Jesus Christ is needed desperately in the far reaches of the earth. You young men who are here tonight need to prepare now for your future service. I would ask, which one of you knows what the

Lord has in mind for you to do in the future? May I ask also, which of you may someday sit here in the Tabernacle in these red chairs on the rostrum? As unlikely as it may seem to you young men tonight, all of the General Authorities were boys once, much like you. Even I was your age once. No young man should aspire to a calling, but as surely as you are sitting in this priesthood meeting tonight, many of you will preside over wards, stakes, missions, quorums, and, of course, your own families. Priesthood training, my brethren, starts when a young man is ordained a deacon in the Aaronic Priesthood. You Aaronic Priesthood bearers need to understand that you are in training.

Nephi had a good training plan. I recommend it to all of the boys here tonight: "And it came to pass that I, Nephi, being exceedingly young [he was in his teens], nevertheless being large in stature, *and also having great desires to know of the mysteries of God*, wherefore, I did cry unto the Lord; and behold he did visit me, and did soften my heart that I did believe all the words which had been spoken by my father; wherefore, I did not rebel against him like unto my brothers" (1 Nephi 2:16; italics added). The key, my brethren, was Nephi's *desire* to "know of the mysteries of God." You young men, fill your hearts with this *desire*.

Training for later calls

Of all the training I have received in my Church assignments, none has been more important to me than the training I received as a nineteen-year-old elder serving a full-time mission in the British Isles. As I look back now, I can see that no training in my life was more important for what I am now doing in the Church than the training I received as a full-time missionary.

I am convinced, boys, that the Lord has no better place to get acquainted with you than when you serve him in the mission field. When you are serving your mission, he will send you

on errands to act in his name. He will give you experience with the power of the Holy Ghost. He will authorize you to teach, to convert, and then to perform the sacred ordinances of salvation in his name. He will come to know you. He will come to know that he can trust you and can rely on you. He will help you learn the lessons that will qualify you for the great work that you must perform as you do your part in carrying the message of the Restoration to everyone in the world.

Prompting of Spirit, and goodness of people

On the recent errand to Ethiopia, the Spirit prompted Bishop Pace and me. We knew what to do. We knew what to say. We knew where to go. In many ways, boys, I relived some of my missionary experiences of thirty-four years ago. For example, we needed a permit from the government to travel to Makale to visit the food stations and the distribution centers where tens of thousands of homeless refugees were gathered. When the permit was delayed, desiring to fill our mission, we knelt in prayer and asked the Lord for help. The next morning the permits were issued. Then we needed to get from Addis Ababa to Makale. We again prayed for help and then found passage with a British Royal Air Force mercy flight in a C-130 Hercules transport plane. From Makale, we had no way to travel to Asmara. The Lord knew of our need. Late in the afternoon we hitched a ride with a Swedish Air Force mercy flight. Hitchhiking is not a good idea, and especially not by air, but being on the Lord's errand, it was all right.

I have deep affection for the goodness of people, many of whom I met in far-off Ethiopia, who are not members of the Church but who are giving unselfish Christian service. Brethren, I was so grateful that the Church made a significant contribution to help meet a desperate need. I believe if we had more missionaries in the world, rendering meaningful Christian service and

helping people come to the knowledge of the glorious message of the Restoration, we would find favor with the Lord.

Call every worthy boy to serve mission

I say to you young men tonight, get ready; every one of you, get ready. This world needs your service. Repent if you need to. Study from the standard works every day. Say your prayers morning and night. Develop in your heart a *desire* to know the mysteries of God. To lead the Church tomorrow, you must prepare today. Train hard, boys, and I promise you that you will live to be grateful that you made the effort to prepare.

Now, you young men, may I speak a few words to your bishops and stake presidents? You can listen if you'd like to. The past four days we have enjoyed historic meetings with the mission presidents and their wives from every mission in the Church, along with all of the Regional Representatives, and the stake presidents. We have received instruction from the First Presidency, the Council of the Twelve, and others. We were instructed to *call* every worthy boy to serve a mission. I encourage each of you bishops in the Church to review carefully the roster of boys who are old enough to serve missions so you can extend a call to every one. Don't miss one!

I would like to share with you a personal experience. When I served as bishop many years ago, a fine young man in our ward had fallen in love before being called to serve his mission. He made it known that he was going to get married and would not be available for missionary service. I worried how I was going to approach this young man because I felt an urgency as his bishop to see that he served our Father in Heaven as a missionary. When I invited Doug into my office, I approached him in a different way than I had ever approached a prospective missionary. I was prompted to say, "Doug, the Lord

wants you to serve a mission." Doug said he was not going to serve a mission because he was going to be married. I asked him to get together with his sweetheart and his parents and to fast and to pray. I asked him to come back within a week and tell me what he was going to do about the fact that he had been called to serve the Lord.

One week later, with a great deal of emotion, Doug said to me, "Bishop, we did what you asked us to do. I cannot ignore a call from the Lord. I *desire* to serve. How do I proceed?" Doug served his mission. In fact, he served as a counselor to his mission president. Upon returning, he married his sweetheart. She waited for him—that is not always the case, and it may not always be best that they do—but in Doug's case it worked out. He has since served as a bishop and presently serves as the first counselor in his stake presidency. His mission was one of the most important training periods of his life.

Prepare to serve

May we ask all priesthood leaders, especially you fathers, to help prepare your sons. Prepare them both spiritually and temporally, to look and to act as servants of the Lord.

Now you fine young men of the Aaronic Priesthood, remember: the Aaronic Priesthood is a preparatory priesthood. You are in training. Train hard. Get ready. The Lord needs you. The world needs you. The Church needs you.

A wonderful chorus of missionaries sang to us yesterday these words:

"Called to serve him, heav'nly
King of glory,
Chosen e'er to witness for his
name; . . .
Onward, ever onward, as we glory
in his name."
("Called to Serve," *Sing with Me*,
B-85.)

May God bless all of you young men to desire to serve him is my

humble prayer. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

We have just heard Elder M. Russell Ballard, a member of the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

The choir and congregation will now join in singing "Praise to the Man."

The choir and congregation sang "Praise to the Man."

President Hinckley

I note that most of you in the balcony have taken off your coats. It is warm. If any of the others of you feel to shed your coats, you may feel at liberty to do so. We would like you to be as comfortable as possible.

We shall now be pleased to hear from Elder Marvin J. Ashton, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, following which we shall enjoy seeing and hearing a visual and audio clip featuring President Spencer W. Kimball. This consists of clips taken from previous talks given at this pulpit at past general priesthood meetings.

Elder Marvin J. Ashton

President Kimball: true disciple of Christ

Each time I listen to the voice and words of President Spencer W. Kimball, my testimony that he is indeed a living prophet is reaffirmed with great impact. I bear you my special witness at the outset to that great reality and truth. Through him we have been blessed with continuous guidance and direction in the ways of the Lord. By his example we have learned how to live the Christlike life. From him we have learned the meaning of endurance.

Day after day, trial after trial, President Kimball has set his goals and moved forward and upward, becoming a true disciple of Christ.

We as members of the Church of Jesus Christ have a prophet who has shown us by his daily living the formula for success. By sharing with you tonight some personal experiences I have had with President Kimball, I hope I can encourage all of us to look to his life for inspiration as we set our goals.

President Kimball: minister and servant

When I was ordained an Apostle, Spencer W. Kimball was President of the Council of the Twelve. I remember his saying to me, "Marvin, I am Acting President of the Twelve. Harold B. Lee is President of the Twelve. As long as he is serving as a counselor in the First Presidency and is my senior, I am merely Acting President." He wanted me to understand that. He has always been careful never to assume any role that was not rightfully his. He was indicating also his respect for President Lee and at the same time teaching me. He has always applied Matthew 23:12—"He that shall humble himself shall be exalted."

After one of our lengthy temple meetings, when I had been a member of the Twelve for only a short time, President Kimball took hold of my arm and said, "Will you wait just a few minutes? I want to talk to you." Of course I waited. When we were alone he said, "I don't want the First Presidency or the other members of the Twelve to know,

but I don't feel very good today. Will you please give me a blessing?"

This thought came to my mind immediately: "Here am I, the least and last to be ordained, and he is asking me to give him a blessing."

I was very nervous; I do not remember all that I said, but I shall never forget how pleased I was that he thought enough of me to ask for my assistance. He was asking the newest member to give him a blessing when he could have asked any of the First Presidency or other Apostles.

Why do I love this great man? In his hour of need he was exhibiting love and confidence in me. He has learned the art of making people feel good about themselves. By his actions we know he loves us. "But whosoever will be great among you, let him be your minister; and whosoever will be chief among you, let him be your servant" (Matthew 20:26-27).

Puts himself above no man

Let me tell you another incident that indicates President Kimball looks upon himself as our minister and servant.

A few years ago I was in my office about 6:30 A.M. I am mentioning that so you will know I was there early—it takes some of us a little longer. My phone rang, and as I answered it, I recognized that special voice that said, "Marvin."

I replied, "Yes, President Kimball."

He said, "Could I come up and see you?"

His office is on the first floor, and mine is on the third. (That is the only time I am ever higher than he is.)

My reply was, "President Kimball, if you want to see me, I will be right down."

He then responded with, "Would you do that?"

He did not exhibit any authority. There was no feeling of "Do you know who this is?" or "You'd better come." He courteously asked, "Could I come

up and see you?" When I told him I would be right down, his voice reflected gratitude as he said, "Will you do that?"

I went to his office in a hurry. After we shook hands, he handed me a letter and said, "How would you answer this?"

I read it quickly and said, "President Kimball, you might want to consider this approach," and told him what I thought.

"I agree," he said. "That is my thinking also." He shook my hand, and I was on my way, reflecting about a prophet who asks for counsel and puts himself above no man.

Lesson in counseling, interviewing, and kindness

Another lesson was learned from President Kimball as we visited a prison together.

One day a few years ago President Kimball said, "Marvin, I'd like you to take me to visit the Utah State Prison." He remembered that when I was in charge of the Social Services programs for the Church I had had the responsibility for prisoners.

I said, "President Kimball, I don't want you to go to the prison. I am afraid for your safety. There are some men confined there who would do anything to attract attention by embarrassing, injuring, or insulting you. I just don't want you to go."

That was once when I felt I couldn't grant his request. He took my advice, and we didn't go.

However, about two months later, D. Arthur Haycock, President Kimball's personal secretary, phoned me and said, "Elder Ashton, President Kimball wants you to go to the Utah State Prison with him." The next day we went. My delaying tactic had only lasted a few weeks.

I called Warden Morris and said, "May we come and visit you? We do not want anyone to know of our visit. Could we just meet in your office and not go through the minimum, medium,

or maximum security places? Perhaps you could invite two inmates with whom President Kimball could visit in your office. Later we could look around the grounds and talk with others." He agreeably made the arrangements.

We traveled to the institution, where about a thousand people are incarcerated. Soon into the warden's office came two prisoners. I was impressed with how hard the convicts looked—how mean, how sullen. After they were introduced and sat down, I broke the silence by saying to President Kimball, "Would you like to say a few words to these two men?"

He said, "Yes."

They both looked steadily down at the floor. President Kimball waited, and finally when one raised his head up a little, President Kimball looked directly into his eyes.

Let me just pause for a minute and set the stage. One prisoner had been convicted for murder and the other for manslaughter. Here is a prophet. Here were two hardened criminals. What do you say? What do you do? Do you say, "Aren't you ashamed of yourselves? What a waste for you to be in such a place as this"? Those are things that might cross your mind and mine.

As I mentioned, as President Kimball caught the eye of one of them, he looked at him with a penetrating stare and said, "Tell me about your mother."

This inmate looked up and told him about his mother. Tears came to his eyes as he talked in detail about his mother.

When that was over, President Kimball looked at the other one, who was now paying strict attention. He said, "Young man, tell me what your father does for a living."

The prisoner said, "I do not know where my father is. I never hear from him." And he went on and on talking openly about his family.

I won't tell you the details, but what a lesson in counseling, interviewing, and kindness was being taught by this great prophet. I learned more about

interviewing in those fifteen minutes than in any similar period in my life. No condemnation. No judging. Only displaying a real interest in the person and his circumstances.

He loves everyone

Before our interview was over, somehow the press found out that President Kimball was there. They were at the door and wanted to get into the warden's office for an interview and a picture. I remember one of the inmates said, "Mr. Kimball, could I have my picture taken with you?"

President Kimball responded with "Why don't I stand between the two of you, and we will take all three of us at once."

I did not feel very comfortable with President Kimball standing between those two men in this setting. I had the responsibility for his safety. I had tried to talk him out of it. But he is a disciple of Christ and holds on to the words of God; "I was an hungred, and ye gave me meat: . . . Naked, and ye clothed me: . . . I was in prison, and ye came unto me" (Matthew 25:35-36).

After the pictures were taken, President Kimball looked at one prisoner and then at the other and said, "Thank you for letting me have my picture taken with you." Is there any doubt we love him? He loves everyone. He teaches us the real meaning of Matthew 22:37-40:

"Jesus said unto him, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind.

"This is the first and great commandment.

"And the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself.

"On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets."

Pray to understand enemies

Each week after the Twelve and First Presidency have met in the temple

to take care of current business, we take turns reporting where we have been and what has been accomplished in the way of stake divisions or reorganizations, or missions visited, regional conferences attended, and so on. One week I remember among the Twelve we had been almost everywhere around the globe. President Kimball listened to all of us and then gave his report: "I spent Saturday and Sunday visiting the sick and the homebound." The rest of us who thought we had had a busy and productive weekend realized that a man of God had again taught us a lesson.

Has our prophet taught us anything through his prayers? Very often the Twelve and the First Presidency pray together. When President Kimball takes his turn to be voice, he generally includes this phrase in his prayers: "Bless our enemies. Help us to understand them, and them to understand us." He doesn't ask for vengeance or retaliation, just for understanding so differences can be resolved. Perhaps family differences and neighborhood problems could be resolved if we would follow our prophet's example and pray for patience and forgiveness.

President Kimball once said, just after he became President of the Church, "I thought I knew how to pray before, but now I am really learning how to pray." A man of God knows he cannot reach goals alone. He knows that guidance and help are available through prayer.

Unconditional love

I share these personal experiences to illustrate lessons I have learned from a disciple of Christ. I only do so to encourage myself and you, particularly the Aaronic Priesthood members, to select the traits I have illustrated and incorporate them into your lives. We should list our goals and then work on them consistently, until little by little they become part of us.

This beloved prophet of ours doesn't speak to us much anymore. He has already given us more direction

than most of us are following. So often we are reminded of the sign on his desk that says, "Do it." Yet are we doing all we can to live productive, spiritual lives, with love of God and neighbor at the center of our plans and actions? Have we learned the power and the need of unconditional love? He even shows love to his enemies and many become friends. He has no time for envy, hate, ridicule, or evil speaking. Do we?

Enduring and persistence

Two or three weeks ago this great teacher gave me motivation to try even harder to follow his example. Each Thursday morning after the Twelve have met for two hours, we are joined by the First Presidency to take care of our joint business. When President Kimball comes into the room on the fourth floor of the temple, one by one we go by and shake his hand.

President Kimball, now worn from long years of service, has a difficult time seeing, hearing, and speaking, so when it was my turn, I said, "President Kimball, I am Marvin Ashton." He took my hand, paused, and then finally said softly, "Marv Ashton, I love you." That is all he said to me. What else do I need? I can now go into the world and accomplish all of my assignments more effectively when I realize President Kimball trusts me and loves me.

When I am asked, "What does President Kimball say when he is with you and the others in the temple?" I say, "That is not too important. The thing that is important is that he is there." Despite pain, discomfort, and a tired, worn body, he is there. From him we learn what enduring and persistence are all about.

The fiftieth section of the Doctrine and Covenants gives, I believe, an accurate description of President Spencer W. Kimball: "He that is ordained of God and sent forth, the same is appointed to be the greatest, notwith-

standing he is the least and the servant of all" (D&C 50:26).

Men of God

Now a great counselor is sitting at the side of this wonderful prophet. To him President Kimball has delegated much responsibility. With wisdom and judgment President Gordon B. Hinckley bears a tremendous load as he carries on the myriad tasks the prophet needs to have completed. Week after week President Hinckley sits at the side of the President in the temple, deferring to him, respecting his wishes, carrying on the daily responsibilities of the First Presidency, never assuming authority or becoming obtrusive. There is a

mighty bond between President Kimball, President Romney, and President Hinckley. As they serve together each one teaches us what it means to be united and to be men of God.

I leave you my witness that President Spencer W. Kimball is a prophet, preserved in this day for purposes and occasions such as this. We can reflect, ponder, and be grateful the Lord has given us an extended period in which to enjoy his influence. His life motivates us to set our goals and make our plans to become disciples of Christ such as he. May God help us as priesthood bearers to follow his example, heed his priceless counsel, and share his wisdom and love in our homes, I pray in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Spencer W. Kimball

A videotape presentation followed featuring these extracts from talks given by President Kimball in past general conference priesthood sessions

Extension of family life

"I am happy to be with you here tonight in this priesthood meeting. It is a particular delight to us to see the fathers and their sons coming early to the Saturday night priesthood meeting—many of them an hour or two early to be sure of a good seat, and thousands of others, fathers and sons, hurrying to the Tabernacle and to the numerous stake and ward buildings all over the country. This is a delightful extension of our family life which we celebrate and love and which the world is beginning to recognize as a basic family pattern—to have fathers and sons together.

"We are grateful to have you present, and our appreciation for you is great and our affection sincere" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1974, p. 124; or *Ensign*, May 1974, p. 86).

Stretch souls in service

"We are concerned, brethren, with our need to provide continually significant opportunities for our young men to stretch their souls in service. Young men do not usually become inactive in the Church because they are given too many significant things to do. No young man who has really witnessed for himself that the gospel works in the lives of the people will walk away from his duties in the kingdom and leave them undone" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1976, p. 68; or *Ensign*, May 1976, p. 45).

Make certain decisions only once

"It is most appropriate for Aaronic Priesthood youth, as well as Melchizedek Priesthood men, to quietly, and with determination, set some serious personal goals in which they will seek to improve by selecting certain things that they will accomplish within a specified period of time. Even if the priesthood holders of our Heavenly Father are headed in the right direction, if

they are men without momentum they will have too little influence. You are the leaven on which the world depends; you must use your powers to stop a drifting and aimless world.

"We hope we can help our young men and young women to realize, even sooner than they do now, that they need to make certain decisions only once. I have mentioned at this pulpit before some determinations made early in my life, which decisions were such a help to me because I did not have to remake those decisions perpetually. We can push some things away from us once and have done with them! We can make a single decision about certain things that we will incorporate in our lives and then make them ours—without having to brood and redecide a hundred times what it is we will do and what we will not do" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1976, p. 69; or *Ensign*, May 1976, p. 46).

Promises to self and Heavenly Father

"Let me tell you of one of the goals that I made when I was still but a lad. When I heard a Church leader from Salt Lake City tell us at conference that we should read the scriptures, and I recognized that I had never read the Bible, that very night at the conclusion of that very sermon I walked to my home a block away and climbed up in my little attic room in the top of the house and lighted a little coal-oil lamp that was on the little table, and I read the first chapters of Genesis. A year later I closed the Bible, having read every chapter in that big and glorious book.

"I found that this Bible that I was reading had in it 66 books, and then I was nearly dissuaded when I found that it had in it 1,189 chapters, and then I also found that it had 1,519 pages. It was formidable, but I knew if others did it that I could do it.

"I found that there were certain parts that were hard for a 14-year-old boy to understand. There were some pages that were not especially interest-

ing to me, but when I had read the 66 books and 1,189 chapters and 1,519 pages, I had a glowing satisfaction that I had made a goal and that I had achieved it.

"Now I am not telling you this story to boast; I am merely using this as an example to say that if I could do it by coal-oil light, you can do it by electric light. I have always been glad I read the Bible from cover to cover. . . .

"And I remember that without being pressured by anyone, I made up my mind while still a little boy that I would never break the Word of Wisdom. I knew where it was written and I knew in a general way what the Lord had said, and I knew that when the Lord said it, it was pleasing unto him for men to abstain from all these destructive elements and that the thing I wanted to do was to please my Heavenly Father. And so I made up my mind firmly and solidly that I would never touch those harmful things. Having made up my mind fully and unequivocally, I found it not too difficult to keep the promise to myself and to my Heavenly Father" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1974, p. 126; or *Ensign*, May 1974, p. 88).

Plan your life

"To be sure your life will be full and abundant, you must plan your life. What you plan now when you are deacons can assure you an abundant life. Have you already been saving money dedicated to your missions?

"You may not yet have chosen your business or profession or life's work, but there are many generalities which you can already set up in your lives, even though you may not yet know whether you will be a lawyer or a doctor or a teacher or an engineer. There are decisions you should already have made or now be making. What are you going to do in the years between now and your marriage? And what will you do about your marriage?

"You can determine now that you will be the most faithful deacon and teacher and priest. You can decide that

now with an irrevocable covenant. You can be a good student; you can use your time properly and efficiently. All the balance of your life you can be happy if you use your time well.

"You can make up your mind this early that you will fill an honorable mission when you reach mission age, and to that end that you will now earn money and save it and invest it for your mission, that you will study and serve and use every opportunity to properly prepare your mind and heart and soul for that glorious period of your life" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1974; p. 125; or *Ensign*, May 1974, p. 86).

Responsibility and opportunity

"And since you will now establish your goal to fill a mission, remember it costs money to go to the various parts of the world and preach the gospel. Remember, then, it is your privilege now to begin to save your money.

"Every time money comes into your hands, through gifts or earnings, set at least a part of it away in a savings account to be used for your mission. Every boy would like to be independent and furnish his own funds for his mission, rather than to ask his parents to do that for him. Every boy in every country in all the world who has been baptized and received the Holy Ghost will have the responsibility of bearing the message of the gospel to the people of the world. And this is also your opportunity, and it will contribute greatly toward your greatness" (in Conference Report, Oct. 1974, p. 117; or *Ensign*, Nov. 1974, p. 83).

Free agency and mission program

"The question has been often asked, Is the mission program one of compulsion? And the answer, of course, is no. Everyone is given his free agency. . . . He *should* pay his tithing, like he *should* attend his meetings, like he *should* keep his life clean and free from the ugliness of the world and plan a celestial marriage in the temple of the

Lord" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1974, p. 125; or *Ensign*, May 1974, p. 87).

You, your attitudes, your responses

"I remind you young men that regardless of your present age, you are building your life; it will be cheap and shoddy or it will be valuable and beautiful; it will be full of constructive activities or it can be destructive; it can be full of joy and happiness, or it can be full of misery. It all depends upon you and your attitudes, for your altitude, or the height you climb, is dependent upon your attitude or your response to situations" (in Conference Report, Oct. 1974, p. 112; or *Ensign*, Nov. 1974, p. 80).

Know by the Spirit

"And you, my fine young men, must not be just average. Your lives must be clean and free from all kinds of evil thoughts or acts—no lying, no theft, no anger, no faithlessness, no failure to do that which is right, no sexual sins of any kind, at any time.

"You know what is right and what is wrong. You have all received the Holy Ghost following your baptism. You need no one to brand the act or thought as wrong or right. You know by the Spirit. You are painting your own picture, carving your own statue. It is up to you to make it acceptable.

"May God bless you, our beloved young men. I know your Heavenly Father is your true friend. Everything he asks you to do is right and will bring blessings to you and make you manly and strong" (in Conference Report, Oct. 1974, p. 118; or *Ensign*, Nov. 1974, p. 83).

Need not wait for blessings

"The youth of the Church should realize that they do not need to be old men, long experienced, to receive the blessings of the Church. Joseph Smith

was only 14 when he had the Vision, 25 when the Church was organized, 18 when he met Moroni, 24 when he got the plates, and 39 when he was martyred.

"Thomas B. Marsh was 31, David W. Patten 30, about the time they became apostles. These were all young men, so to speak.

"Brigham Young was 28, Heber C. Kimball 28, Orson Hyde only 25, William E. McLellan 24, Parley P. Pratt 23, Luke Johnson, 22, William Smith 19, Orson Pratt 18, John F. Boynton 18, and Lyman E. Johnson 18, when the Church was organized on April 6, 1830. And these men, many of them, were of the apostleship in 1835 when the Council of the Twelve was organized. All were still young men when they were deprived of Joseph.

"They were able to inspire boys. They became great missionaries. You young boys need not wait to be great. You can be superior missionaries, strong young men, great companions, and happy, trusted Church leaders. You need not wait until tomorrow.

"The Lord bless you as you grow year by year to receive the inspiration

of the Lord to be able to pass on the glorious blessings of the gospel.

"And this, my dear beloved brethren, I pray in the name of Jesus Christ. Amen" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1976, p. 71; or *Ensign*, May 1976, p. 47).

President Hinckley

Wasn't that wonderful? Before giving my closing remarks, we note that the nationwide Tabernacle Choir radio broadcast will be from 9:30 to 10:00 tomorrow morning. Those desiring to attend must be in their seats before 9:15 A.M.

As you leave this meeting tonight, we remind you to obey traffic rules, to use caution, and to be courteous in driving.

The music has been furnished by a priesthood choir from Brigham Young University.

We are grateful to these brethren for this lovely and stirring music. Following my remarks, the choir will sing "Rise Up, O Men of God!" Following the music, Elder Ronald E. Poelman of the First Quorum of the Seventy will offer the benediction.

President Gordon B. Hinckley

My brethren, I pray for the inspiration of the Holy Spirit. It is almost anticlimactic to speak after what we have heard. This has been a wonderful meeting, beginning with the opening music of the choir singing Parley P. Pratt's great plea, "Come, Oh Thou King of Kings," followed by the beautiful prayer of Bishop Simpson.

President Benson's remarks touched each of us. I think we will all be prone to be a little more obedient as a result of what he said.

Example to all young men

I am confident you boys were greatly interested in the remarks of Peter Vidmar. What a remarkable thing it is to be the very best in all the world in something. It is a tremendous achievement to have won two gold medals and one silver in the Olympics. Peter missed winning his third gold only by .025 of a point. That says that he is very good, and it also says that the margin between number one and number two can be ever so narrow, as he indicated.

Peter weighs only 130 pounds. He is twenty-three years of age. He started

with gymnastics at the age of eleven. He set his eye on the Olympics and prepared for eleven years for that great international contest. He was born in the Church and married in the temple. He is a member of the UCLA ward of the Los Angeles California Stake. He served a stake mission. In his manner of living, in his speech, in his activity, he is an example to all young men. Thank you, Peter, for being with us this evening and for what you have said.

I wish we might have had more time to listen to Brother Ballard. He manages the Missionary Department of the Church. I hope he has stirred within every young man an increased desire to fill a mission. He is a tremendous example of a great and willing servant. When we asked him to go to Ethiopia to investigate the situation there first-hand, along with Brother Pace, he said promptly, "When do you want me to leave?" I said, "How about tomorrow?" He said, "I'll go up today and get my yellow fever shots and be ready to go." There were no questions asked; there was no delay. I shall make further reference tomorrow to what he said tonight concerning what he and Brother Pace found there.

We have been lifted by Elder Ashton's wonderful tribute to President Kimball. I hope that all of us have stored in our memories that which he said and that each will take direction therefrom.

To please his Heavenly Father

And now, what an inspiring and delightful experience to hear again as he spoke in the days of his great vitality, our beloved leader, President Kimball. His words have stirred within us anew a resolution to lengthen our stride and quicken our pace in the awesome responsibility to carry the gospel to the world while strengthening the membership wherever there may be weakness. It is easy to see why President Kimball is universally loved. He has been a leader rather than a commander, and I think there is a difference

between the two. He himself has done that which he has asked others to do and has done it with greater devotion and energy.

I would like to use as a theme for a few minutes some of the words that all of you heard tonight from him. You will recall that in talking of his life as a boy he said that he made up his mind that he wanted to please his Heavenly Father. Now that's a very simple statement. Anybody can make a statement like that, but what a tremendous effect that resolution had upon his life. And what a tremendous effect a similar resolution would have upon the lives of each of us—so to live as to please our Heavenly Father.

If this were the measure by which we gauged all of our activity, what a difference it would make. Think of what that would mean in your own life. Each time we planned a program, each time we became involved in an activity, each time we mapped a course in our lives, if we applied the gauge, "Will this please my Heavenly Father?" we would be spared so much of pain and regret and enjoy so much of success and achievement that it would be wonderful.

A man of integrity, ambition, virtue

Think of what that resolution, made while a boy, did for Spencer Kimball. It made of him a man of integrity in the business life of his community. It made of him a young man of ambition in preparing himself for his future. It made of him a young man of virtue, a husband and father possessed of love and compassion, the servant in whom the Lord found no guile, a prophet to the people.

"I wanted to do those things which would please my Heavenly Father," he said. There is nothing grand or heroic about that statement. It is simply an expression of attitudes: "As [a man] thinketh in his heart, so is he" (Proverbs 23:7).

I wish I might have the capacity to burn into the consciousness of every man and boy within the sound of my voice those words of resolution made by President Kimball when he was a boy.

To please your Heavenly Father?

What would your Father in Heaven have you do that would please Him? First, you boys. He would have you live honestly. That means no cheating in your schoolwork. No boy anxious to please his Heavenly Father would fail to take advantage of educational opportunities. Through words of modern revelation the Lord has laid upon us responsibilities to seek learning "by study and also by faith" (D&C 88:118). The Lord expects each of us to live productive and useful lives. Youth is the season of preparation, and we will please him if we apply ourselves to train our minds and hands that we may make a more substantial contribution to the society of which we are a part.

No boy anxious to please his Heavenly Father could belittle or degrade a daughter of our Father in Heaven through immorality. He would realize that to degrade or dishonor a girl would be to insult her Father in Heaven who loves her and who expects great and good things of her.

In the mission field

Every young man seeking to please his Heavenly Father would be willing and anxious to give approximately a tithe of his life at the age of nineteen or twenty to go into the world to preach the gospel. He would save his money for this; he would plan his life's program around it; he would keep himself physically, mentally, and morally alert, as well as spiritually strong, to be prepared for this great and sacred responsibility.

While in the mission field he would be "anxiously engaged" in the work of the Lord (see D&C 58:27),

willing to give freely of his time, his talents, his strengths, and his substance to bless the lives of others. He would guard against wasting his time or diminishing his effectiveness through engaging in activities that might in any way be out of harmony with his great and sacred call.

As a husband

Having served an honorable mission, he would return home, desiring to complete his education and looking forward to finding his companion to love and cherish for eternity. Trying to please his Heavenly Father, he would see that his courtship is kept unsullied. Again trying to please his Heavenly Father, he would be married worthily in the way which God has prepared for those who love him and those who desire his richest blessings—that is, in His holy house under the authority of His everlasting priesthood.

As a husband, he would live with respect for his wife, standing side by side with her, never belittling her nor demeaning her, but rather encouraging her in the continued development of her talents and in the church activities which are available to her. He would regard her as the greatest treasure of his life, one with whom he can share his concerns, his innermost thoughts, his ambitions and hopes. There would never be in that home any "unrighteous dominion" of husband over wife (see D&C 121:37, 39), no assertion of superiority, no assertion of authority, but rather an expression in living which says that these two are equally yoked.

No man can please his Heavenly Father who fails to respect the daughters of God. No man can please his Heavenly Father who fails to magnify his wife and companion, and nurture and build and strengthen and share with her.

Relationship of Sister Kimball to President Kimball

It has been a wonderful thing to see Sister Kimball in her relationship to

President Kimball. She is a woman of learning, a woman who reads much, a woman who is constantly refining her talents, a woman who loves the Lord and serves in His kingdom—a woman who supports and sustains, loves and encourages her husband and their children. And he, throughout his married life, has encouraged and sustained her, has relied upon her, has shared with her in times of sorrow and rejoicing, in seasons of stress and ease, in sickness and in health. They have worked together, they have prayed together, they have sorrowed together, they have stood side by side in a relationship that becomes an example to the entire Church. He has never lost sight of that boyhood resolution to do that which would please his Heavenly Father.

Wife and child abuse

Wife abuse is totally inconsistent with the gospel of Jesus Christ. Child abuse is an affront to our Father in Heaven. As President Harold B. Lee was wont to remind us, the greatest work that any of us will ever do will be within the walls of our own homes. A father who wishes to please his Heavenly Father will govern his family in a spirit of example and love.

There appears to be a plague of child abuse spreading across the world. Perhaps it has always been with us but has not received the attention it presently receives. I am glad there is a hue and cry going up against this terrible evil, too much of which is found among our own. Fathers, you cannot abuse your little ones without offending God. Any man involved in an incestuous relationship is unworthy to hold the priesthood. He is unworthy to hold membership in the Church and should be dealt with accordingly. Any man who beats or in other ways abuses his children will be held accountable before the great judge of us all. If there be any within the sound of my voice who are guilty of such practices, let them repent forthwith, make amends where possible, develop within themselves

that discipline which can curb such evil practices, plead with the Lord for forgiveness, and resolve within their hearts henceforth to walk with clean hands.

Lift and strengthen others

How beautiful is that home where lives a man of godly manner, who loves those for whose nurture he is responsible, who stands before them as an example of integrity and goodness, who teaches industry and loyalty, not spoiling his children by indulging their every wish, but rather setting before them a pattern of work and service which will underpin their lives forever. How fortunate is the man whose wife radiates a spirit of love, of compassion, of order, of quiet beneficence, whose children show appreciation one for another, who honor and respect their parents, who counsel with them and take counsel from them. Such home life is within the reach of all who have cultivated in their hearts a resolution to do that which will please their Father in Heaven.

It is so even with community effort. Those who love Him will seek to do that which will encourage and uphold community standards which will create and maintain an environment of culture, of growth, and of peaceful relationships. Let us never forget that we are all sons and daughters of God and that if we are to please our Eternal Father, we must work to lift and strengthen his children and the communities in which we all live together.

One who seeks to please his Heavenly Father will serve the needs of our Father's kingdom. This Church is a part of His divine plan. It is the kingdom of God in the earth. Its work is important. Its work is necessary to the accomplishment of the eternal purposes of our Father. If each of us is to please our Father in Heaven, we must be responsive to the needs of His kingdom. We must be willing to work wherever we are called to work and to develop our talents so that our work will be more effective in

reaching out to those who are not members of the Church or those who are inactive in the Church. We must be diligent in carrying forward the great work of salvation for the dead and in every other way giving of our strength and talent and substance to move forward and strengthen the Church. This may involve some sacrifice, yes, but with every sacrifice comes a blessing.

Simple words with power

Mine has been the privilege these past two or three months of interviewing and extending calls to fifty-eight men to serve as mission presidents. What a gratifying and inspiring experience this has been. Each of these men is one who is carrying substantial responsibility in business or professional service, who has many concerns and interests demanding attention. But without exception, in every case, the response has been, "If I can help the work of the Lord, that is what I want to do. If the Lord is extending a call, I am ready to leave." Sometimes after such interviews, tears have welled in my eyes as I have reflected on the great faith of so many who, at the call of the Church, are willing to set aside every other interest out of a desire to please our Heavenly Father.

The remarkable and wonderful thing is that although they give up much

to go, as everyone can testify when he returns home, they gain so very much that is unique and wonderful. They all come back saying there is no experience like it, and they would not trade it for any other on earth. It is so with any service we do as an expression of love for our Father in Heaven. I repeat, these are very simple words which we heard President Kimball express tonight. They were spoken by him when he was a boy. But what remarkable power there lies within them to stir us to greater, more Godlike endeavor.

I want to suggest them to every boy and man within the sound of my voice—"I will try to do that which will please my Heavenly Father." I do not hesitate to promise that if we will do so our lives will be the richer, the more purposeful, the more satisfying. Our homes will be happier, and one day in the life to come we shall hear from Him whom we have served, "Well done, thou good and faithful servant. Enter thou into the joy of thy Lord" (Matthew 25:21). For this I humbly pray in behalf of each of us, in the name of Jesus Christ, Amen.

The choir sang "Rise Up, O Men of God."

The benediction was offered by Elder Ronald E. Poelman.

SECOND DAY MORNING MEETING

FOURTH SESSION

The fourth session of the general conference commenced at 10:00 A.M. on Sunday, April 7, 1985. President Gordon B. Hinckley, Second Counselor in the First Presidency, conducted.

The Tabernacle Choir provided the music with Jerold Ottley and Donald Ripplinger directing and John Longhurst at the organ.

Prior to the opening of the session, the choir sang "Rejoice, the Lord Is King" without announcement.

President Hinckley made the following remarks:

President Gordon B. Hinckley

On this beautiful Easter morning we extend a special welcome to all gathered in the Salt Lake Tabernacle on Temple Square in this, the fourth gen-

eral session of the 155th Annual General Conference of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. We are particularly grateful for the presence of President Spencer W. Kimball at this session of the conference. We are also delighted to have with us President Marion G. Romney. We excuse Elder Paul H. Dunn of the First Quorum of the Seventy who because of illness is unable to meet with us this morning; otherwise, I think all General Authorities are present.

The significance of this day reminds us of the duties resting on those who have accepted the Savior and who have been baptized into his Church, to honor and to love him, to keep his commandments, and to reflect in our lives the noble qualities of character which he exhibited during his mortal ministry and which he has enjoined upon us by commandment.

We acknowledge those tuned to this conference by radio, television, or cable, those who are seated in the overflow congregation in the Assembly Hall where Elders Marion D. Hanks and F. Burton Howard preside, and those participating through satellite transmission assembled in over seven hundred and fifty stake centers in the

United States, Canada, and Puerto Rico.

We acknowledge the presence this morning of government, education, and civic leaders, and officers and members of the Church from many lands who have assembled to worship and to counsel together in this conference.

The Tabernacle Choir under the direction of Jerold Ottley and Donald Ripplinger with John Longhurst at the organ is providing the music for this session.

The choir opened these services by singing "Rejoice, the Lord Is King" and will now sing "I Believe in Christ"; words written by Elder Bruce R. McConkie.

Following the music of the choir, Elder Robert E. Wells, a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy, will offer the invocation.

The choir sang "I Believe in Christ."

Elder Robert E. Wells offered the invocation.

President Gordon B. Hinckley spoke without announcement.

President Gordon B. Hinckley

Mortal death and immortal life

A few days before last Christmas a terrible tragedy occurred at one of the large coal mines in central Utah. Twenty-seven miners lost their lives when fire engulfed the long underground slopes and shafts. Many of these were young men with young wives and young children. The hearts of thousands over the world were touched by the suffering of loved ones left behind.

I met many of these. I spoke with them. I joined with them in a memorial service. There were tears, with much

of weeping. There was an overwhelming feeling of loneliness as widows, with children to feed and clothe and educate, looked into the bleakness of the future. Our tears flowed with theirs. But shining through all of this was a faith transcendent that, as surely as there had been mortal death, there will be immortal life; and as certainly as there had been separation, there will be reunion. This is the faith which comes of Christ, who brought to all the promise of immortality.

Christ opened gates of salvation

My beloved brethren and sisters, what a glorious day is Easter! This is the day when we, with Christian people everywhere, celebrate the most significant event in human history—the resurrection from the grave, the return to life from death, of the Son of God. Among all the facts of mortality, nothing is so certain as its end. How tragic, how poignant is the sorrow of those left behind. The grieving widow, the motherless child, the father bereft and alone—all of these can speak of the wounds of parting.

But thanks be to God for the wonder and the majesty of His eternal plan. Thank and glorify His Beloved Son, who, with indescribable suffering, gave His life on Calvary's cross to pay the debt of mortal sin. He it was who, through His atoning sacrifice, broke the bonds of death and with godly power rose triumphant from the tomb. He is our Redeemer, the Redeemer of all mankind. He is the Savior of the world. He is the Son of God, the Author of our salvation.

"If a man die, shall he live again?" (Job 14:14). This is the great universal question framed by Job. He spoke what every other living man or woman has pondered. The Christ alone, of all the millions who up to that time had walked the earth, was the first to emerge from the grave triumphant, a living soul complete in spirit and body. He became "the firstfruits of them that slept" (1 Corinthians 15:20). Were greater words ever spoken than those of the angel that first resurrection morn—"Why seek ye the living among the dead?" (Luke 24:5). "He is not here: for he is risen, as he said" (Matthew 28:6).

His death sealed the testimony of His love for all mankind. His resurrection opened the gates of salvation to the sons and daughters of God of all generations.

In all of history there has been no majesty like His majesty, He, the mighty Jehovah, condescended to be born to mortal life in a stable of Bethle-

hem. He grew as a boy in Nazareth and "increased in wisdom and stature, and in favour with God and man" (Luke 2:52).

His crucifixion

He was baptized by John in the waters of Jordan, "and, lo, the heavens were opened unto him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove, and lighting upon him:

"And lo a voice from heaven, saying, This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased" (Matthew 3:16-17).

During the three years of His earthly ministry, He did what none other had ever done before, He taught as none other had previously taught.

Then came His time to be offered. There was the supper in the Upper Room, His last with the Twelve in mortality. As He washed their feet, He taught a lesson in humility and service they would never forget. There followed the suffering of Gethsemane, "which suffering," He said, "caused myself, even God, the greatest of all, to tremble because of pain, and to bleed at every pore, and to suffer both body and spirit" (D&C 19:18).

He was taken by rough and crude hands, and in the night, contrary to the law, was brought before Annas, and then Caiaphas, the wily and evil officer of the Sanhedrin. There followed early the next morning the second appearance before this scheming, vicious man. Then He was taken to Pilate, the Roman governor, to whom his wife said in warning, "Have thou nothing to do with that just man" (Matthew 27:19). The Roman, thinking to evade responsibility, sent Him to Herod, the corrupt, debauched, and evil tetrarch of Galilee. Christ was abused and beaten. His head was crowned with sharp and platted thorns, a mocking robe of purple was thrown upon His bleeding back. Again he was taken before Pilate, to whom the mob cried, "Crucify him, Crucify him" (Luke 23:21).

With stumbling steps He walked the way to Golgotha, where His

wounded body was nailed to the cross in the most inhumane and pain-ridden method of execution that sadistic minds could conjure.

Yet He cried out, "Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do" (Luke 23:34).

The hours passed as His life ebbed in pain. The earth shook, the veil of the temple was rent. From His parched lips came the words, "Father, into thy hands I commend my spirit: and having said thus, he gave up the ghost" (Luke 23:46).

It was over. His mortal life was finished. He had offered it as a ransom for all.

Victory over death

Gone were the hopes of those who loved Him. Forgotten were the promises He had made. His body was hurriedly but tenderly placed in a borrowed tomb on the eve of the Jewish Sabbath. That Sabbath came and went. Then, early in the morning of Sunday, Mary Magdalene and other women came to the tomb. They wondered as they hurried how the stone might be rolled from the door of the sepulchre. Arriving, they saw an angel who spoke to them: "I know that ye seek Jesus, which was crucified. He is not here: for he is risen, as he said" (Matthew 28:5-6).

It had never before happened. The empty tomb was the answer to the question of the ages. Well did Paul say: "O death, where is thy sting? O grave, where is thy victory?" (1 Corinthians 15:55).

The miracle of that resurrection morning, that first Easter Sunday, is a miracle for all mankind. It is the miracle of the power of God, whose Beloved Son gave His life to atone for the sins of all, a sacrifice of love for every son and daughter of God. In so doing He broke the seals of death.

All of us will die. But that will not be the end. Just as He in the spirit world taught those who once had been disobedient in the days of Noah and were capable of being taught, even so shall

each of us continue as individual personalities capable of learning and teaching and other activities.

And just as He took up His body and came forth from the tomb, even so shall all of us enjoy a reunion of body and spirit to become living souls in the day of our own resurrection.

We rejoice, therefore, as do many, and as should all mankind, when we remember the most glorious, the most comforting, the most reassuring of all events of human history—the victory over death.

Witness to reality of Resurrection

To all the world we bear solemn witness. We have read the testimony of those who participated in the experiences of those three days of pain, of sorrow, and of rejoicing. We have read of the sufferings endured by those who testified of these things and of their willingness to give their own lives rather than deny the truth of that which they had seen. We have read the testimony of those in Palestine and of those in the New World who were visited by the risen Lord. The Spirit has borne witness within our hearts concerning the truth of these testimonies.

We also have the testimony of one who, in the opening of this dispensation, spoke with the living Christ and with His Eternal Father, and who gave his own life to seal that testimony with his blood. Declared he in words of soberness:

"And now, after the many testimonies which have been given of him, this is the testimony, last of all, which we give of him: That he lives!

"For we saw him, even on the right hand of God; and we heard the voice bearing record that he is the Only Begotten of the Father—

"That by him, and through him, and of him, the worlds are and were created, and the inhabitants thereof are begotten sons and daughters unto God" (D&C 76:22-24).

In solemnity, and with understanding of the gravity of that which we

say, we add our witness to all the world of the reality of the Resurrection, that this same Jesus who rose from the grave ascended into heaven. We declare that in this dispensation of time He returned to restore to earth the pristine gospel which He had taught while walking among men, that with that restoration has come further certain witness of His reality, and has come also the holy priesthood, given to men, which is exercised in His name. This is our testimony, which we bear in the name of Jesus Christ, and we invite all men to hear and accept it.

Special fast for starving in Africa

And now, I should like to turn to another matter, dealing with an expression of the gospel of our Lord of whom we have spoken.

When the lawyer tempted Him, asking, "Master, which is the great commandment in the law?"

"Jesus said unto him, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind.

"This is the first and great commandment.

"And the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself.

"On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets" (Matthew 22:36-40).

When hearts across the world were touched by reports of starving populations in Africa, we invited members of the Church in the United States and Canada to observe a special fast day, abstaining from two meals and giving the equivalent value, or more, to aid these famine-stricken people. We at the time asked only those in North America because of a desire to move quickly, and we felt there was not sufficient time to put in place the program elsewhere. Many of you outside North America have asked that you be given a similar opportunity, and some have responded.

The response of those who participated has been wonderful. It has been most gratifying. It was far more generous than at the regular monthly fast. We, as the trustees of your contributions, should like to give you an accounting of what we have done to date. Your contributions have reached the sum of \$6,025,656. We indicated that any money so received would be handled through organizations of demonstrated integrity. We do not have members of the Church in the areas where the need is most acute. If we were to help quickly and effectively, we had to join hands with others, and this has been a most gratifying experience. We have come to know that there are many organizations that are doing great good in stemming the tide of hunger that threatens millions in that part of the world. We have associated ourselves in this endeavor with four of these, who have been most cooperative and helpful.

Thus far we have distributed funds as follows:

American Red Cross	\$1,300,000
(for use by the International Committee of the Red Cross and the International League of Red Cross)	(plus \$100,000 given earlier, making a total of \$1,400,000)
Catholic Relief Services.....	\$1,400,000
Africare	\$1,100,000
Care, Inc.....	\$ 500,000
Total committed from the special fast.....	\$4,300,000

Geographic Breakdown of Expenditures

Ethiopia	\$2,850,000
Sudan	\$ 825,000
Other African nations....	\$ 625,000
	<u>\$4,300,000</u>

As I indicated, we had previously given \$100,000, making a total of \$4,400,000.

The balance will be committed to areas where our research indicates the

greatest need, to be administered also by qualified agencies.

Aid means difference between life and death

Some few have criticized us for extending aid to those who are the victims of the policies or mismanagement of their governments. My response has been that where there is stark hunger, regardless of the cause, I will not let political considerations dull my sense of mercy or thwart my responsibility to the sons and daughters of God, wherever they may be or whatever their circumstances.

Elder M. Russell Ballard of the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy and Bishop Glenn L. Pace, who joined the Presiding Bishopric yesterday, have just returned from Africa, where they went out into the rural areas of Ethiopia. They saw firsthand how the funds you consecrated are literally saving the lives of many who otherwise would die of starvation, disease, and exposure. Your contributions not only have supplied food and medicine where they are so desperately needed, but your contributions also have furnished tents sufficient to put thirty thousand people under shelter from the blistering sun and the cold night winds, with blankets to comfort them. The food and other commodities are getting through to those who need them. There has been no interference with this, but only the best of cooperation.

Elder Ballard and Bishop Pace have been with these suffering people. They say they are men and women of courage and character, but they are defeated and frightened by the terrifying circumstances in which they find themselves. Their lands are dry and naked. There is neither irrigation water nor food. They wander in desperation until they and their children die unless they are fed. A little cracked wheat literally spells the difference between life and death.

Only if rains come and wells are drilled can there be long-term recovery

and sustenance. Some of our funds will be used in a joint venture relationship to drill in areas of underground water to bring land under cultivation and make it fruitful, with the hope that there may be long-term as well as short-term help for these destitute people.

Acknowledgments

I, for one, am deeply grateful for the opportunity to assist in blessing those of our Father's children in that part of the earth who are in such desperate need. I am confident that there springs up in the heart of each of you a feeling of appreciation for what has come to pass and will yet further come to pass as the result of many of our people with one heart doing so small a thing as refraining from two meals and contributing the value thereof to a common effort. Think what might happen if there were such a fast day observed across the world. No one would be hurt, and many would be helped. How grateful we are for the inspiration of the Almighty in establishing so simple, yet so effective a program for relieving want and suffering.

In the administration of African relief we have not used a single dollar for overhead, but every dollar you have contributed has gone or will go to help directly those in such urgent need, not one of whom is a member of the Church.

May I read a few lines from two letters. The first is from the chairman of Catholic Relief Services:

"I want to acknowledge the very generous contribution of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints . . . for relief efforts in Ethiopia and the Sudan. You can be sure that these funds will be put to rapid use to help alleviate the suffering that millions face in those countries.

"We are pleased to participate in an interfaith action of this kind. Such ecumenical efforts underline the compassion and concern which we hold in common when faced by such human

tragedies as well as our common commitment to positive action.

"This cooperation between us has a special character since the resources involved come directly from your individual members through a day of fasting. It is thus in a very heartening sense an example of people responding to people at a fundamental level of moral and practical concern. . . . Sincerely yours in Christ, [signed] Daniel P. Reilly, Bishop of Norwich, chairman of the board of directors"

And now from the president of the American Red Cross:

"I cannot thank you and your members in the U.S. and Canada enough for the outstanding support you have given the Red Cross relief effort in Africa. Your most recent contribution of \$800,000 brings the total donations to \$1,400,000. This support . . . has permitted us to provide 350,000 victims food for a month based upon the Red Cross estimate that \$4 a month is needed to feed a child. . . .

"In Ethiopia . . . on a daily average the Red Cross workers are feeding more than 500,000 people. . . . Red Cross assistance is being provided to the most vulnerable groups: children under 5 years of age, pregnant women, nursing mothers and the elderly. In northern Ethiopia where few other organizations are able to work, assistance is being given to the most needy.

"In neighboring Sudan the situation is deteriorating rapidly. 200,000 to 300,000 new refugees from Chad, Uganda and Ethiopia are expected by the end of May. In addition, Sudan itself is being affected by the drought with 280,000 forced to leave their homes in search of food. 15,000 children were recently found to suffer night blindness, the last step to total blindness due to poor nutrition. These children are now being fed by the Red Cross. . . .

"You may be assured the Red Cross is honored by the trust you have

placed in our relief work. *All* contributions given through the American Red Cross are used in African Famine Relief. No overhead or fund raising costs are being deducted. I know your members have sacrificed to make this relief possible. The trust of your fellowship will be honored. God bless you all. [Signed] Richard Schubert, President"

Walk in obedience and deal with mercy

As you see, we have provided immediate aid to the extent of \$4,400,000.

Thank you for what you have done. Many contributed far more than the value of two meals. You have cast bread upon the waters, and it will return to you as you experience the peace of generous hearts.

You responded in a magnificent way in sharing of your plenty with those who are destitute. We can similarly respond to a score of other challenges we face as Latter-day Saints to move forward the work of God. On this Easter morning, when we remember Him who gave His life for each of us, let us resolve, individually, to walk in obedience to the teachings and commandments of our Savior and to deal with mercy, I humbly pray as I leave with you my testimony of the divinity of this work, in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

The choir will now sing "O Savior, Thou Who Wearest a Crown," following which Elder David B. Haight will address us.

The choir sang "O Savior, Thou Who Wearest a Crown."

Elder David B. Haight spoke without further announcement.

Elder David B. Haight

On this glorious Easter morning, I rejoice with you and untold millions of people throughout the world whose hearts are turned to Jesus of Nazareth. To the Samaritan woman at Jacob's Well who said, "I know that Messias cometh . . . : when he is come, he will tell us all things" came Christ's declaration, "I that speak unto thee am he" (John 4:25-26).

Many of the heavenly directed events leading up to and following the crucifixion of our Lord have been narrated by the early Apostles and other witnesses.

Jesus' burial, and guarding the tomb

According to these accounts, Joseph, a rich man from the village of Arimathaea and one of the Sanhedrin, did not openly declare his belief in Jesus, as he feared the Jewish authorities. But now sorrow, as well as indignation, aroused his courage. He asked Pilate if he could take away Jesus' body. Pilate gave permission.

Nicodemus—a noble disciple who had visited Jesus at night lest someone might see them together—assisted Joseph. They wrapped Jesus' body in fine linen, together with spices, according to the Jewish custom of preparing a body for burial. They laid the body reverently in the rocky niche of a tomb in a garden that belonged to Joseph. The tomb had never been used. It was the day before the Jewish Sabbath. (See John 19:38-42.)

The next day Pilate gave permission for the tomb to be carefully guarded until the third day, so the disciples could not steal the body and then tell the people that Jesus had risen from the dead, as had been prophesied. The chief priests and Pharisees made the tomb secure, sealing the stone and leaving a guard on watch. (See Matthew 27:62-66.)

"He is not here"

Before daylight the next morning, Mary Magdalene and Mary the mother of James, having prepared fresh spices and ointments, went to the tomb of Jesus and found that the stone had been rolled away. Looking in and not finding the body, they hurried to find Peter and the Apostles and told them what they had found. Peter and John hastened at once to the tomb. John outran his older companion. Stooping down, he gazed in silent wonder into the empty tomb. Entering, Peter saw the burial clothes lying where the body of Jesus once lay. And then John followed him. And in spite of fear, there dawned upon them the hope, which later would become an absolute knowledge, that Christ had indeed risen, but as yet no one had seen him. The two wondering Apostles returned to their brethren.

Mary stayed at the tomb and was grieving at the entrance when someone approached. Thinking it was the keeper of the garden, she asked where he had laid her Lord. Jesus said to her, "Mary."

Jesus himself was standing before her, but he did not appear as she had known him; he was now risen and glorified. She then recognized our Lord and must have attempted to embrace him, for he said, "Touch me not; for I am not yet ascended to my Father: but go to my brethren, and say unto them, I ascend unto my Father, and your Father; and to my God, and your God."

Filled with amazement, she hastened to obey and repeated that glorious message which would give hope through all future ages and to which she added her personal declaration that she had seen the Lord. (See John 20:1-18.)

Later, women carrying spices for the final preparation of the body for burial looked in the tomb and witnessed angels, who said, "Ye seek Jesus of Nazareth, which was crucified. Why seek ye the living among the dead? He

is not here, but is risen" (Mark 16:6; Luke 24:6)

The angels told the women to go and notify the disciples, but the men believed them not. (See Mark 16:7; Luke 24:9-11.)

On the road to Emmaus

The Gospel according to Luke relates that on that same day two of Jesus' followers were on their way to a village called Emmaus, about eight miles from Jerusalem, and they were discussing with sad and anxious hearts the things that had happened in the past two days.

As they walked and conversed, a stranger joined them and walked along with them. Even though this stranger was indeed the resurrected Christ, they did not recognize him.

Gospel writers indicate their conversation went something like this:

Jesus asked them, "What are you talking about, as you walk along?"

They were surprised and said, "Are you the only visitor in Jerusalem that does not know what has been happening here these last few days?"

"What things?" Jesus asked.

"The things that happened to Jesus of Nazareth. This man was a prophet and was considered by God and by all the people to be powerful in everything he said and did. Our chief priests and rulers handed him over to be sentenced to death, and he was crucified. We had hoped that he would be the one who was going to set Israel free."

"And besides, today is the third day since it happened. Some of our women went to the tomb," they continued, "but could not find his body. They came to us saying they had seen a vision of angels, who told them that he is risen. So some of us went to the tomb and found it even as the women said, but we did not see him."

Then the stranger said to them, "How foolish you are, to be so slow to believe all that the prophets have said. Was it not necessary for Christ to suffer these things and to enter into his glory?" And Jesus explained, as they

walked, what was said about himself in the scriptures, beginning with Moses and the writings of all of the prophets.

As they came near the village to which they were going, Jesus acted as if he were going further, but they persuaded him to stay, saying, "Abide with us: for it is toward evening, and the day is far spent."

So he stayed with them. As he ate the simple meal with them, he took the bread and blessed it; then he broke the bread and gave it to them. As he did this, their eyes were opened, and they recognized the Lord; and then he vanished from their sight.

They said in amazement to each other, "Did not our hearts burn within us when he talked to us on the road and explained the scriptures to us?"

They hurried back to Jerusalem, where they found ten of the Apostles and other disciples gathered together, with the doors closed for fear of the Jews. (See John 20:19.) They declared, "The Lord is risen indeed, and hath appeared to Simon."

The two men then explained what had happened on the road and how they had recognized the Lord when he broke the bread.

Appeared to Apostles

While the two men were telling them this, suddenly the Lord himself stood in the midst of them and said, "Peace be unto you."

They were terrified and supposed that they were seeing a spirit, but he said to them, "Why are ye troubled? and why do thoughts arise in your hearts?"

"Behold my hands and my feet, that it is I myself: handle me, and see; for a spirit hath not flesh and bones, as ye see me have."

He showed them his hands and his feet. They still could not believe as they were so full of joy and wonderment, so he asked them, "Have ye here any meat? And they gave him a piece of a broiled fish, and . . . honeycomb. And he took it, and did eat before them."

Then he said to them, "These are the words which I spake unto you, while I was yet with you, that all things must be fulfilled, which were written in the law of Moses, and in the prophets, and in the psalms, concerning me."

Then he opened their minds to understand the scriptures and said to them, "Thus it is written, and thus it behoved Christ to suffer, and to rise from the dead the third day: And that repentance and remission of sins should be preached in his name among all nations, beginning at Jerusalem." And then he reminded them, "Ye are witnesses of these things." (See Luke 24:13-48.)

One of the Twelve, named Thomas, was not with them when Jesus came, so the other disciples told him, "We have seen the Lord." Thomas said to them, "Except I shall see in his hands the print of the nails, and put my finger into the print of the nails, and thrust my hand into his side, I will not believe."

A week later the disciples were again gathered together indoors, and Thomas was with them. The doors were locked, but Jesus came and stood among them and said, "Peace be unto you." Then he said to Thomas, "Reach hither thy finger, and behold my hands; and reach thither thy hand, and thrust it into my side: and be not faithless, but believing."

I have often pictured in my own mind the skeptical Thomas' depth of remorse that must have been burning within his soul as his doubting heart, now purified, attempted a reply to his Lord.

Thomas' only answer unto him was, "My Lord and my God."

And Jesus said unto him, "Thomas, because thou has seen me, thou hast believed: blessed are they that have not seen, and yet have believed." (See John 20:25-29.)

Perhaps no clearer declaration of fact has ever been made than those which tell of the literal resurrection of Christ. The record of appearances to the Apostles during the forty days following his resurrection—as a group or

separately, to teach them "the things pertaining to the kingdom of God" (Acts 1:3)—leaves no cause for doubt. John informs us that "there are also many other things which Jesus did, the which, if they should be written, . . . even the world itself could not contain the books that should be written" (John 21:25).

Appeared on Western Hemisphere

Shortly after Jesus' appearance to the disciples on the Eastern Hemisphere, he appeared to the Nephites on the Western Hemisphere. God himself introduced his Son to the multitude: "Behold my Beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased, in whom I have glorified my name—hear ye him" (3 Nephi 11:7).

"The people beheld a Man, clothed in a white robe, who descended and stood among them. He spake, saying: 'Behold, I am Jesus Christ, whom the prophets testified shall come into the world; and behold, I am the light and the life of the world; and I have drunk out of that bitter cup which the Father hath given me, and have glorified the Father in taking upon me the sins of the world, in the which I have suffered the will of the Father in all things from the beginning.' [3 Nephi 11:10-11.] The multitude [knelt] in adoration for they remembered that their prophets had foretold that the Lord would appear among them after His resurrection and ascension.

"As He directed, the people arose, and one by one came to Him, and did see and feel the prints of the nails in His hands and feet and the spear-wound in His side. . . . With one accord they cried: 'Hosanna! blessed be the name of the Most High God!' [3 Nephi 11:17.] Then, falling at the feet of Jesus, they worshiped Him" (James E. Talmage, *Jesus the Christ* [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1916], p. 725).

Appearances in modern day

When Joseph Smith was visited by the Father and the resurrected Christ in 1820, the latter was introduced by the Father, "This is My Beloved Son. Hear Him!" (Joseph Smith—History 1:17), thus ushering in the marvelous events of the restoration of the gospel of Jesus Christ.

Our resurrected Lord was seen in a vision by Joseph Smith and Sidney Rigdon in 1832. Joseph recorded: "The Lord touched the eyes of our understandings, . . .

"And we beheld the glory of the Son, on the right hand of the Father, and received of his fulness;

"And saw the holy angels, and them who are sanctified before his throne, worshipping God, and the Lamb, who worship him forever and ever.

"And now, after the many testimonies which have been given of him, this is the testimony . . . which we give of him: That he lives!

"For we saw him, even on the right hand of God; and we heard the voice bearing record that he is the Only Begotten of the Father—

"That by him, and through him, and of him, the worlds are and were created, and the inhabitants thereof are begotten sons and daughters unto God" (D&C 76:19–24).

"I am the resurrection, and the life"

Now, these fragmentary events which I have briefly portrayed bear record and witness that resurrection and eternal life come to us because of what Christ our Lord did for each of us. He declared, "I am the resurrection, and the life: he that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live: And whosoever liveth and believeth in me shall never die" (John 11:25–26). To this declaration of truth I bear my solemn witness, in the holy name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

Elder David B. Haight of the Council of the Twelve Apostles has just spoken to us.

The choir and congregation will now join in singing "I Know That My Redeemer Lives," following which we shall hear from Elder Wm. Grant Bangerter, a member of the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

The choir and congregation sang "I Know That My Redeemer Lives."

Elder Wm. Grant Bangerter spoke without further announcement.

Elder William Grant Bangerter

The glory of Easter morning fills the souls of those who yearn for eternal life. A similar glory touched the majestic morning when the Father and the Son announced the dawning of the day of salvation in the last days.

To contemplate what happened on those mornings of grandeur stirs the innermost feelings of the members of the Church.

Spirit of gathering

A mystic, spiritual force, similar to the magnetism of the lodestone, has drawn the Saints to seek the place where their longings can be satisfied. This is the spirit of the gathering, foretold in the scriptures. It is the reason why each one of us is here today, as we have been drawn both literally and spiritually to Zion—an actual, tangible place where the soul's yearning can be

fulfilled in anticipation of salvation and eternal life in the kingdom of God.

As I respond to the new appointment which has been given to me, I have deep feelings about the man whose passing away left the vacancy into which I have been called, Elder G. Homer Durham. Elder Durham married Eudora, the daughter of Elder John A. Widtsoe. Aside from their Church service, these two men, Dr. Durham and Dr. Widtsoe, have been outstanding in positions of leadership and responsibility, particularly in the field of education. Dr. Durham was the first commissioner of Higher Education in the state of Utah, and earlier presided over Arizona State University. He is greatly missed. Dr. John A. Widtsoe was the president of two universities before he was called to serve as a member of the Quorum of the Twelve Apostles.

In the gospel net

Many years ago Elder Widtsoe told the story of his mother, Anna Karine Gaarden Widtsoe, who, one hundred years ago was caught up in the "gospel net." Elder Widtsoe's prologue is as follows:

"This is the story of a woman, a seeker after truth, who, tossed by the waves of mysterious fate, was caught by the Gospel net, and carried into a far country, where, through the possession of eternal truth, though amidst much adversity, she and her family found unbounded happiness" (*In the Gospel Net* [Independence, Mo: Zion's Printing and Publishing Co., 1941], Prologue).

The beautiful story concerning his mother, who came from an obscure island off Norway, has been repeated thousands of times in the lives of the Latter-day Saints. These experiences are the foundation of the faith of every member of the Church. As I make reference to some of the influences that have drawn us into the gospel net, I hope that every Latter-day Saint will reflect on the spiritual power which has brought us to the gospel.

Words of a humble shoemaker

Elder Widtsoe's mother responded to the words of a humble shoemaker who had placed some tracts in her child's shoes. Speaking to her with some hesitation as she was leaving his shop, he said, "You may be surprised to hear me say that I can give you something of more value than soles for your child's shoes."

She responded, "What can you, a shoemaker, give me better than soles for my son's shoes?"

He answered, "If you will but listen, I can teach you the Lord's true plan of salvation for His children. I can teach you how to find happiness in this life and to prepare for eternal joy in the life to come. I can tell you whence you came, why you are upon the earth, and where you will go after death. I can teach you as you have never known it before, the love of God for his children on earth" (*In the Gospel Net*, pp. 54-55).

Confusion of ages ended

The deep and powerful influence which has reached out across time and space, often into far and hidden corners of the earth, has the effect to snatch people from their normal life patterns and bring them to Zion.

Since the Church was organized in 1830, the gospel net has encircled and drawn together many millions of people who, either through their own personal experience, or through receiving the teachings of their parents and grandparents, have found the way to eternal life.

This means that for those who receive the message, the confusion of ages about how to come to Christ has ended. The answers are at hand to the great questions, such as:

What is the meaning of human life on earth?

Is there revelation from heaven?

Where are the Apostles and prophets?

What about those who never heard of Christ?

Which of the many churches is authorized by God?

Who has authority to administer the gospel?

How can I know what God wants me to do?

There is only one way these questions could ever be answered. God would have to tell us. To do so he has called a latter-day prophet. He has sent heavenly messengers to confer the true priesthood and authority. He has revealed the Book of Mormon to support the witness of the Bible that Jesus is Christ. He has reestablished the ordinances and restored the everlasting covenant. The sure way to eternal life is again in place.

My own membership in the Church is in response to this powerful influence. My own grandparents in Switzerland were also led by the Spirit in the midst of ridicule and persecution to find the path by which they could rear their children with the sure knowledge of divine truth.

My mother's grandparents were among the first in England to respond to the teachings of Heber C. Kimball and Willard Richards in 1837.

They vibrated to the thrilling news that the kingdom of God had been brought back to the earth.

The human soul, to be spiritually alive, requires a vision, a yearning, a longing, a desire. The spirit of America reaches out to that longing; the great vision of liberty, the spirit of freedom, the land of opportunity and hope.

"Land consecrated unto him"

Sister Bangerter and I recently stood at the feet of the Statue of Liberty in New York harbor with President and Sister McGregor of Caldwell, New Jersey. They pointed out Ellis Island as the entry point into this land for hundreds of thousands of immigrants, including my grandparents and also Elder Widtsoe and his mother. We read again the inspiring words of Emma Lazarus

announcing the beacon to wandering souls. Referring to the ancient statue on the Greek island of Rhodes, she speaks of "The New Colossus":

"Not like the brazen giant of
Greek fame,
With conquering limbs astride
from land to land;
Here at our sea-washed, sunset
gates shall stand
A mighty woman with a torch,
whose flame
Is the imprisoned lightning, and
her name
Mother of Exiles. From her
beacon-hand
Glows world-wide welcome; her
mild eyes command
The air-bridged harbor that twin
cities frame.
'Keep, ancient lands, your stored
pomp!' cries she
With silent lips. Give me your
tired, your poor,
Your huddled masses yearning to
breathe free,
The wretched refuse of your
teeming shore,
Send these, the homeless,
tempest-tost, to me,
I lift my lamp beside the golden
door."

(In *Masterpieces of Religious Verse*, ed. by James Dalton Morrison [New York: Harper and Brothers Publishers, 1948], p. 517; inscribed in bronze on the Statue of Liberty, Bedloe Island, New York Harbor.)

Then President McGregor coupled this feeling to the words of Lehi:

"Wherefore, this land is consecrated unto him whom he shall bring. And if it so be that they shall serve him according to the commandments which he hath given, it shall be a land of liberty unto them; wherefore, they shall never be brought down into captivity; . . . but unto the righteous it shall be blessed forever" (2 Nephi 1:7).

The yearning of ancient Israel was to Jerusalem. During their captivity, the soul of the people was expressed in the 137th Psalm:

"By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down, yea, we wept, when we remembered Zion. . . .

"For they that carried us away captive required of us a song; and they that wasted us required of us mirth, saying, Sing us one of the songs of Zion.

"How shall we sing the Lord's song in a strange land?

"If I forget thee, O Jerusalem, let my right hand forget her cunning.

"If I do not remember thee, let my tongue cleave to the roof of my mouth; if I prefer not Jerusalem above my chief joy" (Psalm 137:1, 3-6).

Found pearl of great price

All of us should reflect on what we have joined and what power has captured our faith. Hundreds of thousands living today have in their own lifetime personally found the pearl of great price. They are the grandparents of the future whose names will be blessed by their posterity.

For forty-five years I have had close association with the land of Brazil. Many tens of thousands have joined the Church in that country. I had great joy yesterday in hearing of the call of Elder Helio da Rocha Camargo, our companion and fellow member of the Church. Brother Camargo and his wife were stalwart, faithful people before they joined the Church. They had been brought up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord. Brother Camargo was a graduate of the military academy of Brazil. Later, still a young man, he became a Methodist minister. He told me something of his experience with the "gospel net." One evening two young men called at his home. He said that the first thing he noticed was the huge feet of one of the young men. He looked upward from the feet until he found the face of the tallest North American he had ever met. He was not at first impressed with the beauty of

either the feet or the face. However, he invited the young men in, and in the process of their presentation they left him a copy of the Book of Mormon.

On a subsequent visit they inquired if he had read the book. He explained that he had read considerable, making notes of the things with which he did not agree. The elder then suggested that it was not in keeping with a book of scripture to read it to see what was wrong with it, but that it should be read as Moroni says, "with a sincere heart" and "real intent," having "faith in Christ" and desiring to know the truth of the book. (See Moroni 10:4.)

Brother Camargo said he found it necessary to read the book again. In the process the Spirit witnessed to him that it was the true word of God, and he joined the Church with his family. He sometimes refers to the scripture in Isaiah 52:7 which says, "How beautiful upon the mountains are the feet [those huge missionary feet] of him that bringeth good tidings, that publisheth peace; . . . that sayeth unto Zion, Thy God reigneth!" The truth he has found has brought similar beauty to the feet of three of his sons as they have served as missionaries. All of his children were married in the temple covenant, and he and his wife have great joy and rejoicing in their posterity. One of his sons is present at this conference today as a stake president.

Call to Zion

President J. Reuben Clark, Jr., captured the spirit of this drawing power in his memorable address in 1947 "to them of the last wagon"—our pioneers who endured the hardships of their great journey:

"They had," he said, "their testimony burning always like an eternal fire on a holy altar, that the restored gospel was true. . . .

"When in the evening the last wagon creaked slowly into its place in the circle corral, and the Brethren came to inquire how the day had gone with the mother, then joy leaped in their

hearts, for had not the Brethren remembered them? New hope was born, weariness fled, fresh will to do was enkindled; gratitude to God was poured out for their knowledge of the truth, for their testimony that God lived, that Jesus was the Christ, that Joseph was a prophet, . . . and that for the righteous a crown of glory awaited that should be theirs during the eternities of the life to come."

He states that at the conclusion of their journey, "[they] all sank to their knees in the joy of their souls, thanking God that at last they were in Zion. 'Zion, Zion, lovely Zion, beautiful Zion, Zion, City of our God' " (in Conference Report, Oct. 1947, pp. 157-58).

What a thrill of joy must have moved Andrew as he said to Peter, "We have found the Messiah" (John 1:41). Along with countless thousands, it has "come to pass that the righteous

shall be gathered out from among all nations, and shall come to Zion, singing with songs of everlasting joy" (D&C 45:71).

May we lift our souls this beautiful Easter morning with the assurance that through the mystic call of the restored gospel we have come to the threshold of Zion and the gateway to eternal life. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

Elder Wm. Grant Bangerter, recently sustained as a member of the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy, has just spoken to us.

We shall now be pleased to hear from Elder H. Burke Peterson, who was yesterday sustained a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy, having previously served as First Counselor in the Presiding Bishopric.

Elder H. Burke Peterson

Gratitude

This morning my spirit is subdued as I express my thanks to the Lord for the opportunity to serve and to learn. I am grateful for his trust and confidence. I would also like you to know that I have treasured choice memories involving many faithful employees of the Church, both here and in the far-off reaches of the world. They are Saints of the first order. My feelings are tender as I express my love to Bishop Brown, Bishop Clarke, and Bishop Featherstone, with whom I've served these past years. I will miss the brotherhood of the Presiding Bishopric.

My wife and I are thrilled and honored with the call to devote our efforts and energies in the holy temple. We know somewhat of the magnificent experience this will be. I express my deep appreciation to the Brethren for extend-

ing to us this unusual opportunity for service.

A few years ago I had been assigned with other General Authorities to attend a series of area conferences in New Zealand and Australia. Initially, the leader of our group was to have been President Spencer W. Kimball. However, because of the need for some emergency surgery, he could not travel with us, so President N. Eldon Tanner led the group in his place.

Each day during the trip President Tanner telephoned President Kimball in his hospital room to get a report on his condition and to give a brief report of the conferences in which we were participating. After the daily call to Salt Lake City, President Tanner would always give us a report on the President's condition. We were anxious and appreciated these brief messages.

Once, after we had been out for five or six days, President Tanner made

his usual call to the hospital in Salt Lake City. However, this day he had no report for us. When we asked if he had talked to the President, he told us he had tried, but President Kimball wasn't in his room. "Where was he?" we asked. "They weren't sure; they couldn't find him," President Tanner said. "They thought he might have gone down to the next floor of the hospital to visit the sick."

To paraphrase a statement made by Wendell Phillips, it may be accurately said, "How prudently most men sink into nameless graves, while now and then a few *forget themselves* into immortality" (as quoted by William Jennings Bryan, *The Prince of Peace* [Independence: Zion's Printing and Publishing Co., 1925]).

Christlike patterns for living

In the day-to-day process of living, with all of its trials, challenges, and discouragements, we often underestimate our own God-given attributes and abilities which make it possible for each of us to pattern his or her life after that of the Savior and, in fact, do some of the things he did as he lived here among men. We may never personally experience the miracle of raising the dead, or be one to turn water into wine. We may not be one of thousands who may be fed from a few aves and fishes, or be a part of the miraculous experience of walking on a stormy sea. But for each one of us, there are a number of Christlike patterns of living we can be a part of in our mortal sojourn.

For instance, with us here today there are more than a few who display unquestioning obedience to whatever is asked of them—as did he. There are those who are complete in their forgiveness of the offenses of others—as was he. Some among us are scrupulously honest, even when it isn't convenient—as was he. The list of Christlike attributes and patterns of living goes on and on, as does the list of those who will continue to strive to be obedient,

however difficult it may be. Thank heaven for those who keep trying! They cannot fail.

The selfless person

This morning I would like to teach of another divine attribute—a quality which, when it becomes part of our lives, produces as an outgrowth individuals who are happy in their relationships with others and at peace with themselves and those around them: siblings who enjoy each other more; married couples who cherish their relationships; those who are alone, for whatever reason, who find a fuller and more abundant life. You see, there are those among us today who are completely *selfless*—as was he.

A selfless person is one who is more concerned about the happiness and well-being of another than about his or her own convenience or comfort, one who is willing to serve another when it is neither sought for nor appreciated, or one who is willing to serve even those whom he or she dislikes. A selfless person displays a willingness to sacrifice, a willingness to purge from his or her mind and heart personal wants, and needs, and feelings. Instead of reaching for and requiring praise and recognition for himself, or gratification of his or her own wants, the selfless person will meet these very human needs for others. Remember the words of the Savior as he taught his disciples on an occasion when personal recognition was being sought: "But Jesus called them to him, and saith unto them, . . . whosoever will be great among you, shall be your minister: And whosoever of you will be the chiefest, shall be servant of all. For even the son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give his life a ransom for many" (Mark 10:42-45).

The selfish person

There is another word that sounds almost like the one we have been using. However, it is an ugly word. It de-

scribes a characteristic of satanic proportions. We will not say much of this word, for it is not pleasant to think about, and we don't like to use it. The word is *selfish*. The dictionary describes a selfish person as one who is "concerned excessively or exclusively with oneself: seeking pleasure or well-being without regard for others" (*Webster's Ninth New Collegiate Dictionary*). May we add, a selfish person is often one who refers to "I," "me," and "mine" rather than to "we," "ours," "yours," or "theirs." This person is anxious to be in the limelight, to be on center stage in life's little dramas. He or she may be a poor listener, or a conversation monopolizer. Selfishness is the great unknown sin. No selfish person ever thought himself to be selfish.

Self-evaluation

Now let's be positive again. What can we do to cultivate and nurture this divine quality of selflessness? May I suggest, as a first step, that there be a very careful, introspective evaluation. Consider the behavioral patterns we have just referred to. Do any of them fit your style or conduct? For instance:

—Could you be obedient if you were asked to give up your home for two or three years, leave your children and grandchildren, and go across the world to live in a place much less comfortable than your own home, in a culture strange to you? Many here today have done it without a backward glance.

—To those who live alone: will you feel as lonely if you make a nursing home visit after work before you go home for dinner?

—As a parent, can you take precious time to listen to a son or daughter tell you about what the young people are wearing, or what the teacher said? If you do, *without interrupting*, you may find they'll talk to you when they are *really* troubled because they've learned you listen.

—At a dinner or in a group, notice yourself. Do you take up a large share of the conversation time?

Attitude of service

As part of this self-evaluation process, it is important to remember there can be no successful change in any of us unless we recognize a need to change. That must come first.

With the recognition of the need to improve, may we now suggest that as a part of the process of cultivating and nurturing the attribute of selflessness we begin to develop an attitude of service—the ongoing desire for the well-being of others. A beginning would be feeling empathy for those who need uplifting, then acting with caring thoughtfulness. It could be:

—A telephone visit with someone who lives alone—just to chat about the day's experiences.

—Or perhaps a note to a youth speaker who did his best last Sunday.

—Even a thank-you to an unruly neighbor boy when he *doesn't* jump your fence or smash your flower garden. Remember, those who are not the most attractive in their behavior or looks are the ones who need our caring concern the most.

—Or could it be stopping to talk to someone who is handicapped with whom you've never before taken the time to get acquainted? Are we cultivating an awareness that they have the same longings for love and friendship all of us have and yet usually get so much less?

It is important to break the chains of "self" that bind us. Sincere and sensitive acts in behalf of *others* are the mark of the selfless.

A family experience

Now to those who may be incapacitated in any one of a variety of ways, be it physical, mental, or financial—to those who *cannot* do what you would sincerely *like* to do for

another—let me tell of a personal family experience.

Some months ago my wife drove down to Provo for her customary weekly visit with her mother, who had been ill for some time. On this particular day her mother had been having an unusually difficult time, and didn't have the strength to hold up her head, or even open her eyes. Though she was physically restricted, she was very alert mentally, and as my wife was caring for her many needs of the day she visited with her about family and friends. My wife held her mother's head up with one hand while she fed her with the other, and during the meal their conversation turned to one of our daughters and her husband who have five children under the age of seven. My wife commented to her mother that three of our daughter's children had chicken pox at the same time. The fact that this little mother was unusually busy was obvious. My mother-in-law stopped eating, thought for a moment, and then in a weak, almost inaudible voice said, "I feel so sorry for Robin. I wish I could go to her home and help her." A few moments later, as my wife pondered this wish, she observed, "You know, Mother, I think in your case wanting to is enough. Surely you will receive a blessing for service and selflessness as though you went to her home and helped."

When I was told of the experience, I recalled the words of King Benjamin when, in his final address to his people, he said, "And again, I say unto the poor, ye who have not and yet have sufficient, that ye remain from day to day; I mean all you who deny the beggar, because ye have not; I would that ye say in your hearts that: I give not because I have not, but if I had I would give" (Mosiah 4:24).

It is my feeling that, after all is said and done, it will be the intent of the heart by which we shall be judged. However, let us be careful that we do not fill our hearts with *unjustified ex-*

cuses. Being selfless does not come naturally to most of us. Often it is easier to say, "I can't," or "I'm made differently," or "I don't have time," than it is to become involved in making life happier and more pleasant for others. Let us remember the words from the scriptures:

"Then shall the King say unto them on his right hand, Come, ye blessed of my Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world. . . .

"Then shall the righteous answer him, saying, Lord, when saw we thee an hungred, and fed thee? or thirsty, and gave thee drink?

"When saw we thee a stranger, and took thee in? or naked, and clothed thee?

"Or when saw we thee sick, or in prison, and came unto thee?

"And the King shall answer and say unto them, Verily I say unto you, Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto me" (Matthew 25:34, 37-40).

Selflessness is a beautifully expressive word. It is a divine word expressing a divine pattern of living.

I testify of the selflessness of the Savior. I testify that through his life, his atoning sacrifice, and his resurrection, he has made possible resurrection for all mankind, and eternal life for the obedient. I know that he lives!

In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

The Choir sang "Love Divine" without announcement.

President Hinckley

Elder H. Burke Peterson spoke to us, followed by the choir singing "Love Divine."

Elder Thomas S. Monson of the Council of the Twelve will be our concluding speaker.

Elder Thomas S. Monson

Learning another language

Recently I visited the Missionary Training Center at Provo, Utah, where missionaries who have been called to serve throughout the world are devotedly learning the fundamentals of the languages spoken by the people to whom they shall teach and testify.

Vaguely familiar to me were the conversations in Spanish, French, German, and Swedish. Totally foreign to me and perhaps to most of the missionaries were the sounds of Japanese, Chinese, and Finnish. One marvels at the devotion and total concentration of these young men and women as they grapple with the unfamiliar and learn the difficult.

I am told that on occasion when a missionary in training feels that the Spanish he is called upon to master appears overwhelming or just too hard to learn, he is placed during the luncheon break next to missionaries studying the complex languages of the Orient. He listens. Suddenly Spanish becomes not too overpowering, and he eagerly returns to his study.

Language of the Spirit

There is one language, however, that is understood by each missionary: the language of the Spirit. It is not learned from textbooks written by men of letters, nor is it acquired through reading and memorization. The language of the Spirit comes to him who seeks with all his heart to know God and to keep His divine commandments. Proficiency in this language permits one to breach barriers, overcome obstacles, and touch the human heart.

The Apostle Paul, in his second epistle to the Corinthians, urges that we turn from the narrow confinement of the letter of the law and seek the open vista of opportunity which the Spirit provides. I love and cherish Paul's

statement: "The letter killeth, but the spirit giveth life" (2 Corinthians 3:6).

In a day of danger or a time of trial, such knowledge, such hope, such understanding bring comfort to the troubled mind and grieving heart. The entire message of the New Testament breathes a spirit of awakening to the human soul. Shadows of despair are dispelled by rays of hope, sorrow yields to joy, and the feeling of being lost in the crowd of life vanishes with the certain knowledge that our Heavenly Father is mindful of each of us.

The Savior provided assurance of this truth when He taught that even a sparrow shall not fall to the ground unnoticed by our Father. He then concluded the beautiful thought by saying, "Fear ye not therefore, ye are of more value than many sparrows" (Matthew 10:29-31).

Spiritual answers to questions

We live in a complex world with daily challenges. There is a tendency to feel detached—even isolated—from the Giver of every good gift. We worry that we walk alone.

From the bed of pain, from the pillow wet with the tears of loneliness, we are lifted heavenward by that divine assurance and precious promise, "I will not fail thee, nor forsake thee" (Joshua 1:5).

Such comfort is priceless as we journey along the pathway of mortality, with its many forks and turnings. Rarely is the assurance communicated by a flashing sign or a loud voice. Rather, the language of the Spirit is gentle, quiet, uplifting to the heart and soothing to the soul.

At times, the answers to our questions and the responses to our daily prayers come to us through silent promptings of the Spirit. As William Cowper wrote:

"God moves in a mysterious way
His wonders to perform;
He plants his footsteps in the sea
And rides upon the storm. . . .

"Judge not the Lord by feeble
sense,
But trust him for his grace;
Behind a frowning providence
He hides a smiling face."
(*Hymns*, no. 48.)

Examples of "heart petals"

We watch. We wait. We listen for that still, small voice. When it speaks, wise men and women obey. We do not postpone following promptings of the Spirit.

To address such a sacred subject, may I refer not to the writings of others, but to the actual experiences of my life. I testify to their truth, for I lived them. I share with you today three cherished examples of what President David O. McKay identified as "heart petals"—the language of the Spirit, the promptings from a heavenly source.

First, the inspiration which attends a call to serve.

Second, the gratitude of God for a life well lived.

Third, the knowledge that we do not walk alone.

Inspiration in calls

Every bishop can testify to the promptings which attend calls to serve in the Church. Frequently the call seems to be not so much for the benefit of those to be taught or led as for the person who is to teach or lead.

As a bishop, I worried about any members who were inactive, not attending, not serving. Such was my thought as I drove down the street where Ben and Emily lived. They were older—even in the twilight period of life. Aches and pains of advancing years caused them to withdraw from activity to the shelter of their home—isolated, detached, shut out from

the mainstream of daily life and association.

I felt the unmistakable prompting to park my car and visit Ben and Emily, even though I was on the way to a meeting. It was a sunny weekday afternoon. I approached the door to their home and knocked. Emily answered. When she recognized me, her bishop, she exclaimed, "All day long I have waited for my phone to ring. It has been silent. I hoped that the postman would deliver a letter. He brought only bills. Bishop, how did you know today was my birthday?"

I answered, "God knows, Emily, for He loves you."

In the quiet of the living room, I said to Ben and Emily, "I don't know why I was directed here today, but our Heavenly Father knows. Let's kneel in prayer and ask Him why." This we did, and the answer came. Emily was asked to sing in the choir—even to provide a solo for the forthcoming ward conference. Ben was asked to speak to the Aaronic Priesthood young men and recount a special experience in his life when his safety was assured by responding to the promptings of the Spirit. She sang. He spoke. Hearts were gladdened by the return to activity of Ben and Emily. They rarely missed a sacrament meeting from that day to the time each was called home. The language of the Spirit had been spoken. It had been heard. It had been understood. Hearts were touched and lives saved.

A life well lived

For my second example I turn to the release of a stake president in Star Valley, Wyoming—even the late E. Francis Winters. He had served faithfully for the lengthy term of twenty-three years. Though modest by nature and circumstance, he had been a perpetual pillar of strength to everyone in the valley. On the day of the stake conference, the building was filled to overflowing. Each heart seemed to be saying a silent thank-you to this noble

leader who had given so unselfishly of his life for the benefit of others.

As I stood to speak following the reorganization of the stake presidency, I was prompted to do something I had not done before, nor have I done so since. I stated how long Francis Winters had presided in the stake; then I asked all whom he had blessed or confirmed as children to stand and remain standing. Then I asked all those persons whom President Winters had ordained, set apart, personally counseled, or blessed to please stand. The outcome was electrifying. Every person in the audience stood to his feet. Tears flowed freely—tears which communicated better than could words the gratitude of tender hearts. I turned to President and Sister Winters and said, “We are witnesses today of the prompting of the Spirit. This vast throng reflects not only individual feelings but also the gratitude of God for a life well lived.” No person who was in the congregation that day will forget how he felt when he witnessed the language of the Spirit of the Lord.

We do not walk alone

Finally, I testify that we do not walk alone.

Stan, a dear friend of mine, was taken seriously ill and rendered partially paralyzed. He had been robust in health, athletic in build, and active in many pursuits. Now he was unable to walk or to stand. His wheelchair was his home. The finest of physicians had cared for him, and the prayers of family and friends had been offered in a spirit of hope and trust. Yet Stan continued to lie in the confinement of his bed at the university hospital. He despaired.

Late one afternoon I was swimming at the Deseret Gym, gazing at the ceiling while backstroking width after width. Silently, but ever so clearly, there came to my mind the thought: “Here you swim almost effortlessly, while your friend Stan languishes in his hospital bed, unable to move.” I felt the

prompting: “Get to the hospital and give him a blessing.”

I ceased my swimming, dressed, and hurried to Stan’s room at the hospital. His bed was empty. A nurse said he was in his wheelchair at the swimming pool, preparing for therapy. I hurried to the area, and there was Stan, all alone, at the edge of the deeper portion of the pool. We greeted one another and returned to his room, where a priesthood blessing was provided.

Slowly but surely, strength and movement returned to Stan’s legs. First he could stand on faltering feet. Then he learned once again to walk—step by step. Today one would not know that Stan had lain so close to death and with no hope of recovery.

Frequently Stan speaks in Church meetings and tells of the goodness of the Lord to him. To some he reveals the dark thoughts of depression which engulfed him that afternoon as he sat in his wheelchair at the edge of the pool, sentenced, it seemed, to a life of despair. He tells how he pondered the alternative. It would be so easy to propel the hated wheelchair into the silent water of the deep pool. Life would then be over. But at that precise moment he saw me, his friend. That day Stan learned literally that we do not walk alone. I, too, learned a lesson that day: Never, never, never postpone following a prompting.

As we pursue the journey of life, let us learn the language of the Spirit. May we remember and respond to the Master’s gentle invitation: “Behold, I stand at the door, and knock: if any man hear my voice, and open the door, I will come in to him” (Revelation 3:20). This is the language of the Spirit. He spoke it. He taught it. He lived it. May each of us do likewise, I pray in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

Elder Thomas S. Monson of the Council of the Twelve has been our concluding speaker.

We extend our appreciation to the operators of various broadcasting facilities for all they have done to make it possible for many people in various parts of the world to participate with us. Thank you for your presence this beautiful morning.

The choir will now sing in closing "Sweet Is the Peace the Gospel Brings." The benediction will be of-

fered by Elder Rex C. Reeve of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

The conference will then be adjourned until two o'clock this afternoon.

The choir sang "Sweet Is the Peace the Gospel Brings."

Elder Rex C. Reeve offered the benediction.

SECOND DAY AFTERNOON MEETING

FIFTH SESSION

The fifth and final general session of the 155th Annual General Conference commenced at 2:00 P.M. on Sunday, April 7, 1985.

President Ezra Taft Benson, President of the Council of the Twelve, conducted.

Music was provided by the Tabernacle Choir directed by Jerold Ottley and Donald Ripplinger with Robert Cundick at the organ.

President Benson made the following remarks at the outset of the meeting:

President Ezra Taft Benson

The First Presidency has asked that I conduct this concluding session of the conference

We extend our love and blessings to President Spencer W. Kimball who we are so pleased to have in attendance this afternoon and to President Marion G. Romney who is watching at home.

We extend a sincere welcome to all assembled this afternoon in the Tabernacle on Temple Square in Salt Lake City, Utah. This is the fifth and concluding session of the 155th Annual General Conference of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.

We also welcome those seated in the Assembly Hall where Elders Ted E. Brewerton and Angel Abrea preside.

We send our greetings and blessings to members of the Church and many friends everywhere who are participating in these proceedings by radio, television, cable, and satellite transmission.

The Tabernacle Choir, with Jerold Ottley and Donald Ripplinger directing and Robert Cundick at the organ, is providing the music for this session.

The choir will begin this service by singing "Arise, O God, and Shine." The invocation will be offered by Elder Vaughn J. Featherstone, a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

The choir sang "Arise, O God, and Shine."

Elder Vaughn J. Featherstone offered the invocation.

President Benson

The Tabernacle Choir, assisted by the congregation, will now sing "Consolation: I Am a Child of God." Following the singing, we shall hear from Elder Neal A. Maxwell, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles.

The choir sang "Consolation: I Am a Child of God."

Elder Neal A. Maxwell spoke without further announcement.

Elder Neal A. Maxwell

I do not apologize for trying to speak about one of what Paul called "the deep things of God" (1 Corinthians 2:10), only for my inability to go deeply enough.

Submitting fully to the Lord

While we see this quality in the quiet but spiritually luxuriant lives of the genuine, spiritual heroes and heroines about us, the lack of it keeps so many of us straggling in the foothills and off the peaks in the adventure of full discipleship. I refer to our hesitancy and our holding back in submitting fully to the Lord and His purposes for us.

This holding back is like leaving Egypt without journeying all the way to the Holy Land, or waiting in Nauvoo for the railroad to come through, or staying permanently at Winter Quarters.

Though possessed of other fine attributes, we may still lack this one quality. Such was the case with the righteous young man who knelt sincerely at Jesus' feet. Lacking one thing, he went away sorrowing and unsubmitive when a particularized challenge was given. (See Mark 10:21-22, Luke 18:22-23.) Whether it is walking away without looking back from "great possessions" (Mark 10:22), or from a statusful place in the secular synagogue (see John 12:42-43), or from proud but erroneous attitudes accrued over the years, or merely "straightway" from fishing nets (Mark 1:18), the test is always the same.

"Become as little children"

With honest, individualized introspection, each of us could name what we yet lack—and in my case more than one thing.

Spiritual submissiveness is so much more than bended knee or bowed head. Alas, insofar as we "mind the

things of the flesh" (Romans 8:5), we simply cannot have the "mind of Christ" (1 Corinthians 2:16).

Jesus laid down this sobering requirement: "Except ye . . . become as little children, ye shall not enter into the kingdom of heaven" (Matthew 18:3).

One of Jesus' prophets delineated—with submissiveness thrice stipulated—how a disciple can become "as a child, submissive, meek, humble, patient, full of love, willing to submit to all things which the Lord seeth fit to inflict upon him, even as a child doth submit to his father" (Mosiah 3:19).

Three other clusters of scriptures stress these towering qualities. (See Alma 7:23, 13:28; D&C 121:41-42.) Strikingly parallel, they form an almost seamless litany of attributes to be developed, with submissiveness at their catalytic center. This repeated clustering is too striking to be random.

Be led aright

Moreover, the descriptive simplicity of this quality is matched by its developmental difficulty. It is so easy to be halfhearted, but this only produces half the growth, half the blessings, and just half a life, really, with more bud than blossom.

A superficial view of this life, therefore, will not do, lest we mistakenly speak of this mortal experience only as coming here to get a body, as if we were merely picking up a suit at the cleaners. Or, lest we casually recite how we have come here to be proved, as if a few brisk push-ups and deep knee bends would do.

Just how much submissiveness to circumstance there should be is not treated in these brief remarks. Suffice it to say, God "allotteth unto men" certain things with which we are to be content. (See Alma 29:4, Philippians 4:11, 1 Timothy 6:8.) A missing parent or limb is to be lived without. Yet temper and lust are to be tamed. One's race is

fixed, but one's genetic endowment offers opportunity to be a careful steward. The submissive soul will be led aright, enduring some things well while being anxiously engaged in setting other things right—all the time discerning the difference.

Meekness of mind

Required, in particular, is meekness of mind which recognizes God's perfect love of us and His omniscience. By acknowledging these reassuring realities and accepting that God desires our full development and true happiness, we are readied even as the learning experiences come. Such meekness requires genuine intellectual honesty, owning up to the learning experiences of the past and listening to the Holy Ghost as he preaches to us from the pulpit of memory.

As the Lord communicates with the meek and submissive, fewer decibels are required, and more nuances are received. Even the most meek, like Moses (see Numbers 12:3), learn overwhelming things they "never had supposed" (Moses 1:10). But it is only the meek mind which can be so shown and so stretched—not those, as Isaiah wrote, who "are wise in their own eyes" (Isaiah 5:21; see also 2 Nephi 9:29 and 15:21).

God's counsel aligns us and conjoins us with the great realities of the universe; whereas sin empties, isolates, and separates us, confining us to the solitary cell of selfishness. Hence the lonely crowd in hell.

Spiritual submissiveness means, instead, community and communion as the mind and the heart become settled. We then spend much less time deciding, and much more time serving; otherwise, the more hesitation, the less inspiration.

Yielding one's heart

Yielding one's heart to God signals the last stage in our spiritual development. Only then are we beginning to

be fully useful to God! How can we sincerely pray to be an instrument in His hands if the instrument seeks to do the instructing?

As we really begin to keep the first commandment—loving God with "all thy heart, with all thy might, mind, and strength" (D&C 59:5; see also Matthew 22:37)—giving time, talent, and treasure is then accompanied by fully giving of ourselves.

Sometimes, our holding back occurs because we lack faith or we are too entangled with the cares of the world. Other times, there is in us an understandable tremulousness which slows our yielding, because we sense what further yielding might bring.

Yet we need to break free of our old selves—the provincial, constraining, and complaining selves—and become susceptible to the shaping of the Lord. But the old self goes neither gladly nor quickly. Even so, this subjection to God is really emancipation.

How can we truly acknowledge the Fatherhood of God and refuse His tutorials? Especially in view of the fact, the Lord even chastens those whom He loves. (See Hebrews 12:6, D&C 136:31, Mosiah 23:21, Revelation 3:19.)

Saul, when chosen, was "a choice young man, . . . and there was not among the children of Israel a goodlier person than he" (1 Samuel 9:2). Later, he became encrusted with ego and puffed by power. Samuel then recalled a time when Saul "wast little in [his] own sight" (1 Samuel 15:17). In contrast, true submissiveness greatly enlarges the soul, but *without* hypocrisy and guile. (See D&C 121:42.)

Total surrender

Submissiveness also checks our tendency to demand advance explanations of the Lord as a perplexed yet trusting Nephi understood: "I know that [God] loveth his children; nevertheless, I do not know the meaning of all things" (1 Nephi 11:17).

So did a wondering but submissive Mary: "And Mary said, Behold the handmaid of the Lord; be it unto me according to thy word" (Luke 1:38).

Just as the capacity to defer gratification is a sign of real maturity, likewise the willingness to wait for deferred explanation is a sign of real faith and of trust spread over time.

If faithful, we end up acknowledging that we are in the Lord's hands and should surrender to the Lord on His terms—not ours. It is total surrender, no negotiating; it is yielding with no preconditions.

Suppose Enoch had demurred when called by the Lord? He would have gone on being a good person, serving the Lord part-time, living in a city which was a slum compared to the glorious City of Enoch; nor would Enoch be a part of that scene of glorious greeting yet to come. (See Moses 7:63.)

Suppose Peter had not left his nets "straightway"? (See Mark 1:18.) He might have become the respected president of the local Galilean fishermen's association. But he would not have been on the Mount of Transfiguration with Jesus, Moses, and Elias and heard the voice of God. (See Matthew 17:4.)

Three special words

We have been given three special words—but *if not*—by three submissive young men who entered their fiery furnace, knowing "our God . . . is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, . . . *But if not*, be it known unto thee, O king, that we will not serve thy gods" (Daniel 3:17–18; italics added).

Moreover, our prayers should allow for three more special words: "And whatsoever ye shall ask the Father in my name, *which is right*, believing that ye shall receive, behold it shall be given unto you" (3 Nephi 18:20; italics added).

By yielding to God

It is only by yielding to God that we can begin to realize His will for us. And if we truly trust God, why not yield to His loving omniscience? After all, He knows us and our possibilities much better than do we.

"Nevertheless they did fast and pray oft, and did wax stronger and stronger in their humility, and firmer and firmer in the faith of Christ . . . even to the . . . yielding their hearts unto God" (Helaman 3:5).

Otherwise, one can be too busy promoting his own agenda: "For they being ignorant of God's righteousness, and going about to establish their own righteousness, have not submitted themselves unto the righteousness of God" (Romans 10:3).

Distinguished therefrom is Jesus' clear call: "Wherefore, seek not the things of this world but seek ye first to build up the kingdom of God, and to establish his righteousness" (JST, Matthew 6:38).

While events often induce submissiveness, one's development need not be dramatic or tied to a single moment; it can occur steadily in seemingly ordinary, daily settings. If we are meek, a rich and needed insight can be contained in reproof. A new calling can beckon us away from comfortable routine and from competencies already acquired. One may be stripped of accustomed luxury in order that the malignant mole of materialism be removed. One may feel humiliated in order that pride be chipped away.

The shaping goes on, and it is anything but merely cosmetic.

The tilt of our souls in first moments is so vital. Will what follows be viewed with disdain or as having some design? Which will we do most, murmur or ponder?

While most of our suffering is self-inflicted, some is caused by or permitted by God. This sobering reality calls for deep submissiveness, especially when God does not remove the cup from us. In such circumstances,

when reminded about the premortal shouting for joy as this life's plan was unfolded (see Job 38:7), we can perhaps be pardoned if, in some moments, we wonder what all the shouting was about.

For the faithful, what finally emerges is an understanding of "things as they really are" (Jacob 4:13), such as the reassuring realization that we are in the Lord's hands! But, brothers and sisters, we were never really anywhere else! Demonstrating this great attitude is our beloved and submissive brother, Bruce R. McConkie.

"Know ye not that ye are in the hands of God?" (Mormon 5:23.) Likewise, "all flesh" (D&C 101:16, Moses 6:32) and "the heavens and the earth" (D&C 67:2)! Perhaps the realization of being in God's hands comes fully only as we ponder the significance of the prints in the hands of our submissive Savior. (See 3 Nephi 11:14-15.) Some will have to ask what those wounds are, having been estranged. (See D&C 45:51-52.) These are they who "regard not the work of the Lord, neither consider the operation of his hands" (2 Nephi 15:12).

Pondering the awesome atonement

The more we study, pray, and ponder the awesome Atonement, the more we are willing to acknowledge that we are in His and the Father's hands. Let us ponder, therefore, these final things.

When the unimaginable burden began to weigh upon Christ, it confirmed His long-held and intellectually clear understanding as to what He must now do. His working through began, and Jesus declared: "Now is my soul troubled; and what shall I say? Father, save me from this hour." Then, whether in spiritual soliloquy or by way of instruction to those about Him, He observed, "But for this cause came I unto this hour" (John 12:27).

Later, in Gethsemane, the suffering Jesus began to be "sore amazed"

(Mark 14:33), or, in the Greek, "awe-struck" and "astonished."

Imagine, Jehovah, the Creator of this and other worlds, "astonished"! Jesus knew cognitively what He must do, but not experientially. He had never personally known the exquisite and exacting process of an atonement before. Thus, when the agony came in its fullness, it was so much, much worse than even He with his unique intellect had ever imagined! No wonder an angel appeared to strengthen him! (See Luke 22:43.)

The cumulative weight of all mortal sins—past, present, and future—pressed upon that perfect, sinless, and sensitive Soul! All our infirmities and sicknesses were somehow, too, a part of the awful arithmetic of the Atonement. (See Alma 7:11-12, Isaiah 53:3-5, Matthew 8:17.) The anguished Jesus not only pled with the Father that the hour and cup might pass from Him, but with this relevant citation. "And he said, Abba, Father, all things are possible unto thee; take away this cup from me" (Mark 14:35-36).

Had not Jesus, as Jehovah, said to Abraham, "Is any thing too hard for the Lord?" (Genesis 18:14). Had not His angel told a perplexed Mary, "For with God nothing shall be impossible"? (Luke 1:37; see also Matthew 19:28, Mark 10:27, Luke 18:27).

Jesus' request was not theater!

In this extremity, did He, perchance, hope for a rescuing ram in the thicket? I do not know. His suffering—as it were, *enormity* multiplied by *infinity*—evoked His later soul-cry on the cross, and it was a cry of forsakenness. (See Matthew 27:46.)

Even so, Jesus maintained this sublime submissiveness, as He had in Gethsemane: "Nevertheless not as I will, but as thou wilt" (Matthew 26:39).

While bearing our sins, our infirmities, our sicknesses, and bringing to pass the Atonement (see Alma 7:11-12), Jesus became the perfect Shepherd, making these lines of Paul's especially relevant and reassuring:

"Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword?" (Romans 8:35).

Indeed, we are in His hands, and what hallowed hands!

The wondrous and glorious Atonement was the central act in all of human history. It was the hinge on which all else that finally matters turned. But it turned upon Jesus' spiritual submissiveness!

May we now, in our time and turn, be "willing to submit" (Mosiah 3:19),

I pray in the name of Jesus Christ, amen!

President Benson

Elder Neal A. Maxwell, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, has just spoken to us.

We shall now hear from Elder J. Richard Clarke, who was released yesterday as Second Counselor in the Presiding Bishopric and sustained as a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

Elder J. Richard Clarke

Brothers and sisters, this has been a wonderful week. We have been so spiritually fed, and I pray now that I might be able to share something that will be appropriate.

Before doing so, I would like to express my love and appreciation to Bishop Brown and to Bishop Peterson for eight and a half wonderful years of association in the Presiding Bishopric. And to the Seventy and the Twelve and the First Presidency who have been so supportive and encouraging, I express my love and continued support for them. I also would like to acknowledge those wonderful brothers and sisters who work behind the scenes here at headquarters and throughout the world to provide so many services and resources to help move the work along.

It's marvelous to be in the service of the Lord and now to be called as a witness for our Lord and Savior and to return to a land that I love more than I can express. It's just about as much emotion as I can handle at one time. So I pray that I might be able to fulfill the expectations of that wonderful call.

Covenant children of Abraham

In the Pearl of Great Price we read that the Lord delivered Abraham from

idolatrous sacrifice. He introduced Himself as Jehovah and declared, "[Abraham], I will lead thee by my hand, and I will . . . put upon thee my name, even the Priesthood of thy father, and my power shall be over thee. . . .

[And] through thy ministry my name shall be known in the earth forever, for I am thy God" (Abraham 1:18-19).

This blessing was extended to Abraham's posterity, who would "bear this ministry and Priesthood unto all nations." (See Abraham 2:9.) The covenant children of Abraham were to be distinguished by their sacred obligation to declare to the world the true and living God. Not only were they to be believers and worshipers, but His witnesses, boldly testifying of Him among the unbelievers.

God has once again spoken from the heavens and restored the fulness of the gospel through His chosen prophet. We have become the covenant children of Abraham, a new generation of witnesses to bear testimony that God lives and Jesus is the Christ. We are to be a pure people, a holy people, fully committed and zealous in our proclamation of the gospel in word and deed. This is an awesome responsibility.

“Stand as witnesses of God”

In the Book of Mormon we are told that “to be called His people” we must be willing “to stand as witnesses of God at all times and in all things, and in all places, . . . even until death” (Mosiah 18:8–9). As individual members of the Church it is in the everyday context of our lives that this witness we exemplify comes under constant scrutiny.

May I share with you a personal experience to illustrate how humbling this can be? I was employed by a major corporation for almost twenty-five years. During those years I developed a personal friendship with a fine business associate from Texas. Our careers paralleled each other very closely. A few years ago, he presented me with a most unusual gift, which I shall always cherish. It was a large, molded bronze, personalized coat of arms. He said, “I have been observing you for many years and have created an original coat of arms using symbols which I believe represent the four most important values to which you have committed your life, namely, your church, your family, your profession, and your quest for personal development.”

Naturally, I was surprised, deeply impressed, and flattered. As the significance of this gift settled upon my mind, the thought of someone quietly taking mental notes of my actions, attitudes, and values fired my imagination. I realized the weighty responsibility each of us has to demonstrate accurately the principles and priorities to which we are committed. It was like a mini-foretaste of Judgment Day!

I thought of the scripture in Revelation in which John saw the books opened, “and the dead were judged out of those things which were written in the books, according to their works” (Revelation 20:12). It was a most sobering experience.

“Hold up your light”

All of us give our lives daily for what we believe is important. Those with whom we associate are silently assessing us, our values and character traits. Is there anything about our daily conduct we would change if we knew someone was doing a written appraisal for publication?

Suppose you received, as the head of a family, a telephone call from your stake president, who said, “The local newspaper is doing a series of articles on the Church. They have asked permission for a reporter to move into one of our homes for a week to observe firsthand what a Mormon family is really like. We have selected you to represent the Church in our stake.”

You say, “Yes, President, we will be happy to do it.” You have seven children ranging from age two months to a nineteen-year-old son awaiting his mission call. Little time is allowed for “sprucing” things up—just a typical week with life as you live it.

This actually happened to Max and Nettie Ann Nelson of Boise, Idaho, in 1983. How proud I was of this fine family as I read the reporter’s account. What a positive impression was made upon him. The question going through your mind is possibly the same one that I had: “If our family were selected, would we be ready?”

To the Nephites Jesus said, “Hold up your light that it may shine unto the world. Behold I am the light which ye shall hold up” (3 Nephi 18:24).

In a related admonition, Peter counseled “that ye should shew forth the praises of him who hath called you out of darkness into his marvellous light. . . .

“Abstain from fleshly lusts, which war against the soul;

“Having your conversation honest among the Gentiles: that . . . they may by your good works, which they shall behold, glorify God in the day of visitation” (1 Peter 2:9, 11–12).

To the Israelites and again to the Nephites the Lord commanded: “Thou

shalt not bear false witness." (See Exodus 20:16, Mosiah 13:23.) Are we not false witnesses if we are untrue to gospel principles we profess but do not practice?

Character under pressure

Most damage to the collective reputation of the Church is done by those members who want to straddle the line, with one foot in the kingdom and the other foot in spiritual Babylon. Those who so compromise their principles want to play for both teams at once—the Lord's and Satan's—as if to say, "I want to wait and see which side is winning before I declare myself."

There are some members who are not concerned about their outward appearances and actions, rationalizing that they know what they really are on the inside. These individuals inevitably are judged "guilty by association." To be judged fairly, we must avoid the very appearance of evil. We would do well to remember the words quoted by President McKay: "Whate'er thou art, act well thy part." (See *Cherished Experiences*, comp. Claire Middlemiss [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1955], pp. 174–75.)

Character is revealed under pressure. Let me illustrate. A few years ago, Elder Gordon B. Hinckley related this inspiring story:

"I talked with a young man recently returned from the war. He too had walked the jungle patrols, his heart pounding with fear. But reluctantly he admitted that the greatest fear he had was the fear of ridicule.

"The men of his company laughed at him, taunted him, plastered him with a nickname that troubled him. They told him the things they reveled in. Then on one occasion when the going was rough, he faced them and quietly said, 'Look, I know you think I'm a square. I don't consider myself any better than any of the rest of you. . . . But I grew up in a different way. I grew up in a religious home and a religious town. I went to church on Sundays. We

prayed together as a family. I was taught to stay away from these things. It's just that I believe differently. With me it's a matter of religion, and it's kind of a way of respecting my mother and my dad. All of you together might force me toward a compromising situation, but that wouldn't change me, and you wouldn't feel right after you'd done it.'

"One by one they turned silently away. But during the next few days each came to ask his pardon, and from his example others gained the strength and the will to change their own lives. He taught the gospel to two of them and brought them into the church" (*Church News*, 29 Apr. 1972, p. 14).

True witnesses among youth

As Church members, we all benefit when one of us is honorable and righteous. Some years ago I made a speech at a business convention. When I concluded, a distinguished gentleman came up to me and asked, "Are you a Mormon?" I responded, "Yes." He said, "I am associated with John Russon, a member of your church. He is the finest practicing Christian I have had the pleasure to know." To him, and I'm sure to countless others, Brother Russon, now the president of the St. George Temple, is a reliable witness.

One of our greatest needs is for true witnesses among our youth. Young people need models from their own generation. Thankfully we have a tremendous army of latter-day sons and daughters of Helaman, stripping "Saturday's warriors," who are not ashamed of the gospel of Jesus Christ. Rather, they have turned this commitment to the Lord into an advantage. Let me tell you of one.

Steve Hawes is the student body president at New Canaan High School in Connecticut. Of its twenty-three hundred students, only twenty-four are Latter-day Saints. Steve ran unopposed in a landslide election. This is impressive. But even more impressive is Steve's moral courage—his

commitment to living the principles of the gospel.

The Hawes family lived for a time in Tampa, Florida. Steve played junior high football and basketball. When his family was preparing to move to Connecticut, the coach told Steve's father how much he appreciated and admired Steve, not just because he is a fine athlete, but because of his deep religious convictions.

"He doesn't preach sermons; he just quietly lives his religion each day. I remember," said the coach, "a group of us were in the squad room, and one of the boys pulled out a copy of *Playboy* magazine. They opened to the centerfold and began to make some vulgar comments.

"I noticed Steve walk away, so I followed him and asked if anything was wrong. He said, 'I'm okay, Coach, but that just isn't my kind of thing.'"

The coach said, "Steve made us all better people. When he joined us, most of the guys were swearing. Then they stopped swearing around Steve, and af-

ter a while, they pretty well stopped swearing altogether."

When I heard this tribute, I thought of Paul's counsel to Timothy: "Be thou an example of the believers, in word, in conversation, in charity, in spirit, in faith, in purity" (1 Timothy 4:12).

"Ye are my witnesses," said the Lord through Isaiah (Isaiah 43:10).

Let us stand tall, brothers and sisters, and be not ashamed to take upon us the name of Christ. May God bless us as a church and as individuals that the testimony we bear as His witnesses will be true and clear and fully reliable, I humbly pray in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ, amen.

President Benson

Elder J. Richard Clarke, a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy, has just addressed us.

We shall now be pleased to hear from Bishop Henry B. Eyring, who was sustained yesterday as the First Counselor in the Presiding Bishopric.

Bishop Henry B. Eyring

On Friday morning, President Hinckley called me to serve as a counselor to Bishop Hales in the Presiding Bishopric. I am grateful for the call and for the knowledge that it is the Savior who makes such calls through his servants in his Church. And I am grateful for your sustaining vote, which surely must stem from your conviction that God issued that call.

Love and confidence, and solicitude

During the meetings yesterday, I was overwhelmed in two ways by the reaction of the General Authorities. First, they expressed love and confidence, which I deeply appreciate. But second, I felt, in addition to that same

love from Bishops Brown, Peterson, and Clarke, an added expression of almost solicitude. I realized they knew what was ahead of me, and I sensed they might know the growing feeling in my heart that I was overwhelmed by the task ahead. As that feeling increased, I began to think more and more of me. But then I remembered that, in the past few weeks, a deacon has come home with the rolls to announce he was the new quorum secretary; a teacher has been called to preside in his quorum; a mother has been called to be a counselor in a Relief Society presidency; and a nineteen-year-old boy has been called to go to a new city with a new missionary companion. To each of them, and to each of you, fear of failure

might try to poke its head in, as it has with me.

A youthful testimony

Something happened to me yesterday afternoon that I found of great help to me, and it may be of help to you. Since that moment, the fear has gone. It was when Bishop Hales was speaking in conference. He mentioned that we had known each other since boyhood, and as he did a memory was replayed in my mind. It was of a hotel ballroom in New Brunswick, New Jersey. Bishop Hales was likely not there, since he lived in what seemed to us the well-established stake in New York. We were in the New Jersey District, a single district that covered the whole state. The Princeton Branch met in my parents' dining room. Dad was the branch president. Mother was both the pianist and chorister (which is hard to do if you think about it). There was not another family in the branch with children, so my brother Ted was the Aaronic Priesthood, and my brother, Harden, and I were all there were of Primary and junior Sunday School. The congregations were young students who happened to be there, like Jim Fletcher and Neil Zundle, and a few older converts—none with spouses that were members.

There was no building, no gym, no stake center, and so we traveled to a hotel ballroom for what must have been a district conference. I was sitting on a folding chair somewhere near the back, next to my mother. I must have been very young because I can remember putting my legs through the back of the chair and sitting aft instead of forward. But then I remember hearing something—a man's voice from the pulpit. I turned around and looked. I still remember that the speaker was at a rostrum set on wooden risers. There was a tall window behind him. He was the priesthood visitor. I don't know who he was, but he was tall and bald, and he seemed very old to me.

He must have been talking about the Savior or the Prophet Joseph, or both, because that was all that I remember much of hearing in those days. But as he spoke, I knew that what he said came from God and that it was true, and it burned in my heart. That was before scholars told me how hard it was to know. I just knew of certainty—I knew it was true. And when I listened to Bishop Hales yesterday, I knew that what he was saying was from God and that it was true, and then the fear left.

Listen for the Master's voice

You can have that same confidence, not of yourself, but from God. He lives, and he communicates with his children. This is the Church of Jesus Christ, and he leads it. No assignment in it need ever overwhelm you if you know that and listen for the Master's voice.

Now I can hear the young deacons saying, "Well, now, that may be fine for you, but surely you don't think that's going to help me in my assignment down here in this deacons quorum." Oh yes, I do. Between being a high counselor and a member of the general board of the Sunday School, I was a deacons quorum adviser. A boy, the president, presided in the meetings, and I taught the lessons out of the scriptures and out of the manual. I stayed very close to the lessons as they were outlined.

I remember one boy in the quorum had to miss a few meetings, and so he sent his brother to the class with a tape recorder. His brother recorded our meeting and took it home. It happened more than once. When the deacon came back, I asked him why. I don't remember his words, but I remember that it was clear he knew what I knew. God was trying to speak to that deacons quorum. The boy wasn't anxious to have a tape recording to hear me; he was trying to hear God. He knew where to listen and how to hear.

He'd read the scriptures for us in class, and I knew he knew them and

loved them. And so, even when I wasn't teaching very well, by the power of the Holy Ghost and from knowing the Master's voice in the scriptures, he could hear what he needed to hear. The memory of that black recorder with its tape turning will always remind me of the scripture which says, "He that hath ears to hear, let him hear" (Matthew 11:15).

I spoke at his funeral just a few years later. He lived about as many years as the Prophet Joseph had lived when he saw God the Father and Jesus Christ in the grove. My deacon hadn't seen a vision, but he had heard the voice of God through his servants in a deacons quorum. He wanted to hear, he knew how, and he had the faith he could. Like the boy prophet Joseph, he knew the heavens were open.

Study, pray, and tune hearts and ears

You and I can take confidence in that assurance. If you and I will study the scriptures and pray and tune our hearts and ears, we will hear the voice of God in the voice of the people that he has sent to teach and guide us and direct us. I heard it yesterday as I listened to Bishop Hales, and I heard it last evening in the priesthood session as I listened to the recorded voice of President Kimball, a prophet of God. You and I can take confidence in that assurance for the Church itself. However large the kingdom will grow (and it will fill the earth), you will not ever feel lost or forgotten, and you need never feel overwhelmed. God will call people to care about you and to teach you. And if you will listen and hear the voice of God, the kingdom will roll forth to its appointed place, ready for the coming of the Master.

None of us can see now all the wonders of technology and organization and buildings that God may give us; but you, just you, hearing the voice of God through your teacher and leader, will always be at its heart.

Gratitude for heritage

I'm grateful for the gift given to me of ears to hear. One of my great-grandfathers, John Bennion, walked or rode his horse from over Jordan to this place to hear his name called out to go on a mission to Dixie. His journal doesn't say much, except just that the next day he prepared to go, and he went. His assignment was to be a shepherd. In his journal there is a record of an evening in which he met with Erastus Snow. He said another man was in the room; his name was Henry Eyring. And somewhere in St. George that night was Bishop Miles Romney. They talked about sheep. And you might have thought they were talking about something temporal. But not to those men, because they knew they were God's sheep, and they knew they were for God's people. And they knew how to listen, and they knew how to do what they heard.

John Bennion went on another mission to Wales and back again to this valley. Henry Eyring went on to Colonia Juarez, as Miles Romney did. And they left for me a tradition which I deeply appreciate. They were the yeomen of the Church, the soldiers of the Church, and my great-grandfathers. You can't find in their journals records of the positions they held, just of the instructions they heard, and knew were from God, and followed. I'm grateful to my parents who handed me that heritage undiminished. I'm grateful to my wife, who more than once has heard when I did not and gently said, "Would you pray about it?" If my sons and daughters will listen to her, and hear through her what God has in mind for them, we will pass the heritage on again.

God lives, Jesus is the Christ, Joseph Smith in fact saw God and His Son and received all the keys of the priesthood. And President Kimball holds them today. I testify that God loves his children and can tell us what is true. I pray that we all may have ears to hear, that he may guide us. I pray that

I may serve you and him, in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ, amen.

President Benson

Bishop Henry B. Eyring, First Counselor in the Presiding Bishopric, has just addressed us.

The choir and congregation will now join in singing "We Thank Thee, O God, for a Prophet," following which Bishop Glenn L. Pace, Second Counselor in the Presiding Bishopric, will speak to us.

The choir and congregation sang "We Thank Thee, O God, for a Prophet."

President Benson

Bishop Glenn L. Pace, who was sustained yesterday as Second Counselor in the Presiding Bishopric, will now address us. He will be followed by Elder Dallin H. Oaks, a member of the Council of the Twelve.

Bishop Glenn L. Pace

President Kimball, we love you. Prior to getting into my text, let me offer my apologies to you in the audience and across the world who must listen to these proceedings through a translator. During the past year, I have been privileged to travel extensively in your lands, and I have a feeling of love and respect for you. I apologize that I cannot speak to you in your language. May the Lord bless us, as I speak, that you will be able to hear things just as personally as if I were speaking in your language. Perhaps the day will come when we Saints on the Wasatch Front will have to put on earphones so we can understand what's going on.

Humility and confidence

I hope I can convey to you the humility with which I approach this calling. I've just recently been released as a second counselor. What does one say, when one day you are the second counselor of the Bountiful Thirteenth Ward bishopric, and the next day you're the Second Counselor in the Presiding Bishopric. In the Regional Representatives' seminar Friday morning, Elder Russell M. Nelson reminisced that last year he was sitting in the Regional Representatives' seminar—sitting very inconspicuously in the

back, and very comfortably. Later that day he received an interview which turned his life upside down.

Last Friday I was in the Regional Representatives' seminar, but my ticket wasn't stamped "Regional Representative"; it was stamped "Invited Guest." By four o'clock that afternoon, I had received a letter signed by President Hinckley telling me I was to speak for thirteen minutes in the Sunday afternoon session of conference.

My first question to President Hinckley wasn't "What should I say?" It was "How do I get in?"

As late as last Wednesday night, I was rehearsing for a ward play. (By the way, Sister Lalli, wherever you are, I'm sorry I wasn't to play practice yesterday morning.) I was released from the bishopric in January after serving for four years. How I loved that calling, and the brethren with whom I served—Bishop Lee J. Lalli, and his able and dedicated first counselor, D. Ray Alexander—Lee J. and Ray, as I affectionately called them.

Since my release I've been traveling extensively, and therefore have been without a calling for two months. At that play practice Wednesday, I sent a signal to the new bishop, Russ Herscher, that I was ready to reenter the "job market." I hope you won't feel that

I'm an aspiring person, but I told the Primary president, Susan Mabey, I wanted to teach Primary—ideally my seven-year-old daughter's class. I know sanctification comes not with any particular calling, but with genuine acts of service, often for which there is no specific calling.

Now, despite the humility with which I approach this call, I have full confidence in my ability to perform. This, however, is not self-confidence, but confidence in the fact that the Lord makes every man and woman equal to the assignment that he or she is given. Therefore, I state clearly but humbly, "I will go and do the things which the Lord hath commanded, for I know that the Lord giveth no commandments unto the children of men, save he shall prepare a way for them that they may accomplish the thing which he commandeth them" (1 Nephi 3:7).

Brothers and sisters, I have never been a bishop. Since Friday afternoon I have felt puzzled, almost bewildered and overwhelmed, at how a man could be called to be a member of the Presiding Bishopric without having had the experience of being a bishop. I agonized for twenty-four hours until yesterday afternoon, when President Hinckley laid his hands upon my head and ordained me a bishop. I heard the voice of the Lord say in my heart, "No, Glenn, you have never been a bishop, but now you are a bishop, and always will be."

Loss of anonymity

Several years ago, I made a covenant with the Lord. I promised to give him anything he should require of me, and prayed this gesture might warrant forgiveness of my transgressions. Yesterday I gave the only thing I had left. It was something I cherished. I held onto it until the very last moment. I never thought of it as a selfish possession. That of which I speak flew out the window of my home when I turned on the television to watch the news and saw my picture on the television

screen. I speak of my prized remaining possession—anonymity.

How I love not to be noticed! I don't want to sit with the General Authorities in the "fishbowl" at the BYU football games in my dark blue suit! I want to sit in the stands with my father, wearing an obnoxious T-shirt which reads: "BYU #1. Enough said!" I have license and credentials to be obnoxious! I was born and raised in Provo, Utah. I attended school at Provo High School. I received my bachelor's and master's degrees from BYU. I'm a member of the Church, and I even work for the Church. My credentials are impeccable. I want to go berserk in the upper tier of the San Diego Stadium as I have the last four years at the Holiday Bowl—with the exception of Ohio State [which soundly beat BYU's team in the bowl game], when I went into deep depression. I still have one faint hope—perhaps the Brethren will let me sit with Elder Perry at the ball games. Nevertheless, I give up my prized anonymity, just as I will give up my life if it is required of me.

Transformation, love and loyalty

I love the Lord Jesus Christ. I love the transformation his atonement has wrought in me. Earlier speakers have spoken of him with such eloquence. How I wish I had command of the language which would enable me to express my feelings on this Easter afternoon. May I add my simple testimony to those who have spoken articulately. I once was in darkness, and now see light. I once lost all of my confidence, and now know all things are possible in the Lord. I once felt shame and now am "filled with his love, even unto the consuming of my flesh" (2 Nephi 4:21). "I am encircled about eternally in the arms of his love" (2 Nephi 1:15).

I express my deepest loyalty to Bishop Hales and his First Counselor, Bishop Eyring. I will not betray their trust. I express my love and loyalty to the First Presidency, the Council of the

Twelve Apostles, the First Quorum of the Seventy, and those I love most—the rank-and-file members of the Church. I express my love to my wife; without her love and understanding, I literally would not be standing at this pulpit today. I love my children, who must also give up their anonymity, as well as some time with their father. How I wish I could embrace my oldest son, who is serving a mission in the Cook Islands!

I thank God I was born of goodly parents. I begged my mother not to stand and take my picture as I came to the stand for the first time yesterday morning! But what would I have done if, during my formative years, she had not demonstrated that same pride and enthusiasm for everything I accomplished, however small. My father, Bishop Kenneth L. Pace, was the bishop of the Bonneville Ward in the East Provo Stake during my teens. He remains uppermost in my mind as exemplifying the pure love of Christ throughout his life.

Prayer of my heart

Finally, I share the prayer of my heart with you at this time. May I display in my service the courage of my convictions in a manner like unto that displayed by Bishop Victor L. Brown. May I acquire the inspired, objective judgment of Bishop H. Burke Peterson. And may I acquire the open, warm, Christlike personality of Bishop J. Richard Clarke. May I exhibit the love and loyalty to Bishop Hales taught to us so beautifully by Joseph's beloved brother, Hyrum. And lastly, may we as a Bishopric acquire the same love, respect, and unity I felt in the bishopric of the Bountiful Thirteenth Ward with Bishop Lee J. Lalli and D. Ray Alexander, in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

Elder Dallin H. Oaks spoke without further announcement.

Elder Dallin H. Oaks

To partake of the sacrament

On this Easter Sunday we rejoice in the resurrection of our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ. This is a holy day for all of Christianity. Countless Christians attend worship services on this day to partake of the sacrament of the Lord's Supper, which many call communion. (See 1 Corinthians 10:16.)

Members of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints are commanded to partake of the sacrament each week. (See D&C 59:9, 12.) In doing so, they witness unto God the Eternal Father, as stated in the prayer on the bread, that they are "willing to take upon them the name of thy Son, and always remember him and keep his commandments which he has given them" (D&C 20:77, Moroni 4:3). We

should ponder these sacred covenants during the sacrament service.

On this Easter Sunday it is appropriate to reflect on what it means to partake of the sacrament. I will focus on the first of these solemn "witnesses" to God the Eternal Father: that we are willing to take upon us the name of his Son. What does this mean?

Taking upon us the name of Jesus Christ

Our witness that we are willing to take upon us the name of Jesus Christ has several different meanings. Some of these meanings are obvious, and well within the understanding of our children. Others are only evident to those who have searched the scriptures and pondered the wonders of eternal life.

One of the obvious meanings renews a promise we made when we were baptized. Following the scriptural pattern, persons who are baptized "witness before the Church that they have truly repented of all their sins, and are willing to take upon them the name of Jesus Christ, having a determination to serve him to the end" (D&C 20:37; see also 2 Nephi 31:13, Moroni 6:3). When we partake of the sacrament, we renew this covenant and all the other covenants we made in the waters of baptism. (See Joseph Fielding Smith, *Doctrines of Salvation*, comp. Bruce R. McConkie, 3 vols. [Salt Lake City: Bookcraft, 1954-56], 2:341, 346.)

As a second obvious meaning, we take upon us our Savior's name when we become members of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. By his commandment, this church bears his name. (See D&C 115:4, 3 Nephi 27:7-8.) Every member, young and old, is a member of the "household of God" (Ephesians 2:19). As true believers in Christ, as Christians, we have gladly taken his name upon us. (See Alma 46:15.) As King Benjamin taught his people, "Because of the covenant which ye have made ye shall be called the children of Christ, his sons, and his daughters; for behold, this day he hath spiritually begotten you" (Mosiah 5:7; see also Alma 5:14, 36:23-26).

We also take upon us the name of Jesus Christ whenever we publicly proclaim our belief in him. Each of us has many opportunities to proclaim our belief to friends and neighbors, fellow workers, and casual acquaintances. As the Apostle Peter taught the Saints of his day, we should "sanctify the Lord God in [our] hearts: and be ready always to give an answer to every man that asketh [us] a reason of the hope that is in [us]" (1 Peter 3:15). In this, we keep the modern commandment: "Take upon you the name of Christ, and speak the truth in soberness" (D&C 18:21).

A third meaning appeals to the understanding of those mature enough to know that a follower of Christ is obligated to serve him. Many scriptural ref-

erences to the name of the Lord seem to be references to the work of his kingdom. Thus, when Peter and the other Apostles were beaten, they rejoiced "that they were counted worthy to suffer shame for his name" (Acts 5:41). Paul wrote certain members who had ministered to the Saints that the Lord would not forget the labor of love they had "shewed toward his name" (Hebrews 6:10). According to this meaning, by witnessing our willingness to take upon us the name of Jesus Christ, we signify our willingness to do the work of his kingdom.

In these three relatively obvious meanings, we see that we take upon us the name of Christ when we are baptized in his name, when we belong to his Church and profess our belief in him, and when we do the work of his kingdom.

There are other meanings as well, deeper meanings that the more mature members of the Church should understand and ponder as he or she partakes of the sacrament.

Authority of God and exaltation

It is significant that when we partake of the sacrament we do not witness that we *take upon us* the name of Jesus Christ. We witness that we are *willing* to do so. (See D&C 20:77.) The fact that we only witness to our willingness suggests that something else must happen before we actually take that sacred name upon us in the most important sense.

What future event or events could this covenant contemplate? The scriptures suggest two sacred possibilities, one concerning the authority of God, especially as exercised in the temples, and the other—closely related—concerning exaltation in the celestial kingdom.

The name of God is sacred. The Lord's prayer begins with the words, "Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name" (Matthew 6:9). From Sinai came the commandment, "Thou shalt not take the name of the

Lord thy God in vain" (Exodus 20:7, Deuteronomy 5:11). Latter-day revelation equates this with using the name of God without authority. "Let all men beware how they take my name in their lips," the Lord declares in a modern revelation, for "many there be who . . . use the name of the Lord, and use it in vain, having not authority" (D&C 63:61-62).

Consistent with these references, many scriptures that refer to "the name of Jesus Christ" are obviously references to the authority of the Savior. This was surely the meaning conveyed when the seventy reported to Jesus that "even the devils are subject unto us through thy name" (Luke 10:17). The Doctrine and Covenants employs this same meaning when it describes the Twelve Apostles of this dispensation as "they who shall desire to take upon them my name with full purpose of heart" (D&C 18:27). The Twelve are later designated as "special witnesses of the name of Christ in all the world," and as those who "officiate in the name of the Lord, under the direction of the Presidency of the Church" (D&C 107:23, 33).

The significance of temples

By way of further illustration, the Old Testament contains scores of references to the name of the Lord in a context where it clearly means the authority of the Lord. Most of these references have to do with the temple.

When the children of Israel were still on the other side of the Jordan, the Lord told them that when they entered the promised land there should be a place where the Lord their God would "cause his name to dwell" (Deuteronomy 12:11; see also Deuteronomy 14:23-24, 16:6). Time after time in succeeding revelations, the Lord and his servants referred to the future temple as a house for "the name" of the Lord God of Israel. (See 1 Kings 3:2; 5:5; 8:16-20, 29, 44, 48; 1 Chronicles 22:8-10, 19; 29:16; 2 Chronicles 2:4; 6:5-10, 20, 34, 38.) After the temple

was dedicated, the Lord appeared to Solomon and told him that He had hallowed the temple "to put my name there for ever" (1 Kings 9:3, 2 Chronicles 7:16).

Similarly, in modern revelations the Lord refers to temples as houses built "unto my holy name" (D&C 124:39, 105:33, 109:2-5). In the inspired dedicatory prayer of the Kirtland Temple, the Prophet Joseph Smith asked the Lord for a blessing upon "thy people upon whom thy name shall be put in this house" (D&C 109:26).

All of these references to ancient and modern temples as houses for "the name" of the Lord obviously involve something far more significant than a mere inscription of his sacred name on the structure. The scriptures speak of the Lord's putting his name in a temple because he gives authority for his name to be used in the sacred ordinances of that house. That is the meaning of the Prophet's reference to the Lord's putting his name upon his people in that holy house. (See D&C 109:26.)

Willingness to take upon us the name of Jesus Christ can therefore be understood as willingness to take upon us the authority of Jesus Christ. According to this meaning, by partaking of the sacrament we witness our willingness to participate in the sacred ordinances of the temple and to receive the highest blessings available through the name and by the authority of the Savior when he chooses to confer them upon us.

Called by his name

Another future event we may anticipate when we witness our willingness to take that sacred name upon us concerns our relationship to our Savior and the incomprehensible blessings available to those who will be called by his name at the last day.

King Benjamin told his people, "There shall be no other name given nor any other way nor means whereby salvation can come unto the children of men, only in and through the name of

Christ, the Lord Omnipotent" (Mosiah 3:17; see also 2 Nephi 31:21). Peter proclaimed "the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth" to the leaders of the Jews, declaring that "there is none other name under heaven given among men, whereby we must be saved" (Acts 4:10, 12; see also D&C 18:21).

The scriptures proclaim that the Savior's atoning sacrifice was for those who "believe on his name." Alma taught that Jesus Christ, the Son, the Only Begotten of the Father, would come "to take away the sins of the world, yea, the sins of every man who steadfastly believeth on his name" (Alma 5:48, 9:27, 11:40; Helaman 14:2). In the words of King Benjamin, "Whosoever doeth this shall be found at the right hand of God, for he shall know the name by which he is called; for he shall be called by the name of Christ" (Mosiah 5:9).

Thus, those who exercise faith in the sacred name of Jesus Christ and repent of their sins and enter into his covenant and keep his commandments (see Mosiah 5:8) can lay claim on the atoning sacrifice of Jesus Christ. Those who do so will be called by his name at the last day.

When the Savior taught the Nephites following his resurrection, he referred to the scriptural statement that "ye must take upon you the name of Christ." He explained, "For by this name shall ye be called at the last day; And whoso taketh upon him my name, and endureth to the end, the same shall be saved at the last day" (3 Nephi 27:5-6). That same teaching is repeated in a modern revelation, which adds the caution that "if they know not the name by which they are called, they cannot have place in the kingdom of my Father" (D&C 18:25; see also Alma 5:38).

The Book of Mormon explains the significance of being called by the name of Jesus Christ. When the Savior showed his spirit body to the brother of Jared, he introduced himself as the Father and the Son, declaring that through his redeeming sacrifice all mankind

who believed on his name should have life eternal through him, "and they shall become my sons and my daughters" (Ether 3:14). Abinadi said of those who believed in the Lord and looked to him for a remission of their sins "that these are his seed, or they are heirs of the kingdom of God" (Mosiah 15:11). He continued this explanation as follows:

"For these are they whose sins he has borne; these are they for whom he has died, to redeem them from their transgressions. And now, are they not his seed?" (Mosiah 15:12).

Speaking through the prophet Alma, the Lord explained the significance of this relationship: "For behold, in my name are they called; and if they know me they shall come forth, and shall have a place eternally at my right hand" (Mosiah 26:24).

Faith, repentance, compliance with laws and ordinances

In these great scriptures from the Book of Mormon, we learn that those who are qualified by faith and repentance and compliance with the laws and ordinances of the gospel will have their sins borne by the Lord Jesus Christ. In spiritual and figurative terms they will become the sons and daughters of Christ, heirs to his kingdom. These are they who will be called by his name in the last day.

According to this meaning, when we witness our *willingness* to take upon us the name of Jesus Christ, we are signifying our commitment to do all that we can to achieve eternal life in the kingdom of our Father. We are expressing our candidacy—our determination to strive for—exaltation in the celestial kingdom.

Those who are found worthy to take upon them the name of Jesus Christ at the last day are described in the great revelations recorded in the ninety-third and seventy-sixth sections of the Doctrine and Covenants. Here the Savior revealed to Joseph Smith that in due time, if we keep the commandments of God, we can receive the

"fulness" of the Father (D&C 93:19-20). Here the Savior bears record that "all those who are begotten through me are partakers of the glory of the [Father], and are the church of the Firstborn" (D&C 93:22). "They are they into whose hands the Father has given all things. . . . Wherefore, as it is written, they are gods" who "shall dwell in the presence of God and his Christ forever and ever" (D&C 76:55, 58, 62). "And this is life eternal, that they might know thee the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent" (John 17:3; see also D&C 88:4-5). This is the ultimate significance of taking upon us the name of Jesus Christ.

When the priest offers the scriptural prayer on the bread at the sacramental table, he prays that all who partake may "witness" unto God, the Eternal Father, "that they are willing to take upon them the name of thy Son" (D&C 20:77, Moroni 4:3). This witness has several different meanings.

Candidacy for exaltation

It causes us to renew the covenant we made in the waters of baptism to take upon us the name of Jesus Christ and serve him to the end. We also take upon us his name as we publicly profess our belief in him, as we fulfill our obligations as members of his Church, and as we do the work of his kingdom.

But there is something beyond these familiar meanings, because what we witness is not that we *take* upon us his name but that we are *willing* to do so. In this sense, our witness relates to some future event or status whose attainment is not self-assumed, but depends on the authority or initiative of the Savior himself.

Scriptural references to the name of Jesus Christ often signify the authority of Jesus Christ. In that sense, our willingness to take upon us his name signifies our willingness to take upon us the authority of Jesus Christ in the sacred ordinances of the temple, and to receive the highest blessings available

through his authority when he chooses to confer them upon us.

Finally, our willingness to take upon us the name of Jesus Christ affirms our commitment to do all that we can to be counted among those whom he will choose to stand at his right hand and be called by his name at the last day. In this sacred sense, our witness that we are willing to take upon us the name of Jesus Christ constitutes our declaration of candidacy for exaltation in the celestial kingdom. Exaltation is eternal life, "the greatest of all the gifts of God" (D&C 14:7).

That is what we should ponder as we partake of the sacred emblems of the sacrament. As we do so, we glory in the mission of the risen Lord, who lived and taught and suffered and died and rose again that all mankind might have immortality *and eternal life*. Of this I testify in the sacred name of the Lord Jesus Christ, whose witness I am, amen.

President Benson

We have just heard from Elder Dallin H. Oaks, a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles.

Before hearing President Hinckley's concluding remarks, we should like to express appreciation and our sincere gratitude to the Tabernacle Choir, the Primary children's choir, and the Brigham Young University priesthood choir, and to their conductors and organists.

We thank our city officials for the cooperation given this conference, the Relief Society and Church Health Unit nurses who have been on hand to render service throughout the conference, and the ushers and interpreters.

We express appreciation to the local and national press representatives for the coverage given to the conference and to the owners and managers of the many radio and television stations and cable systems who have given public service time to carry sessions of this conference to many countries.

We shall now be pleased to listen to President Gordon B. Hinckley, Second Counselor in the First Presidency, who will be the concluding speaker of the conference, after which the Tabernacle Choir will sing "Testimony."

The benediction will be offered by Elder Robert L. Backman, a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

This conference will then stand adjourned for six months.

President Gordon B. Hinckley

You've heard very much from me in this conference. I think I would like to take the liberty of asking Brother [Hans B.] Ringger, Brother [Waldo P.] Call, and Brother [Helio R.] Camargo to come quickly to the stand and each

take about two and a half minutes so that you won't have to wait six months to see them and hear them. Three good men and true, who we have sustained as members of the First Quorum of the Seventy at this conference.

Elder Hans B. Ringger

Need for friends

Elder Packer taught us two days ago that in the early years of the Church the Saints would sometimes get a letter from "Box B." A letter from Box B meant you were getting a calling without being interviewed first. Presidents of the Church called members on missions with no warning beforehand. I feel the same way today.

It's a long way from Switzerland to this stand in Salt Lake City. I had to cross many borders. I had to ask for a visa, for permission to enter this country. But I found out that wherever I had to cross a border or had to talk with people, the people were friendly. That's exactly what I need in my assignment—friends. I have some sitting behind me. I have some sitting before me.

Answers will come

I'm really happy to be here and to serve. I don't know at the moment all the questions I will be asked or how I will find solutions for them. But I know that I will get an answer when I work on it and pray about it. If I do that, I know I will be blessed in all I do.

I am very thankful for my priesthood leaders, my parents, my sisters, my brethren, my teachers in Sunday School—all who have given me the strength to fulfill the assignments I get in my life. Hopefully, I can serve so that our Lord will be pleased. I am very thankful to the First Presidency for this privilege—for calling me to be a General Authority. I leave you my testimony that I know that our Lord lives, that Jesus is the Christ, and that Joseph Smith is a true prophet. This I say in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

Elder Waldo P. Call

Love and gratitude

My dear brothers and sisters, this is, as our missionaries would say, an

awesome situation. At this time, I want to thank my parents for the good example they set for me. There was one time in my life—and my mother, who

I imagine might be listening, doesn't know this—when the love I knew she had for me saved me. I knelt down one night to pray, as she had taught me. I was about to throw away everything that I had. As I started praying, I started thinking of her and of the love that she had for me. As I cried and prayed—and it took most of the night—I was so grateful that I knew that she loved me.

I am grateful for my wife. Throughout the many years we have been together, I have known that she has loved me. It is because of this love I have felt for my family, and they have felt for me, that I am here today.

I am grateful for President Kimball. I was watching some young

people sitting in front of me as we were singing "We Thank Thee, O God, for a Prophet" (*Hymns*, no. 196), and I imagine they would have liked to have come up and sit beside President Kimball where I sat just now.

Testimony

I know that this is the work of the Lord. I know that he lives. I know this. I know that these men, the First Presidency and the Quorum of the Twelve, are prophets and Apostles, seers and revelators, and if we will follow them, we will have eternal life. I say this in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

Elder Helio da Rocha Camargo

The Lord is in charge

My dear brothers and sisters, you cannot even imagine how I feel now in front of this huge and wonderful congregation of Saints, called to speak in this historical tabernacle. I don't know how my legs support my body now; this is an experience I never wanted to have.

When President Hinckley called me and asked me to accept this calling, there came to my mind the remembrance of a time in the history of the people of God, Israel, when they had to face their enemies. They assembled a huge army of strong soldiers and they presented themselves in front of the Lord to go to battle, and the Lord didn't accept this army. He reduced it, and he reduced it again and again until only three hundred people were left. And with this ridiculous army he defeated the enemy and destroyed the enemies of his people.

This is the way I feel about my calling in this position. The Lord chose

to put me in this position, using my weakness and my inability so that he could prove that he is God, he is the Lord, he is in charge. Even using my poor and broken English, he can do his work. It is because I believe this—I know this, I know that he lives, he is in charge, as I told President Hinckley—that I accept this calling in humility, but in certainty that the Lord is with me. He leads, he governs, and this is his kingdom.

Plan for happiness

I know that the Lord lives. I know that President Kimball is a prophet—oh, I know that! I could tell you some stories, but the time is not enough now. I know that I am a child of God, and that this gospel is the plan for the happiness of all the children of God in this world, and this I say in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Gordon B. Hinckley

I am sure that was time well-spent. I wish we might have heard from these Brethren [Elders Ringger, Call, and Camargo] at greater length. They are three wonderful men, and their very presence here this day is to me a testimony of the great power and the divinity of this work.

Angel Moroni's visit to Joseph Smith

I love to read of the visit of Moroni to the boy Joseph Smith—that night when he was only a youth, when a messenger clothed in white appeared before him in his bedroom. He was a farm boy, with very little in the way of formal education. But he had received a vision three years earlier, the like of which no man in his generation—or in any generation since—has received, when God the Eternal Father and the resurrected Lord had appeared to him.

Now the angel Moroni came, and according to the Prophet's testimony, "said unto me that he was a messenger sent from the presence of God to me, and that his name was Moroni; that God had a work for me to do; and that my name should be had for good and evil among all nations, kindreds, and tongues, or that it should be both good and evil spoken of among all people" (Joseph Smith—History 1:33).

Three Brethren, three lands

Brother Ringger comes from Switzerland. His grandmother was touched by the missionaries a long, long time ago. His father was a man of great faith, a patriarch in the midst of his people, in a very literal way. Brother Hans Ringger has been a stake president among his people and a Regional Representative. He is a man of faith. His English may not be as polished as perhaps yours is. But there burns in his heart a deep, flaming conviction of the truth of this work. By

profession, he is a distinguished architect in his native land. He has just retired as a full colonel from the Swiss Army. When I talked with him the other day about his leaving his business and consecrating himself to the work of the Lord and what it would entail, I looked into his strong face, and the tears began to well just a little. Then he said, "Of course, of course. If that's what the Lord wishes, that's what I want to do."

It was so with Brother Call, who was born in Mexico and reared in Mexico—in that land where the teaching of the gospel has been so fruitful, where there are now some three hundred thousand members of the Church who speak that beautiful language known as Spanish.

It was so with Brother Camargo, who came within a few hours after I had talked with him on the phone—just picked up his things and came, without ever a question, who speaks the tongue of Brazil—Portuguese—in that tremendous nation of South America.

Three lands! "God had a work for me to do; . . . my name should be had for good and evil among all nations, kindreds, and tongues, . . . it should be both good and evil spoken of among all people." These are but representatives of this marvelous, miraculous thing, which we are witnessing in our time, of the spread of the restored gospel across the earth for the blessing of our Father's children wherever they may be found.

The Holy Spirit and faith

Brothers and sisters, the time has come to conclude the conference. We now leave for our homes. May we take with us something of the light of inspiration which we have gained here. Every one of us should be the better for having been here. May we put renewed energy into that which lies ahead of us.

When I was a boy, we frequently sang in Sunday School:

"Put your shoulder to the wheel;
push along;
Do your duty with a heart full of
song.
We all have work; let no one
shirk;
Put your shoulder to the wheel."
(*Hymns*, no. 206.)

God bless you, my beloved associates, that his Holy Spirit may abide in your hearts, that his Holy Spirit may dwell in your homes, that faith will

grow at your hearthsides among those you love most, and that your influence for good may be felt among all with whom you associate, I humbly pray as I leave with you my witness and testimony of the divinity of the work, and in the authority of the holy priesthood in me vested, invoke the blessings of heaven upon you. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

The choir sang "Testimony."

Elder Robert L. Backman offered the benediction.

SALT LAKE TABERNACLE CHOIR AND ORGAN BROADCAST

The following broadcast, announced by J. Spencer Kinard and originating with KSL Radio and Television, Salt Lake City, Utah, was presented from 9:30 to 10:00 A.M. on Sunday, April 7, 1985, through the courtesy of the Columbia Broadcasting System's network throughout the United States, parts of Canada, and through other facilities to several points overseas:

Announcer: Once more we welcome you within these walls with Music and the Spoken Word from the crossroads of the West.

CBS and its affiliated stations bring you at this hour the Mormon Tabernacle Choir from Temple Square in Salt Lake City, with Jerold Ottley conducting the choir, John Longhurst, Tabernacle organist, and the Spoken Word given by Spencer Kinard.

(Organ: Musical introduction to *Rabboni*—Manookin)

Announcer: With soloists JoAnn Ottley, Clayne Robison, Douglas Keeler, and Wilford Whittaker, the Tabernacle Choir presents the broadcast premiere of music from a new

Easter cantata by Robert Manookin, entitled *Rabboni*, the name used in the Gospel of John to address Christ.

After Jesus had been crucified, Joseph of Arimathea besought Pilate that he might take the body away, and Pilate gave him leave. In the night, Joseph and Nicodemus wound the body in linen clothes and myrrh and aloes, as was the manner of the day.

Now in the place where He was crucified, there was a garden with a new sepulchre in which they laid Jesus.

And the women followed after and beheld the sepulchre and how His body was laid.

And they prepared spices and ointments, and rested the Sabbath day. And in the end of the Sabbath, very early in the morning, they came unto the sepulchre bringing the spices which they had prepared.

(Women: "Bring Aloes and Myrrh"—Manookin)

Announcer: Very early in the morning of the first day of the week cometh Mary Magdalene unto the sepulchre, and seeth that the stone was rolled away.

(Choir: "Awake and Sing!"—Manookin)

Announcer: But Mary stood without at the sepulchre weeping; and as she wept she looked into the sepulchre, and seeth two angels in white sitting where the body of Jesus had lain, and they say unto her . . .

(Soloists: "Woman, Why Weepst Thou?"—Manookin)

(Soloist without announcement: "Jesus of Nazareth"—Manookin)

(Men without announcement: "Why Seek Ye the Living among the Dead"—Manookin)

Announcer: And she turned herself back and saw Jesus standing, and knew not that it was Jesus, but supposed Him to be the gardener.

(Soloist: "Rabboni"—Manookin)

(Soloist without announcement: "Remember How I Spake unto You"—Manookin)

(Choir and soloists without announcement: "Awake and Sing!"—Manookin)

Announcer: For behold, the Lord your Redeemer suffered death in the flesh; wherefore He suffered the pain of all men, that all men might repent and come unto him. And he hath risen again from the dead, that he might bring all

men unto him. . . . And how great is his joy . . .

(Choir: "Let Your Hearts Rejoice"—Manookin)

Announcer: The Tabernacle Choir has presented the broadcast premiere of the Easter cantata *Rabboni* by Robert Manookin. This work was commissioned by the Milton A. Barlow Endowment for Music Composition. The text, based on scripture, was prepared by Jean L. Kaberry and Ted Gibbons.

Announcer: Again we leave you from within the shadows of the everlasting hills. May peace be with you this day . . . and always.

Announcer on radio: This concludes the two-thousand, nine-hundred, third performance continuing the fifty-sixth year of this traditional broadcast from the Mormon Tabernacle on Temple Square, brought to you by CBS and its affiliated stations, originating with Station KSL in Salt Lake City, Utah.

Jerold Otley conducted the choir, John Longhurst was at the organ, the Spoken Word was given by Spencer Kinard.

In another seven days at this same hour, Music and the Spoken Word will be heard again from the crossroads of the West.

This is the CBS Radio Network.

SUMMARY OF CONFERENCE MUSIC

The Tabernacle Choir furnished the choral numbers for the Saturday morning, Sunday morning, and Sunday afternoon sessions of the conference with Jerold Otley and Donald Ripplinger conducting.

The music for the Saturday afternoon session was provided by a Primary children's choir from the Jordan Utah Region directed by Sister Susan Kenney.

At the general priesthood meeting a priesthood choir from Brigham

Young University under the direction of Ronald Staheli and Mack Wilberg furnished the music.

Prelude, postlude, and interlude music and accompaniments on the Tabernacle organ throughout the conference sessions were played by Robert Cundick, John Longhurst, and Clay Christiansen, Tabernacle organists.

Francis M. Gibbons
Clerk of the Conference

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